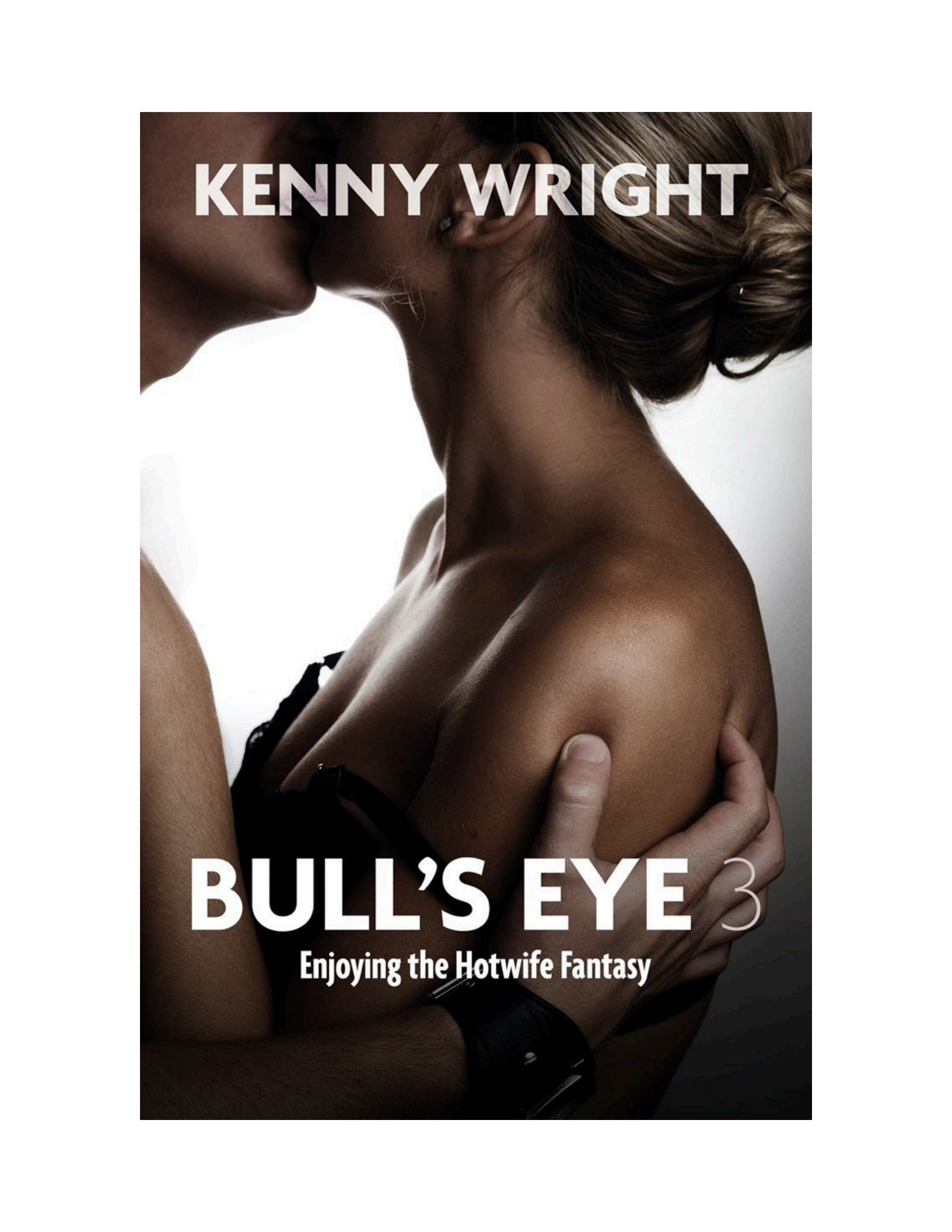
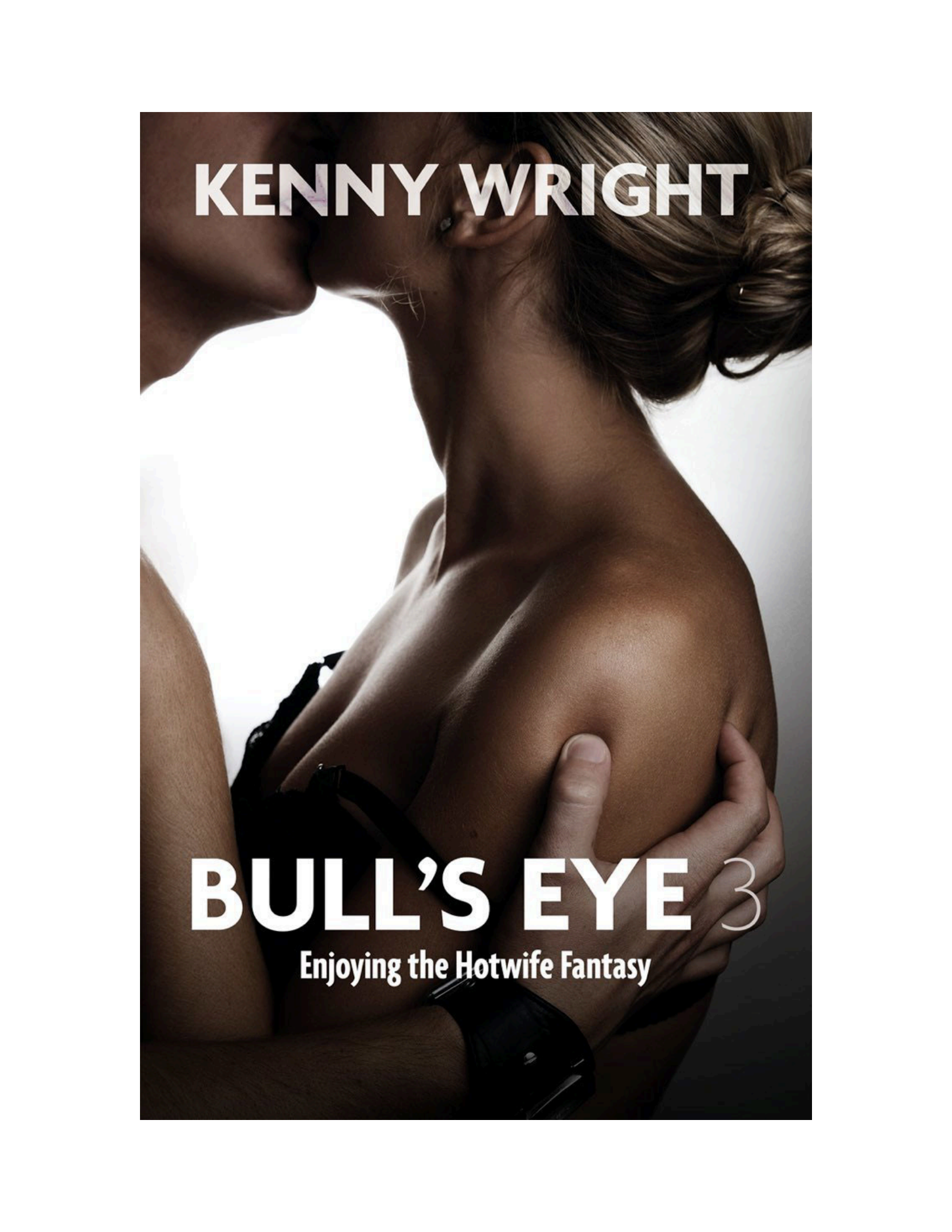




KENNY WRIGHT

BULL'S EYE 3

Enjoying the Hotwife Fantasy



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Preface

Here's where I tell you that if you haven't read the first two books in this series (Discovering the Hotwife Fantasy and Exploring the Hotwife Fantasy), I'd recommend you go back and pick them up. You'll understand the characters and what's going on a lot more.

The only other thing I'll lead with is that this particular book features a made-up dating app called DeBauch, and I want to give credit to Arnica Butler, who created it for her excellent hotwife book, Body of Research: An Experiment In Hotwifing. Look it up!

Enjoy book three. There are two more after this, so keep watching my blog at kennywriter.com for news on those.

My Role

My arms burn. I'm covered in sweat again. But I don't stop thrusting. Her body is a work of art, slender and pale and tight. I stand on the edge of the bed, her hips in my hand, staring at her small ass as I pound her doggystyle and she cries out another wild orgasm.

Her long blond hair is damp, darkened by sweat. By our long night together. I've already made her come countless times. I plan on countless more.

"Yes, James! Oh, yes, right... rightthere!" Her voice is even huskier than when we met, choked with lust and a night of screams. "Baby, it feels so good. So—uh—so big!"

I think she's talking to me, but when I look down at her, she's looking at her husband, sitting in the corner of the room, watching us. He's got his cock out—an average looking thing that's fiercely erect—and is stroking himself slowly, as if desperately trying to hold back his orgasm, yet unable to resist touching it.

Our eyes meet. He looks away, face flush. I grin and turn my attention back to his wife. I pull out of her, as if to show him just how much bigger my condom-wrapped cock is. His wife whines beneath me, complaining.

"On your back," I order. "I want to watch you come."

The blonde obeys, flipping onto her back, one thigh flopping open as she lifts her other leg along my body, red-painted toes trailing across my chest. "You're so hot," she says, almost laughing to herself.

I reply with an appreciative sweep of what she has to offer. Her tits are small, perky, capped with cherry colored nipples. She nibbles on the tip of her index finger as I check her out. I can't help but think about another blonde giving me that same simmering look. Does she also keep a narrow landing strip above her slit to prove that she's a natural blonde? Is she even a natural blonde?

"Yeah, I know I'm hot, too," the blonde says. She hooks her toes behind my neck and pulls me down to her. I grab her ankle, taking control. Feed my cock back into her, and once again, away we go.

I don't know this couple. We met for the first—and probably the last—time tonight. It's been less than a week since I broke things off with Eleanor, so I'm giving myself a pass. A rebound.

"He's fucking me so good, babe! I love that big, hard dick."

They've done this before, these two—I'm not the first man that they've arranged to meet at a hotel bar and then invited up to their hotel room. I'm not the first man to fuck her so good as she taunts her husband with my size. But I'll be damned if I'm not the best. I'm competitive that way.

I lift myself to my knees and roll my shoulders back so she can get a good look at me. I'm gym-hewn, a block of rippling muscle that looks even better glistening with sweat. She takes me all in, from my chest to my clean-shaven, squared-off jaw to my dark hair and darker eyes. Her breath catches as I hold her gaze.

"Ready to get really fucked?"

She manages a laugh. "Okay," she says skeptically.

I'm fine with that. Just puts more pressure on, and I'm a fucking savant under pressure. I pull her into me, lifting her pert ass up off the mattress. Sliding a hand beneath, I grab a fistful of asscheek and squeeze. I lick my thumb, getting it nice and moist, and press it down against her clit.

She jerks forward, shuddering against my hand. “Play with your tits,” I tell her. “Show me how you like it.”

She cups her small swells, her fingers finding her nipples and pinching down until they turn red and she has to grit her teeth. So she likes it rough, I can give her rough.

I grab her leg, folding it over until her knees touched and her hips were twisted onto the side. It made her pussy even tighter, and made it easier to slap her pert little ass.

SLAP!

“Oh, fuck!” she cries. She arches her shoulder blades into the bed as I spank her and fuck her. “Fuck me!”

“You’re a bad little slut, aren’t you?”

“Yes!”

“You like fucking a strange cock.”

“Ngh, yes!”

I glance at her husband and grin. When this adventure began, he was an equal participant. I watch him shrink beneath my gaze. I watch the power shift, feel it coursing through me.

I’m the bull. I’m their bull. And I’m ready to fucking charge.



I go home, but don’t go to bed, even though it’s 2 am on a Friday morning. I’m too amped up to sleep. After brushing my teeth and taking out my contacts, I settle into the bed and open my favorite new “dating” app.

The internet is a beautiful thing when it comes to deviant lifestyles. In addition to all the forums and message boards and subreddits, there are full blown services. Most catered to swingers—or singles looking for a good time. Adult Friend Finder. SLS. Tinder. Ashley Madison. Then there was DeBauch, which is basically a combination of the last two.

I stumbled upon DeBauch a month ago, when I was doing my research into this fantasy, and it's exactly what I need now—a discreet service designed to help married people hook up with other men and women. According to the message boards, it's also become the go-to place for hotwives and cuckolds to find their bulls.

The app handles all the messaging, it's as anonymous as the user wants to make it, and the profile and matching engine is top notch. If I want blondes, I get blondes. If I am interested in dominant sex with a submissive partner, that's who I get. If I want first-timers—and I most certainly do—there's a filter for that, too.

The sheer number of profiles out there is overwhelming. I imagine many are fake, but some—like the blonde tonight—are as authentic as I need them to be.

It's been a week since I broke things off with the Hellers. A week since the board left and we've gone into full prep for the upcoming Global Philanthropy Conference. A week since I made the stupid mistake of getting drunk and kissing Manhattan. Feels like ages ago, and yet I can still feel her lips on mine as the unmistakable scent of her fills my world.

Even DeBauch betrays my desires. I always start with a fresh search, and I always end up filtering it down to blonde professionals in their thirties looking for single men. It's the same search I used to find the woman tonight, and the one from last Tuesday.

They've all been fun, but as the afterglow of good, sweaty sex cools and fades around me, I have to admit that none of them are—

“Careful now,” I say aloud, stopping that thought before I can settle on a name. Whether I'm pining for Eleanor Heller, my first hotwife, or Heather

Kingsley-Fletcher—aka Manhattan—the woman who introduced me to the hotwife world in the first place, it doesn't matter. Both women are my past. I need a new present.

I scroll down, seeing Manhattan in every potential date. It's neurotic. It's not like me to be so fixated. It's not me to measure each potential date against a woman who I can never truly have. But I do. I look until I find someone who looks just like her. So much like her that—

“It couldn't be...”

I'm pretty sure this is just the late night and my mind playing a trick on me. This far down the list, the profiles haven't been updated in a while and most are inactive. As soon as I click on the thumbnail and that profile pic gets larger, I know that it is. Even veiled behind the sweep of her golden hair, her eyes downcast, most of her face obscured, I'd recognize that crooked smile anywhere.

The name, though, is the real giveaway. “Mandy,” short for my nickname for her, “Manhattan.” It's a cute inside joke that no one but the two of us would get, just as my name on here is “Jameson,” as in “Jameson whiskey,” her nickname for me.

I tap on her profile, expanding the photo to the full size of the screen, and am even more certain that it's her. The nose is right. Her Nordic complexion is the kind of pale that tans well. And the single dimple on her right cheek is one I've often thought about running my thumb across.

There are five other pictures in her gallery, small little thumbnails that hold so much promise. I skim her profile first, reading all the little details that confirm that “Mandy” is “Manhattan” is “Heather Kingsley-Fletcher.” Blue eyes. Blond hair. 5'7” with a “slender” body type. It states that she's in the 26 - 34 age range, is married and has no children.

I read her bio:

You have to earn me. You have to woo me. You have to seduce me. You need to make me laugh before you hear me moan. You need to make me like you before I fuck you.

And what I like is a man who is confident, but not cocky. I want an experienced man, comfortable talking to beautiful women—because that's all we'll be doing at first. If you're lucky, I'll buy you a drink on our first date...but nothing more.

What I'm not looking for is a new husband. I have one of those and I'm not looking to replace him. He knows about this profile, and he'll know about you. If that is a problem, then you're wasting your time.

I want a spark, a connection. I want to be seduced. If you're up for the challenge, you won't regret it.

It makes me smile. This is so her. Makes me think about our mutual friend, Mason Coles, who said not too long ago that she was probably worth it.

I tap on the first image in her gallery. Like her profile image, it doesn't show her face, the frame cutting off just beneath her pert nose. I recognize the heather-gray dress from the night we first met, although here, in these photos with what clearly looks like a hotel room behind it, it looks a lot sexier—short and tight enough to show off her narrow waist and the flare of her hips and tits. I can practically smell her vanilla scent.

The second picture is taken from behind, the camera capturing how good her ass looks and how long and shapely her legs are.

It transports me back to a time when things were so much simpler—before the scandal, before becoming the bull. Before Manhattan.

I swipe on to the next photo before I got caught in that rabbit hole. It's easy to move on when I see her in this dress—a tiny, red bodycon mini dress that barely reaches her upper thighs. It's somehow both exactly wrong for the

woman I know, and exactly right for the body she has. It's scooped low in the front, showing off the swells of her well-formed breasts.

Her blond hair was lighter than I'm used to, and her usually pale skin carries the warm tan that I always suspected she was capable of. Delicious.

The next photo in the gallery continues to prove that she could hold a tan. This one was taken from a beach trip, with the ocean in the background and those long legs stretched out before her in the fore, tanned and glistening. Her feet are sandy, her toenails painted red.

It's all a tease for the last photo—Manhattan in a bikini, standing before that same ocean and with that same, crooked smile just beneath the edge of the frame. I wonder if she's rolling her eyes at her husband, Joshua, who must be behind the camera. There's nothing to wonder about with the rest of her, though, that's all laid bare in her blue, halter-style string bikini—her flat abs, her fantastic breasts, the way her skin can hold a tan that contrasts with the sun-kissed golden hair that sweeps over one shoulder. We may be friends, but that doesn't stop me from ogling.

There's been no activity in awhile—not since the account was set up, which appears to be around the time we first met. I wonder about that, but the hour is so late and fatigue is finally catching up to me.

Along the bottom of the profile are the action buttons: Flirt and Heart. Hearts are public, like Facebook Likes. Hitting Flirt goes beyond that. It indicates that you want to get together. My thumb hovers over the Flirt button and the silly kissing lips icon.

We have a complicated relationship. We first met at a bar well before she entered my life professionally. She was there, playing a game with her husband that I now know is fairly common in this new world of cuckolds and hotwives—she pretended to be single, flirting with guys as her husband watched from afar. Nothing happened between us beyond some fun banter, but it was my introduction to this fantasy and one of the reasons I'm where I am now, thumbing through an app designed to connect bulls with hotwives.

Things were fun between us, light and platonic and... casual. Until the kiss. Now I didn't know where we were at. Pretending to be friends? Friends once again?

I don't like to dwell, so I haven't been. Not much. Still, I miss the banter and what we had.

"You're an idiot," I groan. "And you're overthinking it."

I hit Flirt, just for kicks. Because that's what Manhattan and I do—things for kicks. We're a relationship founded on a flirty joke, so saying, "I want to fuck you" in an app as ridiculous as this one tracks with me.

I nearly close the app when another profile catches my eye, in the "Similar profiles to Mandy" section.

She's blonde, too, and more intriguing, she's a first-timer. "Brandi". I scan her profile, hit Flirt on it before I give it a second thought, and close down the app. Time for bed.

Interesting

The next morning—or later on the same Friday morning—calls for coffee. Turns out that having crazy sex late into the night, then getting up for work isn't as easy as it was when I was in my twenties. Now that I have a whole office looking up at me as the acting director, it's harder to hide.

I hit up Aroma House, best coffee shop in the city and now a place laden with memories of Manhattan. I haven't seen the public relations professional since last Friday at the Starlight Lounge. I can still remember her lips on mine and how I want to feel them again—even though I now know I was just being used to get to her husband.

I've thought about it a lot since then, and I'm at peace with it. Like the couple last night, I know the part I'm meant to play in these couple's stories, and there's something freeing about that. I don't have to worry about feelings. I don't have to think long term. I'm just there to have fun and push as many buttons as I can as I do.

She's there, of course. She's always there, waiting at the serving station for her early morning latte. Heather Kingsley-Fletcher, the woman I call "Manhattan" because I need to remind myself she's a friend and nothing more.

She looks good, just as she always looks good. It's particularly hot in DC today, which means Heather wears a particularly short dress today. The blue and white seersucker shirt dress is belted at the waist and paired with cork-heeled sandals, she looks like a New England yacht wife.

I take in her bare arms and the curve of her calves before waving at her and calling her attention away from her phone.

“Fancy seeing you here,” I say.

Her smile feels like a sunrise as it washes over me. It’s been less than a week since I saw her, but it feels like an age. I repress the sudden urge to hug her, which is weird because I’m not normally a hugger. She puts the phone into her purse.

“Hey there, Jameson.” Her whole face lights up.

“So you got my message.”

“Mmhhh. ‘Lives up to the photos. We had an amazing time last night...’” She pauses, and I get the strong sense that she’s making fun of me. “...‘and in the morning.’ Did you write that?”

Ah, that was my Wednesday adventure. I shrug. “What can I say, I’m a fun guy.”

Manhattan snorts. “Oh, right. For a second I forgot who I was talking to.”

It’s nice that our kiss didn’t fester between us. It was just a kiss. Nothing more. We could move on with our lives, get back to the bantering.

“So you’re on... that site,” I say, not wanting to say the ridiculous name of the app I’m using. “That’s interesting.”

“Is it though? Joshua found out about it—I swear it was set up by a man—and showed it to me. I set up a profile to tease him on his birthday a little while back. He gets a kick out of all the attention I get.”

“So you never respond to anyone?” I ask, collecting the small cup.

“Haven’t found anyone worth responding to.”

I pull out my phone, load up DeBauch. Navigate to her profile, which of course I’ve starred. “If you’re lucky, I’ll buy you a drink on our first

date...but nothing more,” her profile reads. It makes me laugh.

“What are you doing?” she asks, peering over my shoulder at my phone.

I click the direct message link—because of course an app that facilitates cheating spouses supports private messages. “Hey now, this is private,” I tell her, turning away as I type my message before I can stop myself.

JAMESON: You seem like a lot of work, but then I saw that you were offering free drinks. I’m a real sucker for free drinks.

Her phone doesn’t get an alert. I wonder if she even has it loaded on there.

“You might want to check your messages on DeBauch. Something tells me you’ve got a new one.”

“Paul?” the barista calls out, setting my drink on the counter. “Espresso for Paul?”

She checks her phone as I retrieve my drink, laughing. “You know Joshua also has access to this account, don’t you?”

“No secrets between you two.” I hope that doesn’t sound as bitter to her as it is to me.

She glances up at me and for a second, I figure she’s going to call me on it. I prepare a denial. Instead, she thumbs a response to me.

MANDY: So you’re a lazy alcoholic. Not really putting your best foot forward there. But hey, you did make me laugh.

Looking up at me, those blue eyes say, Your move. I'm game.

JAMESON: If you're hunting for a dick pic from me, then you're out of luck. I'm a gentleman.

Now she really does laugh, but she responds through the app.

MANDY: Says the guy with a bio that features the line, "If size matters, then don't worry, I'll matter a whole lot to you."

I actually flush at that. I definitely wrote that with the idea that no one I knew would ever read it—especially not Manhattan. Still, Jameson is my persona. Need to stay true to it.

JAMESON: I was talking about the size of my heart and my generosity. Sorry your mind's in the gutter.

She laughs even louder. "Really?"

"There are many layers to me," I say.

She snorts. Types a response because she can't let me have the last word.

MANDY: You're absolutely right. There are definitely not enough photos of you flexing shirtless for my tastes. Dealbreaker.

“Hey, I don’t have any photos of me flexing shirtless.”

She spins on her heels, heading for the door. “Maybe you should.”

That evening, at home, rather than go out to meet up with someone new and fun, I spend an unspeakable amount of time posing in front of the mirror with my shirt off, trying to nail a photo that straddles the line between campy beefcake and GQ. It may be a joke, but I still need to look good.

When I send it to her, I get no response.

Brandi and Andy

“You actually came,” I say, rising to meet Manhattan as she enters the bar. She wears a pair of white pants with pale pinstripes and a sleeveless white blouse. Her hair is still up from what must have been a long day at the office.

“I’m a woman of my word.” I wonder if it’s appropriate to hug her, decide that it’s not, and repress the urge to do it anyway. “Besides, I have to admit that I’m curious how this whole thing works.”

‘This whole thing’ being a DeBauch date that I’ve set up. I invited her along ostensibly “for research.” If she wanted to play this game with her husband, it was a good idea to know how it worked. It’s also just nice to have an accomplice in it all, and there’s literally no one else who could fit that role in my life right now.

She looks around the bar. “So tell me about this couple we’re meeting.”

We. I like the sound of that.

“According to their profile, this is their first time doing this.”

“So skeptical.”

I shrug. “Their names are ‘Brandi’ and ‘Andy’, so...”

She laughs delightedly. “So how does this work?”

“You mean being a bull? I have sex with the wife while her husband watches.”

I want to make her blush. She doesn't even get a shade pink. "No, not that. I mean, like, tonight. You just meet up and go back to a... what? A hotel room?"

"Ah, trying to figure out what to tell your husband happened tonight?" I do a slow walk across her body. It starts as a joke, and end it when it feels like it's not. "With a girl like you, I'd make sure I had a hotel room."

She covers her mouth and laughs at me.

"With these two, it's just a meet-and-greet. No pressure for anyone to do anything. If there's chemistry, then we'll set up another date."

"Look at you being patient."

I look her in her pretty, blue eyes. "It's the anticipation that makes this really fun."

This, of all things, brings out the first tints of red in her sculpted cheekbones. She turns away from me and waves at the bartender. "He'll have a Jameson on the rocks, and I'll take a club soda with lime."

"Oh, come on. Don't make me drink alone."

She laughs. "Fine. Bring me a Manhattan, too."

"Start a tab?" the bartender asks.

I turn to Manhattan and raise my brows. She laughs and looks at me as if to say, You're an idiot, without actually saying it. I like that we have that kind of silent communication. It's not a language I normally share with other women.

She hands the bartender her card. "Sure. Joshua will appreciate seeing this on the credit card bill."

"Ah, so I'm just a pawn."

“Of course you are,” she says, the same way she’d ask a dog, “Who’s a good dog.”

Whatever. “So I took your advice and ended things with Elie.”

“I know.” She flares her eyes at her own mystery. “‘But how?’ you’re wondering.”

Until two weekends ago, I had been having an affair with Eleanor Heller, our new president of the board of trustees and one of the Dawning Foundation’s most notable donors. No one knew about it except for her husband, Ronald Heller, who got off on being cuckolded, and Manhattan, who figured it out. But as far as I knew, she never told Eleanor that she knew.

“Okay, I’ll bite. How do you know that?”

“Yeah, interesting story.” She pauses. “She told me.”

“You two are BFFs?”

“No, not quite. She, um, came to my office on... Tuesday? I don’t know. Last week was a blur. She asked me if we were sleeping together. You and me.”

I wince.

“She wanted to know if I was the reason you broke things off with her.” There’s an insulting amount of skepticism in that statement.

“Did she make a scene?”

“Eleanor?” Manhattan snorts. “Of course not. She’s too polite to start a cat fight.”

“What did you tell her?”

“I told her that we weren’t fucking.” Again, that disbelieving laugh. “But I also told her it was me who advised you to break things off.”

My turn to sound incredulous. “You took the blame?” Before I could let her gain the upper hand, though, I added, “So you just want me for yourself, eh?”

“Totally. That’s why I’m here, killing time with you before your next booty call.”

That’s actually why I’m sitting here on a Tuesday night having a drink with Manhattan. I convinced her to come along and see how a DeBauch meet-and-greet goes down. I invited her along for “research,” and when that approach didn’t work, I told her she owed me a drink.

“For you, I’d happily bail on this couple. But you need to promise me that you’re worth it.”

“Oh, I’m worth it. But you’ll never know.”

The bartender comes by, discreetly setting our drinks down. His smile tells me that he heard quite a bit. Wonder what he thinks the nature of our relationship is.

“Anyway, the really wild turn of events is that we’re now friends.”

“You and Elie?” I can see her mind chewing on the nickname. “Yes, me and Elie. She has no one to talk to about this, except her husband, but that’s like trying to talk to an alcoholic about your favorite cocktails.”

“You tell her about Joshua?”

“I did. Guess I didn’t have anyone to talk to about this, either.”

“Now I’m hurt.”

“You register that emotion?” she teases. “Maybe I needed someone to talk to who didn’t want to get into my pants.”

I shake my head. “Two things. First, I’ve told you, you’re too much work. Second, what makes you think Elie’s not trying to get into your pants?”

Pretty sure she could give me a run for my money when it comes to slut-factor.”

“Weren’t you the one who corrupted her?”

“More like I was in the right place at the right time. That side of her was coming out at some point.” She was a wallflower when I met her at the Dawning gala, but she and her husband, Ronald, were also playing the game that night. If it wasn’t me, Mason Coles, a friendly rival, probably would have landed her.

“What?” Manhattan asks.

“Hmm?”

“You’re grinding your jaw. What are you thinking?”

This woman doesn’t miss much. “Nothing.” I clear my head. “Just wondering how badly I burned that bridge.”

“You think the bridge is burned?”

In the last week, I had a couple official conversations with Eleanor—she was technically my new boss. But we’d not mentioned our secret life, or how it ended. “I mean, it was kind of abrupt.”

Manhattan nods. “Sure was.”

“Hey now, you told me to do it! Said you’d drop me as a client—”

“Which I still plan on doing. After the Global Philanthropy Con. I’m too close to you guys—”

“Because you kissed me?”

“And anyway,” she says, ignoring me. “Don’t worry about ‘Elie.’ She’s also moved on.”

That catches me by surprise. “Already?”

“Says the guy meeting up with a couple on a site called ‘DeBauch’,” she says, throwing big, dramatic air-quotes around the app’s name.

“Touché.” I want to ask her more about Elie and what “moving on” means. I don’t. “So what does Joshua think you’re doing right now?”

“Meeting ‘Jameson’ for a drink.”

“And how did he take it?”

She smiles over the brim of her martini glass. “Excited, of course.”

“So this is kind of a big deal for you, right? Planning on meeting up with a guy for drinks?”

“You just want me to tell you that you’re a Big Deal.”

“Nah, I already know that.” I wink.

Her phone rumbles, and she uses it as an excuse to look away. To check the message.

“Joshua?”

She nods and types something back.

I resist the urge to ask her what she’s typing. She may not actually be meeting up with a bull, but I already know the questions—“how’s it going” or “he there yet” or “anything happen?”

She takes a picture of our drinks, side by side, then turns it to me. “Here, look at this.”

[Joshua]: Having fun?

[Heather]: So much fun.

[Joshua]: He’s not there yet, is he?

She answers with the photo of our glasses.

A response slides into view as I read.

[Joshua]: Send me some sexier photos later. You have my permission.

“Sounds like he wants it,” I say as she takes the phone back and reads.

“He does, but he really doesn’t.”

“You’re going to have fun tonight when you get home.”

Manhattan tosses her hair and responds to me the same way she did to Joshua. “So much fun.” I can hear the sarcasm. I wonder if that’s how Joshua read it.

“You know, I think you should do it. For real. Go for it and see what happens.”

“And I suppose you’re offering yourself up?” She regards her phone again, but doesn’t respond.

“No, not me.” Although it’s getting easier to admit that that’s what I really want. “Maybe after GPC when you drop me as a client.” It’s the joke that’s not really a joke.

She snorts.

“Try that app. Surely ‘Jameson’ isn’t the only one to lay a Flirt on you, or send you a message.”

“Only one I’ve responded to.”

“So respond to another. What’s the harm?”

She thinks about it, no doubt composing some witty retort, when I look and see the couple enter—my couple. He’s dressed much like me, like he’s come from work—suit without a tie. He’s stockier than I am, a little shorter, a little more stout, with receding hair and glasses that make him look older.

She's attractive, blond, more petite than Manhattan with a tight, little body, sheathed in a black dress that shows off her legs.

Manhattan sees my focus shift, but doesn't swivel around to look.

"They're here," I say. "Settling into a table."

"Show time."

She nods, turning to the bartender and holding her finger up. As she does this, she glances in the direction of the couple, taking them in out of the corner of her eye.

"She's cute." Her assessment is matter-of-fact, but when she looks back at me, she's all smiles. "You've got a thing for blondes."

"Don't read too much into it. I'm equal opportunity."

"A modern man," she says. The bartender comes over. "Now I'll take that club soda with lime."

"Staying?"

"For a little. Can't go home to Joshua just yet, and besides, I want to watch the master at work."

I tilt my head, cracking my neck like I'm about to enter the ring. "I'd ask you to wish me luck, but you know I don't need it."

Manhattan rolls her eyes. "Good luck anyway, stud."

Knowing that she's watching actually does make me feel more nervous than I would otherwise. I hop off the stool and approach the waiting couple, improbably named "Brandi" and "Andy." Brandi sees me first, a pleased smile spreading across her face as she glances up at me through her long, dark lashes. I know that look. This one's eager, and I wonder if I really am their first—maybe not hers.

"Hello, there," I say as the two rise. "Andy? Brandi?"

Andy looks nervous behind his glasses, unsure of whether to meet my eyes or look just past me. “Oh, hey,” he says, like he wasn’t actually expecting me to come here at all. “You’re Jameson?”

I wish Manhattan could have heard that I’m using her nickname for me. I almost look back at her, but don’t. “Call me James.”

Brandi rises. She’s taller than I originally thought, although a good four inches of that are in her heels, and the rest of her is still slender. Her voice, though, is smoky and deep. “Nice to meet you, James.”

With her pale skin and bright red lips, she reminds me of the delicacy of a Disney princess first, then of much naughtier things. I give her an appreciative once over, watching her body shiver with anticipation.

“Very nice to meet you, too, Brandi.”

We sit. A waitress takes my order—I go with a craft IPA this time, wanting to pace myself. Andy orders the same as me; his wife orders another glass of white. We chat about DeBauch at first, because it’s safe and a shared thing to make fun of.

“When Andy first told me about the app, I thought that he was making it up,” Brandi says, laughter on her face. “I mean, ‘DeBauch’? Really? Might as well call it, ‘let’s fuck’.”

I like her. She doesn’t pull her punches. She doesn’t hold back. Andy shifts, rankled, feeling the same defensiveness that I did when talking with Manhattan. He says, “That probably wouldn’t get past the app store approval committee, dear.”

Brandi puts her hand on her husband’s. “What if they used a star instead of a ‘u’?”

She’s teasing him, but he misses the joke and almost answers her question for real before stopping himself. I feel the tension between them. This isn’t a fantasy that he’s comfortable with—and one she seems to have more than

willingly embraced. We are supposed to only be meeting for a drink, but I sense it could lead to more tonight.

“So how long have you two been using it?” I ask, seeking to quell whatever is going on between them.

“Just a few weeks,” Brandi says. “You’re just the second guy we’ve met.”

“That’s a shame. I was hoping to be the first.” My eyes meet hers, which sparkle.

“You still can be the first for other things,” she says. “The other guy we met turned out to be ten years older than he claimed, and didn’t match his photo at all.”

“And what about me?”

Brandi lifts her hand from her husband’s and runs it across the back of mine. “Oh, James, you’re even better than I was expecting.” She watches her hand tickle the hairs along my wrist, then glances up at me. “But you know that, don’t you?”

She likes confidence. Luckily, I have more than enough. I smile at her, holding her gaze as I lift my hand and lace my fingers through hers. “So I’ve been told a few times.”

I can feel her shiver down her arm, where goosebumps form. “You’ve done this before?”

“With a couple? Yes, I’ve done it with a couple.”

Brandi licks her lips and glances nervously at her husband. They seem to exchange a whole conversation in that glance.

I look past them as they do, seeking out Manhattan. When I find her, though, my heart leaps. She’s not alone at the bar any longer. Next to her, leaning in between the seat that I was in and hers, was a young, twenty-something frat guy wearing a golf shirt and a pair of flip-flops. Chatting her up.

He says something. She puts a hand over her mouth, eyes wide, and releases a laugh. I cannot tell whether it's at whatever joke he's made, or at some ridiculous pick up line he's trying to use. Either way, I feel...jealous.

Brandi's entwined fingers pull away from mine, drawing my attention back to the couple. Where it should be. "So when you were with other couples..." She breaks off with a nervous sigh.

"Do the husbands watch?" I say. "Usually."

I don't tell them that I've only done it a couple times. They don't need to know that.

"And you don't... I mean, that's not weird?" asks Brandi.

I look at Andy. "I don't mind an audience, as long as it's just an audience."

Andy goes white. "Oh, no, I'm not like... I mean, I wouldn't—"

"Andy just wants to watch."

Where there's hesitation and nervousness in Andy, there's almost none with his pretty, blond wife.

"I can respect that," I say, and as I do, I can't help but look back toward Manhattan. She's still with Frat Boy, looking engrossed now in whatever he's telling her. Gone is the incredulity, that ironic amusement. The kick of jealousy is there like an uninvited guest who just won't go away, but this is fine. It's good. Maybe she'll fuck him and get that monkey off her back. It's time to start thinking about myself.

"And how about you, Brandi. Do you like being watched?"

"Mmm, sounds fun."

"My apartment's a five minute walk away. Want to move this party back there?" I look between the two of them, watch the deliberation. He's on the fence. She wants it, nodding slowly to her husband, coaxing him to her side.

I glance at Manhattan, who's once again alone. She meets my eyes and gives me a little wave, just her fingertips. I smile back at her.

When I look at the DeBauch couple, they've made up their mind. "Lead the way," Brandi says. "Andy will get the check."

Initiation

There's an electric high that comes with late nights in the city, with booze flowing through the veins and sex on the brain. It reminds me what it's like to be twenty again. It's why I will never leave the city, and why I'll never put a ring on my finger and give up this life.

Guiding a new couple through this charged and pulsing world intensifies all of it. The lights outside seem brighter. The smell of booze and cigarettes make me feel alive. I know this neighborhood. I've made this walk countless times. I'm the master of my domain here, and when Brandi links her arm in mine, I feel all the control bending in my direction.

"God, I haven't been in the city this late in ages," Brandi says. She feels the energy, too.

"Bet you used to come in a lot. To dance?"

I can sense her looking at her husband before she answers. There's a story there that I don't probe. "Once upon a time."

"You miss it."

She doesn't deny the statement.

"I know I'd love to watch you dance."

I love how this one blushes and giggles as she squeezes closer to me. "Maybe I'll let you take me out some time."

But not tonight. Tonight, we all know where this is headed.

“This is me,” I say, stopping before my apartment building. It’s just a block off the main drag, a three-story apartment building tucked between row houses. It’s close enough that you can still hear Friday night happening and feel the electricity radiating.

“You’re right in the middle of it,” Brandi says, impressed.

“Just where I like to be.” I buzz us in. “Come on. Let’s have some fun.”

I keep a clean apartment for just this reason—never know when I’ll get unexpected guests. My furniture is all mid century modern stuff—low-backed sofas, walnut tables and chairs, things I’ve cobbled together from Craigslist and yard sales and the things left over as my friends moved away.

I take it all in from their point of view—one used to a home filled with toddler toys, baby gates, managed chaos. I don’t know them or what their life is like, but I can see them comparing, taking it all in. They’re outside of their comfort zone, and things are finally getting real.

“What’ll you have to drink?” I ask, shutting the door behind us as quietly as I can. Even still, they look back, Andy scanning the locks like the door’s a prison cell. “I’ve got a bottle of white chilling.”

“Yes,” Brandi says in a rush. “That.”

She still wants this. She just needs some motivation. Time to see how ready Andy is. I step up to his wife, drinking in her petite frame and how blonde her hair is. It’s lighter than Manhattan’s—not that I’m comparing, straighter than my friend’s—again, not that I’m comparing.

“Andy,” I say without taking my eyes off of his wife. They’re soft and brown, a lovely contrast to her light features. “...the wine’s in the fridge. Glasses are in the cabinet to the left of it.”

I reach up and cup Brandi’s face, running my thumb across her parted lips. She gasps. Her skin is soft, warm from her perpetual blush.

I know her husband stands there, dumb struck. I know he's not doing as I've told him. That's fine...for now. This, he needs to watch. This, I want him to watch.

Pulling Brandi to me, she lifts up on her toes as I slide my hand behind her neck, into the silkiness of her hair. She tilts her head, ready for me, her eyes fluttering shut. When our lips meet, when my tongue slips into her mouth, she moans. Her hands find the back of my shirt, squeezing. She kisses me back with the same desperation that I remember Eleanor kissing me, pressing her tight body into mine, her tongue jockeying against my own.

When we break, it's Brandi who looks over at her husband. "I could use that drink now."

He clears his throat. "Right," he says, nearly tripping over himself as he winds around my sofa.

"Your apartment is nice," she says to me. "Clean. Were you expecting us to come back?"

"I like keeping a clean home," I say. "Scouts taught me to always be prepared."

"You were a Boy Scout?"

"Not anymore."

We kiss again. This time, I explore her body, experiencing all of her—her warmth beneath her black dress; her perfume, new to me, but certainly not new to this couple; the taste of her lipstick mixed with wine and something sweet. Every woman I'm with is unique in their one way—every couple is their own version of special. I love experiencing it every single fucking time.

It's Brandi who makes the first move of escalation, shifting her tight, little body against me until her hip grazes my cock. Unable to help herself, she reaches down and runs her hand across it. She kisses me harder as she does.

“Mmm, you’re big.”

“You like ’em big?”

“I don’t know,” she says with a delightful laugh.

I pull her along to my sofa, the black leather crunching under our body weight. “Take it out,” I tell her.

She looks up at me, her soft, brown eyes sharpening as she considers this next line. She looks up, seeking out her husband. I don’t. I keep my eyes on Brandi and how I’ll soon be watching her pretty face tighten in orgasm.

She finds whatever comfort she’s looking for in her husband, giving him a quick nod before turning back to me. Her hand trembles as she reaches down and finds the zipper of my pants. She checks on me, as if making sure that I’m okay with this.

I nearly laugh. Instead, I just nod encouragingly.

Licking her lips, she finishes the motion, unzipping me, undoing the button. Reaching in, she slides her soft hand along my shaft. I can feel her clammy palm, and I kiss her to put her mind at ease.

We get my pants off and my cock out, kissing and caressing. When she breaks it, we watch as her hand slides up and down my shaft, and how she can’t quite get her fingers all the way around it. My cock curves up and into me, seemingly larger because I keep everything shaved bare. She laughs, as if to say, ‘Is this really happening?’

I pull my shirt off, letting her appreciate all the hard work I’ve put in at the gym—then laugh at myself and my ego. What would Manhattan say if she could read my thoughts. It cows me.

Brandi doesn’t notice. She takes my unspoken offer, running her heavy-lidded gaze over my thick chest and broad shoulders.

She looks over the back of the couch one more time, looking at her husband. This time, she’s looking for reaffirmation or permission. She’s no

longer just checking in. She's saying, 'Can you believe we're doing this?'

She brushes her hair out of her face and gingerly lowers her head into my lap. I watch her the whole way, her eyes focused on my cock, the tip of her tongue pinched between her lips.

I drape a hand behind my head and lounge back into my sofa, taking in the show before me. I love this moment, when boundaries are pushed and suddenly anything is possible. Same script, but exhilarating every time.

Brandi holds my cock by the base, angling it against my abdomen as she slowly runs her tongue along the underside. Her eyes are shut. She's savoring this moment.

Her lips graze the ridge of my cockhead where she plants a demure kiss right on the cap. Her eyes flutter open, full of mischief. Just not for me.

Andy has settled into the armchair beside us, still awkwardly holding two glasses of wine. Maintaining that eye contact with him, she runs her tongue along my glans, getting me nice and wet. With a firm grip on the base and full command of her husband's attention, she takes the tip into her mouth.

We all groan. For me, it's the soft, wet feeling of a new mouth. For Andy, it's the wrongness of this image. I glance at him. He's transfixed.

Brandi slides halfway down my length, her tongue swirling a lazy zig-zag across the most sensitive parts of me. She retreats in the same fashion, pulling off of me with a smile at her husband.

And that's all nice and fine. She's a tease and she's putting on a show for him. But we're also here for me. Luckily, there's a way that we can all be winners.

"Your wife's a pretty good little cocksucker," I tell him as she returns to my cock. "Let me guess... she's always been that good."

It's a hunch. Could backfire, but it doesn't.

Andy swallows as he connects some dots that may or may not be there—she was always this good, so how did she get so good?

I stroke her hair, encouraging her to bob a little faster, to take me a little deeper. I watch her, knowing Andy's watching her and wondering. "Where do you think she got all this experience, Andy?"

Brandi catches on quickly, putting a little more flare to her blowjob. She shifts her head so my cock presses against the inside of her cheek. It looks great for Andy, and feels fantastic for me. I make sure her hair stays out of her face, giving her husband an unobstructed view.

"You two talk about her exes? I bet you have..." I muse. "So tell me, Andy, she have a lot of boyfriends before you?" I glance up at him. "Or was it just one guy in particular that taught her how to suck a cock."

His nostrils flare at his sharp inhale. He shifts back, as if struck, and I recognize the pained, jealous expression that tightens along his jaw and between his brow. It's the look of a true cuckold.

"What was his name?"

Andy gulps. His voice comes out as a croak that I can barely understand.

"Victor?" I look down at Brandi. "You like fucking Victor, Brandi?"

With my cock angling into the back of her throat, she nods.

"Did Victor have a big cock?"

Again, another nod, desperate now to breathe. I keep her there, easing deeper.

"I bet you took him all the way into your throat."

I release her, and she gulps down air as she nods.

"Show him." I nod at Andy. "Show him how you sucked Victor's cock."

Brandi takes a fortifying breath, all focus on my dick—her next, big hurdle. It bows out of her hand like it's bending under its own weight. With one last, deep flare of her nostrils, she drops back down to me. It's swift. I hit the back of her throat a beat later.

She holds it there for just a moment, letting it choke her. Just as she gags, she pulls back, just as quickly, swirling the crown of my cock with her tongue before dropping back down. This time, she holds me in her throat longer. Her gag spasms around me, feeling fantastic, before stroking back up and doing it all over again.

When I look up at Andy, he's got that deer-in-headlights look to him. He's never seen this before. He's never watched his wife behave this way, but he's definitely, one hundred percent imagined it.

Brandi's lips touch the base of me, my cock all the way into her throat. She holds me there, a sword-swallower impressing her audience with her skills, before gagging off.

"Gah!" she gasps.

She glances not at me, but at Andy, before doing it all over again. She doesn't even pause long enough to fully catch her breath.

"You ever meet Victor, Andy?"

At first, I'm not even sure that he hears me. He blinks, glances at me as if remembering that I'm a person and not a figment of his imagination. He nods.

"Before you two were together?"

Again, he nods, holds onto something, then finally adds, "And after."

Interesting. There's a story here, but I don't push, and Andy isn't offering. Brandi's attention on my cock distracts us, her gags filling the charged space between us. She eases back, holding half of my length in her mouth as she wraps both hands around the rest of me. She pumps me, working her

spit into my shaft as her tongue swirls in perfect harmony around my cockhead.

The deepthroat was hot in a visceral, powerful way. The sensations that radiate down my cock now are divine.

“Ah, fuck,” I groan. I forget about teasing these two. I forget about the dynamic. About being a bull. About having the power and being the driver of this seduction. I’m lost in the amazing things this woman is doing with her mouth and hands, of the sight of her golden hair rising and falling in my lap and how good she looks each time her cheeks cave and she sucks down.

I consider stopping her. I consider warning her. I don’t need to. She knows. She can feel my orgasm build because she’s been here before, she’s sucked cock like this before. She draws back further, focusing her lips and tongue on the millions of nerve-endings as her hand jacks me to completion.

When I come, she dives deep again, taking me all the way into her throat as my cock pulses and spews my hot excitement. Looking up at me with a naughty expression, she shows me how much she likes choking on it, how much she gets off on it.

“Damn, girl, you know how to suck cock. That was easily top ten.” I don’t even lie. For all the training I gave Elie, she never got even close to this chick. “Thank you, Victor, I suppose.”

Brandi giggles. Adorably, she blushes at that, even as she keeps stroking my still hard cock. “It was fun.”

“Fun for all of us,” I say. We glance at Andy, who’s as turned on as he is uncomfortable. “You ever watch her do that with Victor?”

He hesitates. The couple looks at one another meaningfully. She wants to share. He doesn’t. Wordlessly, though, they come to some kind of consensus.

“It was back when we were first dating,” Andy says slowly. “We’d been friends forever, and I’d always had a crush on her, but she always seemed

so unattainable.”

“Ah, babe...”

“Seemed like you were always with Victor.”

“And you were always the guy I went crying to when he broke my heart,” she says. I can feel the emotion run between them, even as she continues her slow handjob. “You’ve always been my best friend.”

“Victor eventually took a job across the country. They broke up. We got together.”

I know where this is going. This is the age old cuckold origin tale. “Until Victor came to visit.”

“I walked in on them,” Andy confirms.

“And you’ve been thinking about seeing that again, ever since,” I finish.

He nods.

“Ready to see it again?” I grin at him, then look at his wife. “Come on, let me show you my bedroom.”

I stand, the only one in the room without clothing on. I don’t shy away from it. Why should I? I worked hard for what I have. I take the glasses of wine that Andy still holds, hand one to Brandi, and raise mine. “To Victor.”

Brandi giggles, tipping her glass against mine in a harmonic clink. She swallows half of it in one go. I laugh, sipping mine as I lead her towards my bedroom. I know she’s making eyes at her husband. Makes me smile wider.

I survey my bedroom—my domain. It’s as tidy as the rest of my apartment, my platform king dominating the center of the room.

“Alexa, lights on low,” I command, and up come the two brushed metal lamps that flank the bed, dim enough to be romantic, bright enough to see all of the action.

I take a seat on the edge of the bed as Brandi enters, pausing just inside of the doorway. Her black dress is short and tight, and she still wears her heels, turning her legs into works of art.

“You’ve got the body of a dancer. Did you ever dance?”

She shakes her head, almost apologetic for letting me down. “I did cheer.”

That makes sense, too. “You ever dress up as a cheerleader for him?”

Brandi giggles. “I have.”

I could imagine it, but as hot as that would be, seeing her standing there in her LBD and tall heels, I couldn’t ask for a better first meeting. “Show me what’s under that dress.”

She shifts her head just slightly, and the vixen is back, studying me through her long lashes. She reaches behind her, shifting her shoulders back and her breasts forward as she lowers the zipper.

Her husband looms behind her, still in the living room with that I-can’t-believe-this-is-happening expression. His eyes follow the dress as she peels it down, exposing her black, satin bra, the diamond stud piercing her navel, her matching black thong.

“Leave the shoes on,” I tell her. I love a woman in lingerie and heels. “But I want your husband to take the rest off.”

She smiled wickedly and nodded as Andy stepped up behind her and put a hand on her shoulder. I was fully erect again, stroking it slowly as the power of this moment coursed through me.

Andy pushes her bra straps off her shoulders, and Brandi gasps, shutting her eyes. I can see his hands shake. He doesn’t look at me, but at his wife as he reaches behind her and unclasps her bra. Her tits are small, perky, with large nipples that are swollen and erect.

She turns in his arms as the bra hits the floor. Andy sinks to his knees like a worshipper, staring up at the blonde as she strokes his hair. Her ass, in the

thong, is tight and round. I can't wait to get my hands on it.

Andy nods at some unspoken exchange they've shared, reaching up and grasping the sides of her thong.

"Is she wet, Andy?" I ask as he teases the black panties down her thighs. "Is she excited?"

He nods, like he doesn't trust his voice.

"Give it a lick for me."

He leans in, doing as he's told. Brandi shudders, grasping his head to steady herself. I reach into my bedside table and retrieve a condom.

"That's good, Andy. Now send her to me."

He sits back on his heels, subservient, obedient. He nods at her. This is what I want. Go. Do it.

She hesitates for only a moment, touching his cheek. Then she glances over her shoulder through the curtain of her golden hair. Her blue eyes glint, taking in my cock again. When I hold up the foil wrapper, I swear I can see her pupils dilate.

I crook my finger at her, and like a puppet, she turns and comes my way. She's shaved herself into a tidy, dark brown triangle of pubic hair, and her pussy glistens.

Biting her lower lip, she takes the condom wrapper from me, tearing it open with a laugh. I pull her into me, kissing her as we tumble back onto the bed. I touch her pussy, pushing my ring and middle finger into her tight opening. She gasps, breaking the kiss.

"Put it on," I tell her, glancing at the condom. "Let hubby see."

Brandi is no stranger to doing this, it appears. She pinches the tip as she rolls it along my erection. "XLs, honey," she tells her husband. "Told you we should have bought the big ones."

She grins at me, like I'm in on the joke, before straddling me. She leans down, kissing me as she strokes my cock along her slippery groove. Even through the condom, it feels unreal. The view for her husband must be intense, too. I hear him gasping and sputtering in the doorway. Then I tune him out, focusing on the gorgeous creature above me.

Running my hands down her body, following the curve of her waist and the flare of her hips, I grasp her tight little cheerleader ass. She knows what comes next. Welcomes it, breaking our kiss with a happy sigh. She reaches behind her, taking my cock in her hand, and angles it against her pussy.

Andy would be able to see it all. See the moist petals of her pussy, the latex-sheathed length and how it pressed against her, then, with a thrust, pushed inside, stretching her.

“Uh!” she groans. He groans. We all groan. “It’s so big.”

But she doesn’t slow down. She doesn’t stop. She lowers onto me, taking it all into her tight body. Her fingers slither across my balls, caressing them as she begins to slowly undulate her hips.

“He’s fucking me,” she cries. “Watch him fuck me, baby.”

I fill my hands with her small tits, squeezing them, thumbing her nipples as she rides me. She’s a good fuck. An athletic fuck. But this show demands more.

I begin thrusting up, meeting her halfway, driving deeper—“Uh!”—and deeper—“Yes!” She writhes and rocks over me, tossing her hair, touching her throat. She tightens a hand over mine, pushing it into her breast. I feel her diamond ring dig into my flesh, a reminder of what we’re doing. My balls swell.

I steady her hips completely, holding her in place above me as I thrust up, fucking her faster and faster. She forgets to breathe, squatting there, taking my dick. She claws at her chest, tweaking her nipples until they scream pink and painful. Until she screams. “Fuck me! Fuck me with your big cock!”

When she comes, she's bowed back, her body sweeping and on display for me as she clutches my ankles behind her. I drive up into her, watching the muscles along her stomach ripple. If she hadn't blown me, I would have joined her. I'm grateful that she did, because there's still so much more fun left in the night.

We rearrange ourselves on the bed. Andy has finally found the chair I left for him in the corner and is sitting on the edge, rubbing his bulge through his pants. Poor guy. He must be dying. We don't relieve him, though. That's Brandi's job, and I get the feeling she likes to torment him.

Instead, I get behind her, on our sides and facing Andy. Lifting her leg, I re-enter her from behind. He can see everything, every detail, lewd and laid bare. She kisses me over her shoulder as I fuck her from behind, squeezing her thigh.

Andy rubs himself faster through his pants, but doesn't unzip himself. He stares at us, at our union, at a cock going into his wife's pussy. A cock that's definitely not his. The jealousy and pain and conflict are gone. All that remains is desire, burning bright, like watching a match burn in slow motion.

Brandi comes again, her fingers mashing the pliant flesh at the apex of her pussy, rubbing and digging and helping her once again over the edge. I fuck her through her orgasm, driving in and out, driving her to moan until her throat is raw.

"Are you close?" Brandi gasps.

"Yes."

"I want..." She trails off, looking at her husband. He looks strung out, tapping his foot on the ground, his face screwed up like he's in pain. He nods to her, and she finishes her request. "I want you to come on...me."

Andy licks his lips.

"Come all over my face."

It catches me by surprise, and I nearly lose it. I pull out of her, rolling her onto her back, and straddle her torso. Ripping the condom off, I toss it aside as I wrap my hand around my shaft and start to pump it.

Brandi moans in anticipation, opening her mouth, ready to receive. My balls tighten at her pretty, bright face and what I'm about to do to it. I slap my cock on her tongue, and she swallows me briefly. All it takes is one, quick swirl around the crown and I'm done.

I pull back, aim at her face, and launch a rope of come along her right cheek. The second hits her forehead, just along her hairline. The third lands on her chin.

When this is all over, these two will come back together, but be different. Be forever changed. This is the end of one story, and the beginning of another.

Just not mine. I'm the catalyst. I'm the agent of change. I'm the supporting role in everyone else's wild tale.

Making Up

“...and that’s why I think we need to change the name of the organization,” Eleanor Heller concludes.

What follows is an awkward silence, despite the twelve other participants on the conference call. Makes sense when the newly minted president of the board of trustees makes a compelling argument for changing the name of a storied charity. Makes it tense when that storied charity is named after the family of a man on this call.

Henry Dawning clears his throat. “Paul, what do you think?”

I’ve stayed out of this since it was brought up—just a couple weeks ago. As the acting director, I run the day-to-day operations of the Dawning Foundation. I make sure the wheels are turning. I don’t make large and sweeping decisions like this.

I also know that picking a side will have a long-term impact on my future and on my career. Pick the wrong one, the losing one, and that “acting” part of my title probably changes to “former.” It’s funny. A few years back, I wouldn’t have considered any of this calculus. I would have answered with my gut without worrying about the consequences. When had I become so cautious?

“According to our perception analysis from Smith & Kingsley, it’s probably a good time to change our brand. We still haven’t gotten past the Hamilton thing.”

“Fucking Greg Hamilton,” Henry Dawning mutters. A couple months back, one of our most influential donors turned out to be a con artist who was funneling millions of dollars into offshore accounts. We’d only just barely gotten our feet back under us, and that was only after a huge churn in management and the board. Dawning came back strong. “But things are better now. And will keep getting better.”

“Maybe,” I say. It’s reckless to challenge this man, but it also feels like the right thing to do. I’ve seen the numbers. I’ve read the report put together by Manhattan’s PR agency. But beyond that, I trusted Eleanor and her instincts...and I owed her. For what I’d done to her. For what we once had. “But maybe not. It may not be the scandal of the moment, but our donors—and future donors—aren’t forgetting.”

“Henry,” Eleanor adds, and there’s real conviction behind her cultured accent. “Can we truly afford to take this chance?”

“I’ll... let me think about it.”

“GPC is in one month. If we’re going to make this big brand change... that’s barely enough time to prepare for even an announcement.” GPC, or the Global Philanthropy Conference, is one of the biggest charity events of the year, and the ideal place to announce this shift in vision.

“I’ll let you know by the end of the week,” he says.

He’s still running this like the de facto decision maker, when he’s now only a vote on this board. In practice, though, his opinion went a long way with many of the members. An endorsement probably meant the difference between a vote passing or not.

“Thanks, Henry,” Eleanor says. “We’ll reconvene on Friday. Paul, set up another conference call?”

It isn’t a question, and I find it amusing that she’s now the one giving me orders. If we were still together... but then, we’re not.

“Will do.”

The call ends and I immediately delegate the meeting off to Margaret, my administrative assistant, who was sitting in on the call with me. “I like her,” she says, standing. Margaret’s been here long before me and has seen a lot of changes over the years. I value her opinion.

“You think this is a good idea?”

She shrugs. “I think it’s necessary. All change is. People just don’t like admitting it.”

She collects her things. “Thanks, Yoda.”

Margaret has a smoker’s laugh. Reminds me of an aunt I knew as a kid. “Yes, I think it’s a good thing for those out there suffering from Alzheimer’s. Maybe not so great for everyone on that call, present company included. But hey, I guess that’s the decision you need to make.”

My phone rang as she left the room, and since she wasn’t there to screen it, I pick up.

“Paul. Debrief?”

It’s Eleanor, and this constitutes our first one-on-one conversation since I broke things off with her. “Of course. Let me shut my door.”

Margaret hears me, pulling my door closed behind her. I feel inexplicably nervous as it clicks softly shut.

“Thank you for your support.”

“It’s the right thing to do.”

“A concept you’ve taken to heart lately.”

I glance at the door, double checking that it’s fully closed. “I’m sorry about how I ended things between us.”

“But you’re not sorry that you did end things.” I hear the bitterness there.

This was always going to get messy. I knew that from the moment I approached her at the gala.

It's Eleanor who decides to break it. "I'm sorry, I'm sorry. I'm being dramatic." She forces a regal laugh.

"I don't really blame you," I say.

"If anything, I should be thanking you."

"Yeah? And why's that?" My gut says that she's going to have a good answer for this one.

"You were like training wheels. Now that they're off, things are so much more exhilarating."

"Dare I ask?"

My phone rumbles on my desk. I lift it, and my heart skips. The photo that waits for me is of a woman on the bed, in profile with another man. She's naked, on her elbows and knees, her full tits pressed into the bedsheets. It's cropped so that we can't see her face, but I know Elie's body well. The man behind her, holding her hips, is also definitely not Ron. He's fit in a way her husband isn't. With a shock of shaggy, sandy blonde hair that's definitely not her husband's.

"Judging from the silence, I'm guessing my text came through? He was called Jamie."

My phone buzzes again and another photo slides into view. This one is a POV shot from the man's perspective, the camera pointed down at a kneeling Eleanor Heller, her hair pulled back in a tight ponytail, as she gives him a blowjob. Her eyes are blurred out, but again, I'd recognize those lips and her high-boned, freckled cheeks anywhere.

"He's called Richard."

"You've been busy."

“From what Heather says, so have you.”

I chuckle. It’s funny, thinking about those two sharing gossip. “Honestly, this was my normal life before I met you,” I say.

“Then I like your normal life before me. It feels... free.”

“How’s Ron handling it?” That, of course, is the difference between us—she has a partner in crime.

“Oh, he’s loving it. Ron may be more into this change in lifestyle than I am.” She laughs. “He actually set me up with Richard, a friend of his from university who was visiting last weekend.”

“Does Richard know about your game?”

Her laugh is so effervescent. “He thinks we are doing it behind Ronald’s back. What a great friend, yeah?”

“In my experience, guys never do the right thing when facing temptation and they think they can get away with it.”

“That your personal experience, huh?”

“You of all people should know that.”

Her voice gets husky. “So if I asked you to come over because I miss the feel of your cock in my arse, you’d come?”

My cock swells. She is certainly a temptation. “No, but only because Mrs. Kingsley-Fletcher would have my balls.”

“Look at that. You two are not even a couple, and she’s got you wrapped around her finger.”

“She’s just the infuriating voice of reason.”

“Hm... yeah. We need to break her moral compass. At least a little. Don’t you agree?”

I cannot tell if she's joking or not. Probably not. "No comment."

"So if my offer for you to come over involves a ménage à trois with a certain blonde, you'd drop your things and be on your way?"

"At the very least, I'd be impressed."

"Then I'll keep you posted."

This feels wrong, but whatever. We're all adults here, and if this is how Elie wants to play it, who am I to get in the way? Manhattan can certainly take care of herself.

"So we're good, you and me?"

"Better, anyway," Elie says. "I'm a smidge less furious with you."

"I'll take what I can get. Being in the boss's dog house is not a great place to be."

Eleanor seems tickled by being the boss. "Talk later. Bye, love."

What a crazy woman.

The Setup

It's Tuesday Morning—a day after the board call and another sleepless night with Brandi and Andy. I need to start scheduling these things on the weekends, but hey, when a woman who looks that good sends me a pic with her legs spread wide and the caption, Hungry? who am I to disappoint.

It's one of those blissfully cooler days, despite mid-August in DC. We sit by the windows of Aroma House, watching the street traffic shuffle by. The sky is overcast, threatening rain. Manhattan's irises reflect the weather and the mood, a richer, deeper blue today. Cloudier. Lost in thought.

The DeBauch PM arrives just as I put my order in at Aroma House. I'm only half awake, but the message hits me stronger than a shot of espresso.

MANDY: Not bad, Jameson. I'll put you on my shortlist.

At first, I'm confused. I scroll up, jogging my memory, and laugh. The last thing I sent her was a photo of myself, shirtless and flexing. Why the hell did I think that was a good idea?!

I look up, and sure enough I see Manhattan sitting towards the back of the shop, smirking at me. Your move.

I grin and respond through DeBauch.

JAMESON: Want to see something even hotter?

She laughs and shakes her head as she reads it, mouthing, No! to me. In the app, though, the ruse continues.

MANDY: I don't know if my delicate sensibilities can take it.

My coffee arrives. I pull the plastic lid off, take a photo, and send it to her through DeBauch.

JAMESON: There's nothing more exciting on a Tuesday morning than this.

I snap the lid back on and go to join her.

MANDY: Maybe you really are a man after my own heart.

“Having fun?” I ask.

“Silly fun.” She motions to the seat. “Go ahead and sit. I don’t like looking up at you.” She hears the innuendo as soon as she says it and laughs. “Don’t say it.”

I sit. “I would never...”

“You and Eleanor friends again?”

“We never were enemies.”

Manhattan blows across the lid of her coffee. “She appreciates you taking her side. Nice peace offering.”

“You just saying it because it’s partially your recommendation to rebrand?”

“Well...”

But I don’t want to talk about Eleanor or the rebrand or work. I want to know about the blonde sitting in front of me and how her husband reacted to meeting me for drinks last week. “So? Did he buy it?”

“Well...” She pauses, and I watch as she steps back into memory for a moment, her smile emerging from it before she does. “Not exactly.”

“But?”

“Well, when I got home Friday night, things were intense.”

“Reclamation?”

She blushes without blushing, looking around us as if to say, Watch it, buddy, we’re in public. “What a silly way of putting it.” But then, she leans in and adds, “It’s never been quite like that, either.”

“Now he’s got something to prove.”

She laughs. “You guys are so weird. He wants me to go... do this thing. Then when I do, he wants to demonstrate why I don’t need to.”

“So you said he didn’t exactly buy it?”

“He’s a details guy, and hyper analytical. Friday night, he wanted to believe. Saturday, he put it all together and couldn’t.”

“What tipped him off?”

“We didn’t set up the date ahead of time. ‘We’ meaning ‘Jameson’ and ‘Mandy.’ He was apparently checking our exchange obsessively, so knew that the last thing you sent me was that photo. If we really were meeting up, we would have coordinated through there.”

“Ah, yeah. Makes sense. So what are you going to do?”

“Well, Eleanor has this crazy idea.”

“She wants to name the Dawning Foundation the Heller Foundation,” I joke.

“No. What?” She looks up at me. “Really? No, you’re joking.”

“Feels like her ego’s growing by leaps and bounds. Maybe that’s coming next week.”

Manhattan laughs, sliding a strand of hair behind her ear. “No, but she thinks I should try again, only this time make it more real.”

The thought of Manhattan going on a real date sends a complex tumble of mixed, yet exciting, emotions through me. “Hey, isn’t that what I’ve been saying all along?”

“I mean, this’ll still be pretend, only this time, when I meet up with ‘Jameson,’ I’ll work up to it. We’ll exchange some messages. I’ll get all dolled up in front of Joshua and leave. Then, I’ll grab dinner or drinks or whatever with Eleanor, stay out, and pretend like I was out with ‘Jameson.’”

“You mean me.”

She laughs and shakes her head. “I mean Jameson. I don’t think we want him to know that Jameson is actually one of my clients.”

“Fair enough. I’m in.” I pull out my phone before she has a chance to respond.

JAMESON: You free Friday? We can get together and chat about coffee beans.

Her phone rumbles. She checks it and smiles. “You’re so easy.”

“Well, here’s the thing. I want you to meet me for that drink.”

Concern crosses her face. “Paul...”

“With Elie, of course. I want to be in on this.”

She stares at me, weighing me and my intentions. Thing is, I don’t really know what my intentions are. In the end, she settles on a sarcastic, “I’m shocked that you’re free on a Friday night.”

She stands, picking up her coffee. “I seem to have surrounded myself with bad influences.”

“Says the woman who was almost certainly a bad influence when she was younger.”

“‘When she was younger’ being the operative word there.”

We walk out together, ready to start our day. I feel buoyant, like I could just float up through the summer breeze.

“Keep me posted about Friday,” I say.

She waves her phone at me. “Mandy will be in touch.”

Accomplice

I play the role of Jameson to her Mandy. We flirt. We joke. No pictures are exchanged, but we agree to meet up at the Continental Ballroom for drinks and dancing. Not my personal choice, as I don't do many clubs these days, but one that seems natural for the Jameson bro I am playing.

JAMESON: Perfect excuse to wear that red dress from your profile.

MANDY: Intriguing, but I don't think that dress would fit you.

I got there early, just to take in the place. The Ballroom sprawls, and the music and the high ceiling give it the air of a cheesy wedding reception. The hits are Top 100, recognizable, singable. Katy Perry. Miley. Lady Gaga. Older songs, too, but all recognizable, all classics. All the things you'd hear at a high school reunion or your cousin's wedding. It even has an enormous disco ball that rotates overhead, throwing stars and shards of light across the entire space.

The Continental Ballroom is actually Eleanor's recommendation, which makes sense. This is exactly the kind of club that she would come to. The clientele skews older, a thirty-something crowd. These people don't flail with the carefreeness of youth; they flail as if to rebel against the adult lives they've all checked at the door.

It's cheesy. I should hate it. A part of me does. But I also can't help but love it. The DJ puts "The Fox" on, and I smile as all these grown men and women hop around making funny noises. It helps that while the music and the mood is almost juvenile, everyone's still dressed like this is a club for grownups, and makes it sexier knowing that most of the women here are probably married or attached. I watch a group of female friends dance in a big circle—clearly a group of mom's on a night out. I watch as a few dance with other men, and see the potential in a place like this.

Eleanor and Heather arrive together, walking through the crowd and leaving a path of turning heads and staring eyes in their wake. Both wear little club dresses. Elie's is a black wrap dress, fitted with a red belt that matches her deep red lipstick. Her hair is teased and curled, pulled back enough to focus all attention on her glowing face. She owns the look, confident in a way that she wasn't when I first met her at our charity gala. The girl who stood alone, awkwardly wringing her hands and looking like she wanted to fade away, is gone. This woman demands attention, and revels in it.

Manhattan, at her side, wears her beauty with less flash and more experience. She's not overcompensating for anything. She floats along, seeing the heads turn without reacting to them. Like she's used to it. Like all of this is no big deal. She wears the short, red dress from her DeBauch profile, and it transforms her. I haven't seen this version of her since the Marriott. This dress is so short, so tight, so inappropriate for anything but for showing off. I scan her body, how the lights of the club glance off her, and wonder if she's wearing anything beneath, and catch the telltale lines of her bra before snapping myself out of it.

Still, when they're close, I can't help myself. "You wore it."

Her blue eyes glitter through her long lashes. "Joshua made sure that I did. He also picked out these heels, the bastard."

That forces me to look at her heels—short boots that slouch around her ankles, with spindly heels entirely impractical for dancing. On the way, though, I take in her legs, lean and muscular. I want to run my hands along her silky skin. Instead, I say, "You planning to dance in those?"

“I’m going to hate myself in the morning.”

“No pain, no gain,” Elie says. “But we can do something to numb that. Paul, be a dear and order us a round of shots.”

Manhattan’s brows go up as she hears the order. She drinks in moderation, I’ve noticed, and starting a night off with shots is far from moderation. But Eleanor’s enthusiasm is infectious. We go with it.

The shots come, and we order a round of drinks—a Manhattan, a Cosmopolitan, and another whiskey. As they’re being prepared, Elie grabs Manhattan by the hand and, with a sly smile my way, pulls the blonde toward the dance floor, leaving me to wait for their drinks. The bartender just looks at me with a grin that says, You’re one lucky mother fucker. He’s not wrong.

I pick up my whiskey, leaving the two cocktails waiting behind me, and turn to watch the women dance to a Rihanna song. They come together on the dance floor, surrounded now by a healthy crowd swaying and moving to the rhythm. They know that others are watching and seem to know how to put on a show. Manhattan puts a hand on Elie’s hip as the brunette lifts her arms to the air, swaying her body in time. They whisper to one another. Manhattan laughs, raking her fingers through her hair, deliberate and sexy, before turning her back to Elie and moving against the other woman.

Tonight is a lark. We’re here to kill time and make Heather’s husband wonder. That doesn’t stop me from looking at these two dancing together and fantasizing about the night ahead. Like so many others in this club, watching them, it’s easy to imagine a threesome. It’s so absurd, so improbable, like being hit by lightning, and yet it burns through me like I’ve been struck.

The eyes of the women find me through the crowd, seductive and inviting. Manhattan can only maintain that smoky expression for a few beats before she breaks it with a smile and a laugh. She turns again, facing Elie, getting close to her new friend.

The song, appropriately, shifts to “I Kissed a Girl” as a couple guys join them. The women don’t turn them away, although they remain focused on one another. Everyone seems to hold their breath, hoping that these two “girls” will kiss.

For a moment, I wonder if they will. With Manhattan’s hands on Elie’s hips, and Elie’s on Heather’s shoulders, their heads tilt and their lips get so close. The club holds its breath. Then, Manhattan’s eyes open. Something passes between the two women—realization, a moment, the gravity and thrill and near miss of it all?

They laugh it off. The song ends and the guys move on as they leave the floor, their skin glistening in the disco ball lights.

“You’ve got half this club drooling,” I say as they collect their cocktails from the bar.

“Just half?” Manhattan pouts.

“Told you we should have made out,” Elie says.

Manhattan does an excellent job looking scandalized. “I am a married woman.”

“Ron says it doesn’t count with other girls,” Elie says.

“He also doesn’t count other guys,” I add.

“Good point.” She reaches up, pulls me to her, and kisses me hard. It catches me off-guard, and I can feel Manhattan’s eyes on us, making all of this more awkward. I can taste the booze on her breath and wonder exactly how drunk we all are.

When we part, Manhattan is pretending to be interested in the cocktail menu. I’m about to make some kind of dumb joke to lighten the mood when a man emerges out of the crowd, handsome and tall, with a trim, hipster beard and a pair of Raybans pushed up into his close cropped hair. To Manhattan, he says, “Pick something out. Put it on my tab.”

Her eyes slide my way before she catches herself. She smiles, turns to the bartender, and orders a Jack and Coke. “Put it on this guy’s tab.”

“Right away.”

I feel the burn of jealousy, but it’s manageable—especially with Elie draped over me, her perfume tantalizing my senses. “Come dance with me,” Elie whispers. Throwing back the rest of her drink, she grabs my arm and tugs. And I go.

But I can’t help looking over at Heather. Elie catches me. Calls me on it. “You’re jealous.”

“Don’t be silly.” Her hipster suitor makes her laugh, and based on the way she holds his eyes and touches her neck, she’s not just humoring him.

“You are!” Elie looks delighted. “I know that look. Remember who I’m married to.”

“No.” There is steel in my voice. I force myself to look at Eleanor, to forget about Manhattan. “I’m not your husband.”

She knows better than to keep pressing. She takes another tack instead, shimmying closer, pressing her body tight to mine. Her hand drifts across my cock, squeezing it. “Definitely not my husband.”

We broke up. She’s my boss and things could get so messy. But something moves inside me, primal and dangerous. I spin her, take control of her, moving her against me to the rhythm of music. JLo comes on, and Elie moves with the smoky voice, rocking and slithering her body, making me almost forget about Manhattan. Almost.

The blonde joins us after a few songs, holding a bottle of water and shaking her shoulders as she shimmies on the dance floor. Her hipster suitor grins behind her, his eyes glued to her legs beneath that short, red skirt.

Manhattan meets my eyes, mischief dancing in her bright blue irises. I wink at her. A friendly, encouraging smile, because that’s what I was here for,

right? To be a friend. To encourage her to be the kind of wife for Joshua as Elie was for Ronald.

Manhattan moves with a grace that's mesmerizing. Like fire. Like heat made manifest, twisting and undulating, arms up, flickering above. She meets my eyes through the sheet of her golden hair, through her thick lashes, then turns away, throwing herself into the dance with this stranger.

I entertain a brief yet satisfying fantasy of peeling that guy off of her and flipping him into the crowd. He sees me and does that irritating bro-nod at me, chin first. I return it, and hate that I do.

Is he...me?

Elie looks up at me with a knowing smile. "You two are cute," she says.

I need to clear out of here. To Elie, I say, "Come on, let's get another drink."

It feels good to leave Manhattan behind, with another man. I force myself not to look back. Let her have her fun.

The club actually does have a second floor, half lounge, half rooftop bar. It's crowded, but with a woman like Elie, it's not hard to get another drink.

"You cool just leaving her down there with that guy?" she asks.

"She's a big girl. She can handle it." I say the words. I even mean them. But deep inside, envy and anxiety tear at me.

Elie sees the conflict, too, or at least suspects as much. She looks like she's going to say something more, but restrains herself. "Sorry I kissed you in there," she says instead.

"You don't have to apologize." I'm more buzzed than I realize, and wonder if I've crossed into being drunk. I should probably stop drinking. "Although you should have kissed Heather."

Elie doesn't snort or roll her eyes. She doesn't make a sarcastic remark, the way Manhattan would. She just smiles shyly and nods. "I should have, but

that would have been completely inappropriate.”

I raise my glass. “To a night of inappropriate things.”

Manhattan finds us eventually. She’s alone, her man gone. “There you two are. Thought for a second you guys left the club.”

“Oh, Paul would never do that,” Elie says with a sparkle as she looks at the blonde. “Where’d your man go?”

“Oh, I fucked him in the bathroom and he went home.”

I nearly did a spit take. The women laugh.

“He wanted to take me home, and when I told him I just wanted to dance, he moved on.”

“Why didn’t you go?” Elie asked. “He was cute.”

“And ditch the two of you? Never.”

Elie looks at me. “She thinks that if she leaves us alone, we’ll be naughty.”

“I’m not wrong, am I?” Manhattan says.

“Hey, we’re here for you,” I say. “This isn’t about us.”

The blonde throws herself into the bench we’re sitting in, right between the two of us. Wrapping her arms around us, she announces, “I’m drunk.”

“Good for you!”

Despite that, she switches to water when Eleanor and I go to get more drinks. Doesn’t put a damper on the night, though, and after sitting and recharging, the girls are ready to dance some more, and I’m more than ready and willing to let them rub their bodies against mine.

Descending the grand staircase along the back wall, the sea of bodies undulates like a sea, hands up, rising and falling in time with Lady Gaga’s

“Just Dance”. The girls get into it even before we hit the dance floor, Manhattan singing along as she swings her hips.

By the time we reach the floor, though, the song shifts to “Cotton Eye Joe”, the remixed version of the line-dance song immediately getting everyone’s feet two-stepping.

“I love this song!” Manhattan squeals unexpectedly. I laugh as she grabs my hand and pulls me with her, caught in the current of the sea of people. She links elbows with me as we bounce to the dance-mix version, fiddles flying, heavy bass driving. I forget to be serious for a moment, lost in the moment.

Elie’s with us, too, swinging to the country techno...at first. But as one song tumbles into the next, and that into the next, and soon it’s just me and Manhattan. When “Billie Jean” comes on, I playfully pull her against me in a swing step—habit from the brief period in college when I thought ballroom dance was the best way to impress girls.

When she matches me perfectly, my brows go up. She watches me, amused, challenging. I spin her, a simple thing, and when she responds with a practiced flourish, I try something more complex. She doesn’t miss a beat.

I twirl her close, so she’s facing away, my arms wrapped in front of her. She lifts her head and says over her shoulder, “You’re full of surprises.”

I spin her back out, and she moves with the practice of someone used to following, in perfect time to Michael Jackson’s rising and falling rhythm. I do a couple salsa moves, rocking my hips before returning to the swing. “Someone once told me that learning to dance helps in the bedroom.”

Manhattan laughs. “Now that makes more sense.”

That song ends and the slower paced jazz of Louis Armstrong’s “What a Wonderful World” comes on—our cue to leave the floor at last. But I don’t want to leave, and neither does she.

We’re back in the Starlight Lounge. Back in that moment. That mistake. Only with the thrum of alcohol and music, it doesn’t feel like a mistake at

all.

I see friends shaking hands saying how do you do...

I pull her close, feel her fingers caress the short hairs on the back of my neck. I hold her and it feels good and right and perfect. I can feel her breasts between us, can trace her rib cage with my hands as it rises and falls in short, expectant breaths.

I want this. She wants this. I turn my head, lean in, ready to kiss again. Ready to go so much further. My lips meet her hair as she turns her head. As she denies me.

“I’m sorry,” she mouths, pushing back, pushing away. “Say goodbye to Eleanor for me, okay?”

I stand there, an idiot in the crowd, vulnerable and wounded and uncertain. I don’t want her to go. I don’t want her to ever go. But that’s definitely the booze talking. Numbly, I watch as she turns and leaves, threading through the crowd, a red-clad ghost, still drawing every man’s eye.

Eleanor is at my side. I’ve forgotten all about her. “You alright?”

“Hm?”

“You’re standing in the middle of the dance floor,” she shouts. “But you’re not dancing.”

“Oh.” She’s right. “Heather left.”

“Probably time for us to leave, too. It’s half-past two.”

“How did that happen?”

She regards me with playful, smiling eyes. “Time can fly when you’re with the right person, can’t it?”

“You are good company. Why did I break up with you?”

Elie laughs. “You’re drunk. So am I. Come on, let’s get out of here before we do something we’ll both regret in the morning.”

Outside, away from the reverberating music, everything seems quieter. It’s still warm. Street light and the electric glow of the other bars on the city block chases away the idea of “night.” The sidewalk is crowded with drunk club-goers like us, mutely smoking cigarettes or hanging off one another as they stumble to the next venue.

“You think Joshua’s going to buy it?” I ask as we wait for our Ubers.

“You mean do I think he’ll believe that she spent the evening with a guy she’s got a huge crush on? Then yes, I think she can be pretty authentic there.”

I stare at her. “We’re friends, you know.”

“And you guys are beginning to annoy me.”

I try another argument. “It’s not appropriate.” I can feel my drunk tongue stumble to say appropriate and know that I should stop talking now.

“Since when were you ever appropriate?”

“I’m trying to be a better man.”

Elie’s Uber arrives before mine. She turns to me. “So if I invited you back to my place, you’d really turn me down?”

My eyes drift into her cleavage. I lick my lips. “What happened to getting out of here before we do something we regret?”

“Well, we are getting out of here...”

She gets into the car, but doesn’t shut the door after her. I look up and down the street. Don’t see my own car. I also don’t see Heather—my conscience. “No one has to know,” I say to myself, cancel my rideshare, and get in with Eleanor.

Market Research

“‘The Memory Project’ is tracking well with our focus groups.” Heather Kingsley-Fletcher stands before the executives of the Dawning Foundation. We’re joined by Eleanor Heller, who’s as keen as anyone to hear the report on the rebrand, and Henry Dawning listens in over Skype. “With ‘Clarity’ a close second.”

She advances the PowerPoint to the next slide, where she shows the brand and logo treatments for those two names, along with our third, the Clear Mind Council.

“Have you given any thought to a simple rebrand of Dawning Foundation?” Henry Dawning’s disembodied voice asks over the conference call.

“Of course, sir,” Manhattan says. The next slide shows a revamped logo and color palette for the Foundation. It’s good, but doesn’t pop as much as the others.

More than anything, this seems to be what my life at work consists of—making small and inane decisions that all add up to something huge and monumental. I listen to the discussion, add my opinions when they’re strong enough, and let the whole thing move on.

Really, I’m far more interested in Manhattan and Eleanor and the very unprofessional place that our relationship has gone.

Manhattan, as always, is the picture of professionalism. She wears a pair of gray slacks that conform to the flare of her hips before cinching high on her narrow waist. Tucked into that is a short-sleeved, button down blouse. All

perfectly acceptable, except that I keep looking at her and seeing the woman in the red dress from Friday night, and how thin that material was, and how hot her body was beneath it.

“...Paul thinks.”

My name snaps me out of my day dream. The room is looking at me, including both Eleanor and Heather, who are smiling with delight. It's Eleanor who helps me out. “I personally think that we should put all of the designs on the survey. I'm not opposed to keeping the name if the majority of our donors want it.”

Ah, yes. Back to this. It takes just a glance at Margaret, my administrative assistant, to remind me where I stand. “No, I don't think so. We need this change. It's necessary.” Margaret looks up at me and, hearing her words coming out of my mouth, smiles. “People just don't like admitting it.”

Eleanor, despite what she advocated a moment ago, smiles. It's the right thing to say.

“Great, decision made,” Manhattan says. “Next up on the agenda...”

And the meeting drones on until it's over and everyone but my two accomplices filter out of the room.

“Well, I think that went pretty well,” Manhattan says as she sinks into one of the conference chairs. “Glad I wore flats though.”

“Feet still sore from last Friday?” Elie asks. Then immediately uses her own question to segue into the subject we all want to talk about. “So how did your husband take it last Friday? Did he get freaky?”

Manhattan glances at the conference room doors. They're shut, but also the whole wall is constructed of glass with Dawning Foundation employees strolling by. Doesn't feel very private, despite this looking like a legitimate meeting with our PR Agency.

“Uh, yeah. This time he bought it. I mean, I got back and was pretty wasted.”

“Yeah, we all got quite pissed.”

“He could smell the booze and, I guess, whatever cologne you were wearing, Paul.”

“Hey now, wasn’t just me you were dancing with.”

“Anyway, that smell drove him crazy.”

“Mmm, wish I could have seen that.”

“Eleanor!” Manhattan covers her mouth as her brows go up.

The British socialite just laughs. “Oh, come now, let’s not get modest. Not amongst this circle of friends.”

“If you want details about what happened between me and my husband, I wouldn’t hold your breath.”

“What do you think, Paul. Joshua spank this naughty girl?”

Manhattan can only laugh and say, “Oh, my God.”

“So what does your husband actually think happened?” I ask, forcing this conversation along.

“That I met up with Jameson. We had drinks and that we danced.”

“That it?”

“I mean, I was gone for over three hours. I led him on at first, but in the end, that’s where we landed.”

“So you hung out with this guy for three hours and all you did was dance?” Elie asks. “That doesn’t sound like the Paul I know.”

“Tell me about it,” Manhattan agrees. “So what did happen after I left?”

Elie glances at me. “You sure you want to know?”

“Maybe not.”

“I caught up with an old friend,” Elie says.

“Eleanor...”

“Oh, don’t mother me. We were discreet.”

Manhattan looks at me disapprovingly. All I can do is shrug. She ends up laughing. “I guess I can’t blame you. This one was pretty hot.”

Elie drums her fingers on the glass surface of the conference table. “You should have joined us.”

“Uh huh.”

“At least to watch. I like being watched.”

Manhattan won’t say it, but I can tell she’s not comfortable. “So what comes next?” I ask.

“Right.” She thanks me. “Joshua wants to actually watch, the next time I meet ‘Jameson.’”

I think back to the Starlight Lounge, and how he saw me kiss his wife. He knows who I am. He knows I’m a client. “That doesn’t sound like a great idea.”

“Sounds like permission to me!”

“He knows who I am.”

“And why does that matter? I think it’s better. Hits him stronger. When I fucked Ronald’s university roommate, he went mad with jealousy. But in a

really, really good way. I think that the closer this is to home, the stronger the reaction.”

When Manhattan says, “No, I’m not going to bring Paul into this,” a part of me is disappointed. But only a small part.

“So that’s going to make it even harder for you to meet up with ‘Jameson’, right? Considering he doesn’t exist?”

“I’ve got it.” Eleanor lights up. She laughs to herself. “It’s pretty brilliant, if I do say so myself. I actually know a guy called Jamie. He would be perfect.”

The guy with the surfer hair. I remember the photo she sent me. I suppose he could have resembled me, build-wise, and I never did reveal the color of my hair on DeBauch.

“Think he’ll go along with it?” Manhattan asks.

“I think we could convince him to, given the proper incentives.”

“I’m not going to sleep with him.”

“Isn’t that what your husband wants?”

“So he says. I guess we’ll find out whether he means it or not soon enough. And besides, I don’t just sleep with guys I barely know...anymore.”

“Okay then. This one has shaggy hair, nice big muscles, and about eight-and-a-half thick inches of—”

“Got it!” Manhattan’s laugh is hysterical enough to draw a look from someone passing along the hallway.

“Well, anyway,” Elie continues. “I’ll take care of the incentive. You just show up looking hot.”

“Yes, ma’am.”

“And if you want to stick around and see how this hotwife stuff is done—call it market research—you’re more than welcome to watch.”

“Uh... that’s my cue to leave,” Manhattan says, standing. “Good meeting, you two. We make a good team. And Paul, Mandy will be in touch.”

“Jameson looks forward to it.”

“Bye now.”

We watch her leave, the two of us checking out her ass as she glides down the hall. She looks back, catches us, and laughs before breezing out the door.

Eleanor is still looking in the direction the blonde left in when she says, “You should be her Jameson.”

“You know I am ‘Jameson’, right?”

“I know that you would like to be.” She crinkles her nose. “And I know that it drives you mad that you’re not.”

“You’ve got me confused with your husband.”

She turns to me and smiles in a way that makes my cock swell. “Do I?”

I laugh. “Your games aren’t going to work on me, Elie.”

“So this is when we’d usually slip into your office, and I’d get down on my knees.” She leans on her elbows and bats her lashes. “You know I’m not wearing any panties?”

“That’s a good girl.”

Eleanor sighs. “If I had you fired, could we get back to how things were?”

“You aren’t the first woman to threaten that.”

“Heather?”

I nod. “Although she wasn’t going to fire me because I wouldn’t sleep with her.”

“She would, though.” Eleanor loves stirring this pot. “And so would you, Paul.”

“Of course. She’s a hot blonde. But there are a lot of those out there.”

Eleanor pauses, weighing everything she knows about me. Feels like she’s reading my thoughts. “It’s okay, Paul. You’re allowed to feel something, you know.” She places a hand on my chest, feeling my pulse. “She’s a cool girl.”

“Who’s married.”

“And that’s stopped you how again?”

I don’t want just a physical relationship with Heather. I almost blurt it out. Instead, I find restraint. Eleanor lets it go. Kind of.

“You know that right now she’s playing this game. But one of these days, one of these dates, she’s going to cross a line. I was hoping it would be with you.”

“Why?”

“Because you’ve got a nice cock.” She winks. “And I think you two are adorable together.”

“Thanks, hotwife matchmaker.”

Eleanor laughs hard enough that she has to cover her mouth. “I like that. We’ll see how good I am this Friday, with Jamie and the ‘hot blonde’.” She says the last with an exaggerated American accent.

“Thought this was all for optics. To fool her husband.”

Eleanor shrugs. “I mean, probably. But there’s always the possibility for more, right?”

Direct Messages

JAMESON: I had a great time last Friday.

MANDY: Watching a man like you shake it to Miley Cyrus always makes for a great time.

JAMESON: It's all in the hips.

MANDY: No comment.

JAMESON: Really? Because other women can't get enough of my hip motions.

MANDY: OMG. You're not a real person.

I send a photo of my upper body, cropped and artistic while still showing off the smooth lines of my pecs and abs.

JAMESON: I've been told that before. But I can assure you, I'm very real.

MANDY: This is the problem with guys like you. You think it's all about looks. Wear a tight shirt, flash a charming smile, and we'll drop our panties.

JAMESON: Then let's go somewhere quieter this Friday. Somewhere to chat. I'll even wear something loose and unflattering.

MANDY: Yes to the drink. No to the loose clothing. At least then I get eye candy out of the night when you turn out to be a shitty conversationalist.

JAMESON: Same requirements for you then, although it's going to be hard to top that dress you wore last Friday.

MANDY: Not as hard as you think.

JAMESON: Show me.

MANDY: That really work with other women on here? You demand photos and get them?

JAMESON: I'm happy to reciprocate.

MANDY: LOL I told you, I'm not into dick pics.

JAMESON: Just shirtless ones. I can do that.

The photo I send is of me posing in the bathroom mirror after a shower, from my neck down and with just a towel wrapped low around my waist.

MANDY: Oh, my!

JAMESON: Your turn.

MANDY: Fine.

Her photo is of her bed, with three different dresses laid out. One is white with black, diagonal stripes. One is yellow. One is leopard print. They all appear to be short.

JAMESON: White and black. But I'll need to see it on you to be sure.

MANDY: Really? I'm surprised you didn't go with red.

JAMESON: I'm classier than that.

MANDY: Really?

JAMESON: Fine, you caught me. The white and black one looks shorter.

MANDY: Oh, it definitely is shorter than this one.

The photo she sends is of her in the leopard one, strapless and tight and short. The shot is over her shoulder as if to emphasize how snug it is on her heart-shaped ass.

JAMESON: That's pretty short.

MANDY: If you went with the yellow one, I could wear stockings...

Next photo is just of her legs, crossed in front of her, wearing a pair of nude-colored, lace-topped thigh highs.

JAMESON: I do love the look.

MANDY: So does my husband. :)

JAMESON: What else would you wear under there?

MANDY: Maybe you'll find out Friday. Maybe not.

JAMESON: You are a tease.

MANDY: I'm worth chasing.

This is followed up by a photo of her own post-shower shot. She wears a towel around her waist and covers her tits with an arm. Other than the arm, it's a mirror of my own teasing shot.

JAMESON: Damn, girl. Drop the arm.

MANDY: Mmm, I don't think so. I'm a tease, remember?

JAMESON: I'll see you Friday, then. In that white and black dress.

MANDY: We'll see.

Mason Coles

Only I don't see her Friday night, and I don't know whether she wears the dress, because she's not meeting up with me. She's meeting up with Eleanor's friend, Jamie, who gets to reap all the benefits of my flirting.

But hey, it's not like I didn't get anything out of it. I've now seen more of my friend than I have a right to see, and the banter—even through DeBauch's clunky system—has been fun as hell.

Not that I'm going to sit around Friday night, torturing myself with what-ifs and hypotheticals. No, instead, I find myself in a hipster bar with the most unlikely of company—Mason Coles.

"To what do I have the honor?" He's a good looking guy and knows that he's got a good looking grin—straight white teeth that set out from his dark skin.

"Can't a guy buy another guy a drink?"

Mason's face tightens up a half-grimace. "Man, you're not hitting on me, are you?"

I chuckle. "You're not my type."

"Naw, you like them blonde."

"More like I need tits."

Mason snorts. "Why am I here?"

“I need you to support Eleanor on the name change.”

“Ah. So this is a political thing.”

I shrug. “Always is.”

He shakes his head. “No, not always. You could be applying to be my wingman. Plenty of tail in here.”

I don’t like this guy, but mostly because he reminds me of myself and how douchey I probably come off. Not that I’m about to change.

I follow his gaze to a trio of women standing by the bar. I recognize their type, although I don’t know any of them—they’re married suburbanites on a girls’ night out. I usually dismiss a crew like this. They’re all flirt, happy to take free drinks and the thrill of a little strange before going back home to their suburban life.

“Waste of time.”

“Quitter talk.”

“More like realist.”

“Don’t be turned off by the rings.” He knocks the bar, calling for another round. The bartender, a burly, tattooed hipster, looks at us witheringly before turning to the taps. “I don’t think they get many black folks in here.”

He picks up a tater tot—because this place refuses to offer normal bar fare—and pops it into his mouth.

“Anyway,” he goes on. “I actually prefer it. The rings, I mean. Did you know that there’s this whole world out there for guys like you and me? They’re called hotwives and cuckolds, and fuck, man, it’s like an all you can eat buffet of pussy.”

“I didn’t know you were a poet, Mason.”

“Go fuck yourself.” Our craft beers arrive. “It’s truly amazing. I’ve got this system worked out now, like I’m a professional bull. Some guys even pay me to seduce their wives, if you’d fucking believe that. Those are my favorites. Especially when the chicks turn out to be real whores in bed.”

“I know about the lifestyle.”

“Course you do. You’re fucking a certain, blond PR exec with an amazing rack.”

“Not fucking her.”

“The fuck’s wrong with you? You’ve been dribbling this ball for way too long, man. Take the shot already.”

As if on cue, my phone buzzes.

[Manhattan]: He’s hot, and he just invited me back to his place. I can’t wait to get his cock in my mouth.

It hits me like a physical blow, and I feel the world go sideways.

“Booty call?” Mason asks. He knocks back his drink.

“No. Friend.” I force myself to calm down. It doesn’t work until I get the follow up text.

[Manhattan]: Oops, that was meant for Joshua. He’s eating this up!

“Everything good?” Mason asks.

“Um, yeah. Just...” I type back the message of encouragement that’s expected of me.

[Me]: Hope you’re having fun too. I say go for it.

Then I darken the phone and slide it back into my pocket. “People are weird.”

“Most definitely. Get this. There’s a guy I’m talking to who wants me to seduce his wife without her knowing. He’s feeding me all this information on how best to do it. Stuff she likes to do. Hobbies and interests and shit.”

“That’s pretty fucked, man,” I say. “You doing that?”

“Hell yeah, I am. Check it.” He pulls out his own phone and brings up a photo of a gorgeous blonde, posing in a lacy red lingerie set—bra, panties, garter belt into nude stockings. She’s glancing right at the camera with a pair of stunning, deep blue eyes. “That’s Jaclyn. And get this. She’s 46. Can you fucking believe that?”

I looked again, and I couldn’t see it. He swiped to another photo, this one of Jaclyn in a small, blue bikini as she looked out onto the beach. Her body was amazing.

“Tits aren’t real, but I’m not one to judge.”

“And she doesn’t know her husband’s talking to you?”

“Not at all. Haven’t started that phase yet. We’re still working out the details, but it’s looking likely to go down during GPC. He’s making some excuse to fly out there for business and is taking her along for an unplanned vacation. We’ll sit together on the plane, and boom. Magic.”

“Man, okay.” I laugh and drink my beer. At least he’s done one thing that I couldn’t—totally gotten my mind off of what Manhattan was up to. “So are

you going to support the rebrand or what?”

“Shouldn’t Mrs. Heller be asking this?”

I don’t trust you around her, I thought. “You want me to beg, man? You really attached to the ‘Dawning’ name?”

“Fine, I’ll throw in.” He glances at the trio of women from earlier, who have already gone through a couple glasses of wine. “But you’re going to back me up with them.”

“I told you, waste of time.”

“So you’ve got nothing to lose but time. Be a sport. Promise it’ll be fun.”

I look at them again, all dressed casually sexy—tight jeans, glittering blouses, makeup and hair done. Drinking wine in a brew pub. They’re all pretty, and back when they were single, I imagine they were all down to fuck. Now, they’re here for guys like us to hit on them so they can laugh about it on the cab ride home, then wake up their husbands for a late night fuck.

My phone buzzes in my pocket. I check it automatically. There are actually a couple waiting messages—one from Elie, the other from Manhattan. I tap Elie’s first because there’s a photo attached.

[Elie]: I think our girl has taken a liking to Jameson. ;-)

There are actually two photos attached—both grainy under the low light. The first is inside some bar, where Manhattan half sits, one leg bent, heel hooked into the stool. She wears the white dress with the diagonal, black stripes, and it’s tiny, barely covering her upper thighs, and low cut enough that her cleavage is on deep display.

The man, Jamie, leans close, one hand resting on the bare skin of her knee. He's whispering something into her ear, and she's smiling at whatever he's saying.

The second photo is outside, a distant shot of two figures embracing. The wisp of blond hair and the white of her dress is unmistakable. She has her right hand tucked beneath Jamie's shaggy head of hair, on the back of his neck, and in her heels, she's tall enough that she doesn't need to look up to kiss him. And fuck, she's kissing him.

The other message is from Manhattan herself, time stamped earlier than the photos—a response to my text.

[Me]: Hope you're having fun too. I say go for it.

[Manhattan]: Maybe I will.

"So we doing this? Or you gonna keep your face buried in that phone?"
Mason's disparaging question sucks me out of the hole I disappeared in.

I look again at the waste of time these women represent. They're laughing with one another. Having a good time.

"Fine, let's do this."

It may be a waste of time, but I'm into the distraction. Besides, the man's got my competitive spirit up. He's going to go in, and he's going to try. And if he is, then I sure as hell am not going to just watch.

I eye the blonde, but already know what Mason thinks is my type. "Dibs on the redhead."

Mason grins. "That's fine. I'll take the other two."



“Mmm... yes...” She’s quiet as I fuck her. “Yeah, it feels... ngha!” Her breath catches. “...so good... mmm, so good.”

I’m over her, my cock sheathed in a condom that’s sheathed in her tight pussy—a pussy that’s probably used to scheduled, once-a-week sex with a husband who’s nothing like me. I’m cut and lean, my chest chiseled and hairless. She keeps touching it, running her fingers along my pecs like she still can’t believe this is real.

“You like my cock?”

“Mmm, I do.”

“You like to get fucked?”

“Yes.” She can barely say it. But she repeats it. “Yes.”

“Good, because I like to fuck.” I don’t say her name because I’m not one hundred percent sure what it is. Sara or Sally or Sofie. It doesn’t matter. She’s hot, a MILF who’s worked hard to maintain her body, and who looks even better naked than she did in those tight jeans.

She wraps her legs around my torso and squeezes. She doesn’t need to say another word. I start to pick up speed, fucking her the way she wants to be fucked but is too shy to ask. I know I’m right when I feel her hands squeeze my biceps and her quiet gasps grow just a little louder.

On the other bed of this hotel room is another scene entirely. Mason Cole has the other two women side-by-side on their hands and knees as he fucks one and fingers the other. The two of them—best friends, we learned, from all the way back in high school—are making out like they’ve been doing it for years rather than for the first time tonight.

It's how this whole crazy night started, after all. Mason strolls up to the group with me at his side, starts flirting. Asks if we can buy them drinks.

"You can, but that's it."

"Yeah?" he asks. "Alright then. We can start there."

I sidle up to the redhead, who's quieter than her friends, and act apologetic. That's my role here, good cop or whatever. She's the flight risk and the one who'll shut us down. She's the DD. She's the reasonable one.

"He's an ass," I tell her. "Mason, man, show a little respect."

It softens her, and intrigues the other two. They get respect all the time at home, maybe. Maybe too much.

"What are we celebrating?" Mason asks when the next round of drinks arrive.

"My birthday," says the brunette, raising her hand and laughing.

"How old do you think she's turning?" the blonde says, laying a trap.

Mason doesn't care. He walks right in like he doesn't give a fuck, and I have to give it up for him. "50."

"Uh!" the brunette whines.

"Just messing. You're... honesty, my guess would be thirty...seven."

The women laugh. She could be 37, but she carries herself like a woman who's experienced raising teenagers.

"Okay, I'll go with that," the birthday girl says.

Even the redhead laughs at that.

Mason looks between his two marks, then glances at me with a this-is-going-well grin. "You all live in the city?"

“Outside of it,” the brunette says. “Actually, Kelly’s just visiting. She’s from Dallas.”

“Howdy, y’all,” the blonde, Kelly, drawls. “I wanted to take my bestie out to celebrate her... 37th in style.”

“It is an important milestone,” Mason agrees. “I’m Mason, and this is my own ‘bestie’, Paul.”

The women introduce each other—Kelly is the brunette, Sara or Sally or Sofie is the redhead. We flirt some more. The clock is ticking. These women need to get home before too late, although Kelly’s actually staying in a hotel just a short cab ride away and they could crash there.

“We have had a lot to drink tonight,” Lacey reasons. “But you two are not invited.”

“That’s no fun.”

“You knew the situation from the start,” Kelly explains. She puts her arms around Lacey, who just laughs at her gregarious friend. “I’m sorry to give you the wrong impression, but we’re not into men.”

Lacey laughs even harder.

The redhead at my side laughs, too, although she shakes her head and shares, “Kelly always gets like this when she’s drinking.”

“Didn’t realize you three were lesbians. I’m cool with that, too.”

“Bet you’d like to watch,” Kelly says, wrapping her arms fully around Lacey’s neck.

“I’m a good watcher.”

Sara-or-Sally-or-Sofie keeps the quiet commentary up. “We’re not, you know.”

“I figured. Those two ever fool around?”

“No. Sorry to disappoint, but we’re just boring housewives blowing off some steam.”

I look down at her, taking her all in. Making sure that she sees me see her in a way that she hasn’t felt from whoever she’s got back home. “I’m not disappointed at all.”



“Harder,” she gasps beneath my rutting body. “Please do me… harder.”

She’s all a whisper, like she’s embarrassed. She knows what she wants, but has spent so many years keeping those desires quiet that she doesn’t know how to express them now.

I’m freeing her of that burden. Sliding my hands under her ass, I take control of her prone body, lifting her to me as I start to fuck her harder. I’m not going to break her. I’m not worried about hurting her. I’m her fantasy and I’m going to make sure she gets all of it.

“Oh, yes,” she cries, louder now. She must feel the cords of my biceps and triceps ripple under her fingertips. She gasps again, squeezing, clutching. She’s close. “Ngh yesss.”

“Come for me.” I squeeze her ass, pulling it against me with each thrust. “Just let go and come for me.”

She nods, eyes shut, feeling it all. Feeling every inch of my strange cock splitting her open. I fuck her harder, our bodies slapping, wet skin-on-skin.

Her cries come faster. More desperate. More guttural.

“Come. Do it. Do it now!”

“Yes! I’m coming. I’m—” The rest is lost in her deep moan, primal, animalistic. I hold out. It’s not time, and I don’t want to waste it in the condom.

I pull free when it becomes too much for her, but I don’t let her recover. As soon as she does, she’ll come to her senses. She’ll flee. I move down between her thighs and bury my face in her trimmed muff.

She moans, spreads her legs wide, rakes her fingers through my hair. I know how to fuck. I also know how to eat pussy, and it has probably been a long time since her husband has done this for her.

“What are you... what are you doing to me?” she gasps, lifting a leg over my shoulder and pressing her heel into the gap between my shoulder blades.

I lap and lick until my jaw hurts, corkscrewing two fingers in and out. She comes again before finally pushing me away and flopping onto her back, totally spent.

On the other bed, Mason is over Lacey, the birthday girl, his black body rippling with each powerful thrust. Lacey is going crazy, screaming and moaning like she was on a porn set.

Kelly is leaning against the backboard, masturbating as she watches her “bestie” get fucked. She’s got a small, tight body like a fitness instructor’s, and curly blond hair that just reaches her chin. Her hands are a blur between her legs, where she fingers herself with one and rubs her clit with the other.

“Oh, God! Oh, yes! Harder! Fuck me hard—AH!” Lacey, apparently, likes a good, hard fucking.

Kelly glances at me, sees me watching her. Sara-or-Sally-or-Sofie would have looked away and blushed. Maybe tried to cover herself. Kelly doesn’t. Kelly crooks her finger in my direction and opens her legs wider. Her pussy is shaved bare, and she’s got a rose on her hip.

I go to her, snapping off my used condom and replacing it with a new all in the time it takes me to move between beds. I’m a badass like that.

“Hey,” I greet. She giggles. We kiss. “You looked lonely.”

“So did you. Looks like you wore Steph out.”

Stephanie. That’s her name. “Your turn,” I say.

“You can try.” She pushes me onto my back. “But it ain’t gonna be easy.” She mounts me, holding my cock high as she lowers herself onto it with a groan. “We’re lesbians, remember?”

“Almost forgot.”

Kelly’s an athletic fuck, reminding me a little of Brandi, although like all women, different than her, too. This one knows what she wants and she’s not afraid to just go for it. She takes my hand and places it against her clit. “Touch me.”

I press with my thumb, and she lights up. I don’t hold back. Kelly doesn’t want me to.

“Jesus, you’ve got a nice, big dick.” The Texas twang only adds to how hot that is to hear.

I grab her hip with my free hand, urging her up, taking control of our cadence. She’s so light. So pliant. I thrust up, engaging my core as our thighs meet. She tosses her hair, grown even kinkier with sweat.

She scoops her small tits up and squeezes them, tweaking her nipples as she crests into her own, loud orgasm. I watch her, watch the beauty of her climax. She grimaces, clenches her teeth. Perspiration beads around her forehead and along the tops of her breasts. She arches back, stretching and bounces and tweaking those nipples until she breaks. It all breaks.

She collapses onto me, heaving and shuddering in the after glow. I hug her, but even that is almost too much.

“That was hot.” It’s Lacey, who’s done with Mason, apparently.

Mason, who's pulling his condom off his softening dick. Mason, who's out of the game, at least for now. My muscles are already sore, from my abs and buttocks all the way up to my biceps. Even my neck is feeling the strain. But I'm a competitive fuck, and there's nothing so rejuvenating as a chance to one-up your chief rival.

I collect Kelly into my arms and lift her, laying her against the pillows at the head of the bed. I spread her legs wide, but unlike with Stephanie, I don't go down on her. I look at the birthday girl, who's pushing her thick, dark hair out of her face.

"Your girlfriend needs to be reminded that she's really into girls," I tell Lacey.

It's a risk, but I watched the two of them kiss. If they've never been with each other, there's at least a curiosity.

"Come here, Lace," Kelly says. "Promise I'll return the favor."

Lacey licks her lips, looks at me, then back at her friend. Kelly nods, smiles. She knows she's about to get what she wants. I wonder how long she's fantasized about this.

"I've never done... that."

"You said that you wanted to try new things," Kelly says. "And I promise, this one's so much fun."

Lacey nods, hesitates one last moment, then crawls over to her friend. She's not quite as lean, but the muscles in her arms and along her back hint at a rigorous gym routine. She's taller, curvier, her full, natural tits swinging beneath her as she crawls over her best friend.

Kelly pulls her into a kiss—this one not for show, not for us, not for anyone but themselves. It's deep, raw, passionate. And mutual. Lacey breaks it off when she feels Kelly's fingers glide across her sex.

"I love you, Lace," Kelly whispers. "And now I want you to eat my pussy."

Lacey nods. She's over her fear. Her friend's kiss has calmed her nerves. She slides down the blonde's body, trailing kisses as she goes. Kelly watches her the whole way, nodding in encouragement and gasping as the brunette hits her sensitive spots.

She hesitates just over Kelly's bald pussy, staring at it like she can't believe she's here. She glances up at her friend when Kelly loses her patience. She reaches down and pushes Lacey's face against her pussy.

"Haaa!" she gasps. "That's so soft..."

I move into place behind Lacey and grasp her hips. She moves onto her knees, spreading them enough for me to enter her from behind. She hums against Kelly's pussy and begins eating her friend in earnest.

"Oh, Lace," Kelly sighs. "That's... that's it. Tongue my clit just... just—like that!"

The sight is glorious. Feels even better. I have both women moaning, one on my cock, the other by extension. "That's it, Lacey. Make her come. Listen to how hot you're making her."

"Uhhh, you feel so good, Lace! Fuck!"

Mason recovers during our daisy chain fuck. He's suddenly standing beside the bed, near Kelly, his cock in hand, and while he's not quite fully erect yet, he's close, and Kelly's going to get him closer.

"Here you go, babe. Suck this."

Kelly turns and swallows the new cock without hesitation. Mason meets my eyes and nods. Told you we could do it, that look says. Grudgingly, I nod.

Kelly can't keep up her BJ. Not as she comes on her friend's mouth and fingers. Mason steps back, letting her ride it out before suggesting a sixty-nine. "You said you'd return the favor."

Lacey no longer hesitates. When I pull out of her, she swings around and straddles her friend's face before going back to work on her pussy. Mason

and I bookend the two women, alternating between Kelly's sex and Lacey's soft mouth, the foursome groaning.

It's unreal. It's over-the-top. It's too much for Stephanie, who finally comes to.

I catch her out of the corner of my eye at first, hastily dressing. She looks freaked out, her eyes as wide as saucers, her whole body shaking as she struggles with her dress.

"Steph, join us," Kelly says from the bottom of our writhing limbs. "Don't go."

"Fuck," Steph hisses under her breath. "I shouldn't be here. I shouldn't have done..."

She looks at the scene on the bed, and I feel a pang of remorse. Kelly and Lacey may have been looking for a good, no-strings-attached time tonight, but Stephanie wasn't. Stephanie will probably go home and confess it all to her husband, begging for forgiveness. Will he forgive her?

She runs her hand through her damp, reddish hair, looks one last time at the four of us, and flees.

I consider, briefly, following her. Telling her it'll be okay. Helping her get through the betrayal that she's just done. If only to absolve me of a little of this guilt.

The moment passes and she'd gone. Mason shrugs, slapping Lacey's ass. "So, birthday girl, tonight's all about new things, huh? Ever had anal sex?"

Comparing Notes

“Spent the last week thinking about this, and I agree with Mrs. Heller. It’s time to rebrand.” Mason’s on the conference call, the lone man of diversity in a sea of old, white faces.

I watch Henry Dawning closest of all, and at last, I see him cave. “I have, too,” he says. “And you’re all right. It’s the right thing to do now. Heather, what do you recommend?”

Manhattan, who’s come into the office for this late afternoon call, leans in. “Well, it’s too late to change in time for GPC, but we can make the announcement then. I’ll have my team put some mood boards together for the top contenders for a new name.”

“We’ll vote Friday,” Eleanor says. No, not just says. Commands.

She’s a different woman than she was. She holds herself differently now. She dresses to show off rather than to blend. Even in this meeting, and even over the video stream, she wears a tailored black suit and a scooping blouse that puts her cleavage on full display.

“Heather, can you have the boards ready by then?”

“Um, sure. Yes, we can get on that right now.”

“Great. See you all then.”

This wasn’t open for discussion. The call ends.

“She’s a tough cookie,” Manhattan says, sitting back.

“Is Friday even possible?”

“Oh, sure. Eleanor’s had us working on the designs for almost a month now. But we can’t let the board know that.”

“Sneaky. Between this and your schemes against your husband, you two are not to be trusted.” The segue feels forced, but it’s all I’ve been able to think about through the call. It’s embarrassing how many times I’ve looked at those photos and read those texts over the weekend. As casually as I can manage, I ask, “How did that go, by the way?”

“Last Friday?” She fidgets with the latch on her laptop. At least I’m not the only one feeling piqued. “It was... educational to say the least.”

“That doesn’t sound sexy.”

“Oh, there was sex alright.” She laughs, then looks around, remembering that we were sitting in a glass-walled conference center in the middle of the office. “Maybe here’s not the best place to talk about this, though.”

“Callahan’s then.”

“Can’t, unless we’re talking really late. Believe it or not, I’ve got a client dinner tonight.”

“Bet Joshua is all conflicted about that.”

“The client’s a woman, although yeah, he still is. Told me I could stay out late if I wanted.”

“There you go. Permission to meet me for a drink. I am the original Jameson, remember?”

My computer starts to chime. An incoming Skype call from Henry Dawning. This is how it’s been of late. He doesn’t even ask if I’m free. He just calls.

“Need to take this,” I apologize, but hold up my hand for her not to leave.

"I saw that you put your name in for the big job," he says.

I glance at Manhattan. I haven't told anyone. I barely even remember doing it myself. "I did."

After siding against Dawning and recommending a brand change that drops his family name, I figure I've got no chance. His smile surprises me. "Wonderful news. Wonderful."

"A good friend of mine told me that sometimes, you've got to take risks for something you're passionate about."

"Your friend's a wise man."

Manhattan and I share a smile.

"Thanks, sir. I'll definitely agree with that."

Manhattan scribbles something down on a piece of paper then slides it over to me. Waving, she leaves.

See you at Callahan's around 9. -H

I shouldn't feel this way, but the elegant, feminine script takes me back to middle school and all the trepidation and anxiety and excitement that came with it.

"I'm sorry, sir, what was that?"

Dawning is talking, and it's time to get back to business.



Callahan's on a Monday evening is pretty dead. A bright-eyed Indian-American woman works the bar. I've seen her before, although never

caught her name. She's talking to an equally attractive redhead.

I settle in a couple stools down. The two women glance at me with admiring smiles I know well before the bartender detaches herself and slides over to me.

"Hey there, pretty," she says to me. I laugh. "Jameson on the rocks?"

"Sounds perfect." I pull out my card and hand it to her. "Buy a round for you and your friend?"

She looks at the redhead. "Katie, he wants to buy us a drink. What do you say?"

Katie, the redhead, looks at me much the way Manhattan always does—amused just enough by my antics to entertain me. Or so I think, right up until she rolls her eyes and shakes her head. "No, I don't think so."

But she's intrigued. The door isn't shut completely on this one, and I'm about to push a little more when Heather walks in. She looks between me and the redhead, quickly assessing the situation.

To Katie, she says, "Is he bothering you? Or should I come back later?"

Katie looks surprised by the turn of events, her brows going up. "He's fine," she says. "But you should tell him he's got a better shot at Nadia here than me."

Nadia, the bartender.

Manhattan swivels to me as she settles in at my side. "Call it women's intuition, but you may want to focus your attention on the pretty bartender."

I chuckle. "Women are so mysterious. I never get how you just know these things."

Manhattan makes a flourish with her fingers before taking the stool beside me. "We are complicated creatures."

She's wearing an off-white scarf with abstract blue splotches that match her dark pantsuit. Sunglasses sit atop her head. She looks cool. I almost groan at my schoolyard crush feeling. She orders a Manhattan from Nadia, who mixes the drink before going back to her friend.

"I think they're talking about us," Manhattan says, sipping her drink.

"They're intrigued. You make a better wingman than most."

"You work with a wingman?" Manhattan looks surprised.

I think about my wild Friday evening. "Sometimes. Interested in the job?"

"Do I get the redhead or the bartender?" She winks. "Speaking of jobs, you didn't tell me you applied for the big one!"

"I thought a lot about what you said."

She nods, and for a few breaths, we share... something. Mutual respect? I don't know. The silence doesn't feel awkward, but it's not comfortable, either.

"So tell me about Friday?" I finally say. "It work?"

She chuckles. "Was wondering how long it would take you to bring that up."

"We can talk about something else if you want."

"You mean like you?" She's messing with me, but I take the bait.

"No. Still about you. Like... what are your thoughts on cilantro?"

"Gross. Tastes like soap."

"Really?"

She shrugs. Asks, "Do you have any pets?"

“Nope. You?”

“A dog. Boston Terrier named Spock.”

“You named him?”

Manhattan laughs. “I’m not sure Joshua has ever seen an episode of Star Trek.”

“You a Trekkie?”

“I mean, not a Trekkie. But I did religiously watch TNG when I was a kid.”

I look at the blonde and just can’t picture it. “Thought you were some big slut.”

“Elegantly put.”

“You know what I’m talking about. You told me!”

She smiles in a way that seems to say, You’re too easy to play. “That was in college, and just after. In high school, huge nerd.”

“Not a cheerleader? Because you seem like the cheerleader type.”

“What, cheerleaders can’t be nerds?”

“Not in my experience.”

“Then you need more experience.”

I chuckle. “That’s not what women usually tell me.”

She laughs. I love making her laugh.

“So now can we talk about Friday night?” I press.

“You’re like Spock with a bone.”

“Bow wow.”

She just rolls her eyes. But she does answer. “I wore the dress.”

I wonder if I should tell her that I know, or keep my little, British spy a secret so that I could piece together a bigger picture.

“I saw a photo.” Whatever’s going on between the two of us, one thing’s always been clear: we don’t hold back and we don’t keep secrets.

“Eleanor.” She doesn’t seem upset. “So you actually know a few things.”

“A few. But why don’t you tell me more.”

“Okay, sure. So leading up to the date, Joshua was on edge, but in a really eager way. I haven’t seen him so worked up since... well, maybe ever. You know he has access to my DeBauch account, so he saw all of our exchanges. He actually picked out the three dresses I sent, and he actually...” She glances away for a moment, one blip in her otherwise smooth demeanor. “...encouraged me to send some of those other pictures.”

“Thanks for that, by the way. Although you didn’t have to be so strategic in your cropping.”

“Oh, I have plenty of photos we tried that were definitely not strategic.” She winks. “Anyway, so yes, he was fired up. I actually tried getting out of wearing that dress because it was so short, but Joshua wasn’t having any of it.”

“Jameson appreciates it.”

“Yes, Jamie certainly did.” Her stare is flat and knowing, like she can read the tickle of envy in me. “He knew the whole setup, of course, but that didn’t stop him from being extra... charming.”

“I saw.”

“What did she send you?”

Rather than telling her, I unlock my phone and show her. She glances at the texts as she does, confirming what I do and don't know.

“So I get to tease both Jamie and Joshua, with no strings attached at all. I let my guard down, which is probably the first error in judgment of the night.”

The hollow space beneath my ribcage starts to fill with something cool yet constricting. “Okay.”

“There's definitely an edge to the night that I guess I completely miss. Whenever I look over at Joshua and meet his eyes, there's this... intensity there. I don't know. It challenged me, I guess. Usually, I make some excuse to the guy and leave, Joshua picks me up, and we go home.” She looks at me meaningfully. “But this time, I pushed it. I told Jamie that I wanted him to take me out of there. We went out to his car, talking, enjoying the night. I knew Joshua would eventually follow, and when he did—”

“You kissed Jamie.”

“Yeah.”

“For show?”

“Mostly, I suppose. But I was also pretty...” She clears her throat. “I mean, I got there before Jamie, so I had a couple drinks already.” She looks at her half-full cocktail and a sardonic chuckle slips free. “I swear I'm not some kind of lush.”

“Well, I am, so you're not going to get any kind of judgment from me.”

Regardless, she pushes her drink away before continuing. “I still can't believe I kissed another man. Like, thinking back on it now, it just doesn't seem like something I would do.” She toys with the stem of the cherry dunked in her Manhattan, staring at it like a flame before glancing over at me. “But that kiss was so tame compared to what happened next.”

It's a statement designed to get a reaction from me, and boy does it. I feel myself pulled to the extremes—hot and cold, jealous and aroused, shocked

and intrigued. I don't know what happened after, and my mind fills the unknown in with the most lurid of details. Just as I'm sure Joshua did.

"What happened next?" I'm proud that my question sounds as casual as it does, and that my voice doesn't crack.

Manhattan looks at me, and really sees me. "You're not jealous, are you?"

I shrug. "Just interested in what my proxy did. That's all."

"And if I told you I went down on your proxy in the car as he drove us to his apartment?"

Okay, I'm definitely feeling jealous. "I'd say you weren't being very safe." She just stares at me, the joke rolling off her. "You did that?"

She cracks a smile. "No. But after the kissing, we went into his car, talked some, then drove off to the Heller's. I texted Joshua on the way something like, 'Don't wait up.' After that, he pinged me over and over, but I ignored them until it was time to go home."

"Evil."

"It's what he asked for."

"So you went to Eleanor and Ron's..."

"Right." She takes a deep breath. I know that kind of breath. Something juicy always follows. "I was still pretty tipsy and definitely horny. We went to Eleanor's carriage house, which I guess is where she brings her guys?" She pauses, looking at me to confirm. I nod. "She has drinks ready. I should sober up. I should probably go home and call the whole thing off..."

She's back in that moment, lost in a memory she doesn't seem completely comfortable with. "Eleanor and Jamie started making out, right in front of me."

"And you didn't leave."

“Not...” It’s then that she sees me. Remembers that I’m there. “Not right away.”

“You watched.”

She bites her lower lip and looks adorable doing it. “I did.”

“Did you join?”

“No.” Then, repeats it as a reaffirmation. “No!”

“But you thought about it?”

She looks at me like she’s trying to understand me. Like she’s wondering why I’m asking these questions at all. I don’t actually know. I’m curious. I’m also feeling the jealousy that Joshua feels, the sense of being left out. When she answers, it’s almost a challenge thrust at me. “I did think about it.”

“Did you just watch? Or did you...?”

She leans in, close enough that only the two of us could hear her whisper. “Are you asking me if I played with myself as the newly elected president of the board deep-throated my date’s pornstar sized dick?”

She is playing me. Even knowing that doesn’t stop the bead of sweat from rolling off my temple. I ignore the tightness in my chest and the prickles across my scalp and force a grin. “So he has a big dick?”

Manhattan pushes back and laughs loudly. “You men. Always comparing.”

“Like you don’t.”

“Oh, he definitely had a bigger dick than mine.” She smirks at me.

“So you watched, didn’t participate, and may or may not have touched yourself as they did it.”

“All correct.”

“Very kinky.”

“Right?!” Manhattan says, brows up. “I can blame the booze, but it wasn’t just that.”

“Maybe the husbands aren’t the only ones who like watching.” I sip my drink. “And Elie’s fun to watch.”

Manhattan covers her face at that. “I still can’t believe I did that.”

“And I can’t believe you didn’t join in. That’s some self-restraint.”

“Anyway, they eventually took things up to the loft and I caught an Uber home. I was so amped up from what I’d just seen that I almost forgot about poor Joshua at home, waiting for me, his imagination going crazy. When I did get home, he was just as keyed up as I was. It was intense, man. For a second, I swear to God I thought he was having a heart attack. I kept telling him how bad I was, because... you know, I was! He saw the kiss. Just assumed that was the beginning of the rest of the evening.”

“In the heat of the moment, it was all good. Then, the next day, like before, things were not so good. He was so jealous, and not in a good, tortured kind of way.” She looks distant. “We got into this huge fight. He stormed out. Didn’t come back until the next day, Paul. I was out of my mind.”

“Wow.”

“He was calmer. I was so worried. I told him that it was all just a game. Told him about Elie and Jamie. I told him what happened when we got back to the Heller’s.” She laughs bitterly. “He didn’t believe that I didn’t actually join until I told him he could call Ronald to confirm... which he did.”

“You know this isn’t healthy, right?”

“I know, right? This is what I’m saying. He can’t handle it. It’s a problem.”

“So that’s it, right?”

Heather frowns. “Well, he thinks my client meeting was really me meeting up with someone, and he told me that I could stay out as late as I want, remember?”

Joshua has a habit, as surely as any alcoholic or smoker. It’s hard to kick. “He know you’re with me?”

“No. I don’t want to pull you into our drama.”

“Think he’ll come hunt me down?” It’s mostly a joke.

Heather laughs. “No. Joshua’s harmless. He’s just... intense.”

“So why do this?”

“The things we do for love, right?”

“A Jaime Lannister quote? Hold on, please tell me Joshua’s not your brother.”

“We’re not that fucked up.” She swirls her Manhattan. “This is just normal fucked up stuff.”

“Okay, but you’re making this all about him. What’s in it for you?”

I expect a quick and witty reply. Instead, she gives it some thought. I look up. Nadia, the bartender is leaning on the bar checking her phone in a way that makes me wonder if she’s listening. Let her listen, if she wants. Having an audience has never stopped me from anything.

As if sensing my eyes on her, she looks up and smiles. Maybe it’s because I’ve got sex on the brain, but I read all kinds of suggestion into that smile.

“Okay, so this is kind of hard for me to admit, but...” I turn all attention back to Manhattan. The bartender is completely forgotten. “It’s fun for me, too. It’s like I get to pretend to be single again, when everything is a possibility.”

She glances at Nadia before continuing. “I know you know what I mean. You’re making eyes with the bartender not just because she’s cute, but because there’s a pretty good chance she’ll invite you back to her place after her shift. I had that once, and yes, I outgrew that and I’m past all that, but who am I kidding? It’s still fun, even if it’s all just a game.”

“But it doesn’t have to be—”

“It does. I know I’ve said this before, but if I wanted to have all this freedom, I never would have gotten married. I got married for a reason.”

“You know it doesn’t need to be that black and white, right?” Surprisingly, it’s the bartender, although this isn’t the type of bartender-ly advice I’ve ever heard.

We both turn to her, momentarily stunned.

“I’m sorry, it’s just that your conversation is... I’m a chronic eavesdropper and busybody.”

“Good qualities for a bartender,” I say. “So please, explain to my friend here why it’s not so black and white.”

“Your husband wants you to have sex with other men.”

“He wants it, but he can’t handle it,” Manhattan corrects.

“It’s hard for a man. Especially at first. But let’s put that on hold for right now. You married because you found this guy... Joshua, right?”

“Wow, you really have been listening to everything.”

Nadia shrugs. “It’s quiet in here, and my friend had to leave. Anyway, you married Joshua because he checked a bunch of boxes you had at the time and maybe you were ready for something more stable. I don’t know. That’s the end of it for most women. Which is totally fine. I have plenty of totally vanilla, totally happy friends in great relationships.

“But you have an opportunity. You’ve got a man who’s not only willing to give you a little of that freedom back, but is also turned on by the idea.”

Manhattan snorts. “Until he thinks about it and gets all moody.”

“Sure. But that’s not the end of the pattern. You said it yourself. The moodiness is just his way of dealing with it. Just like yours is self-denial. You’re holding yourself back because you’ve constructed this false dichotomy—there’s life before the wedding, and life after—when really it’s not so clean cut.”

“My husband got pissed off enough that he left for an entire night.”

“And he came back.”

“Sure, but—”

“And I bet the makeup sex was amazing.”

She glances at me. “That’s kind of a personal question.”

“You just finished telling this guy here how you watched your friend have sex with the man you were on a date with.”

“Okay, fine. Yes, it was great sex. A little rough, but that's exactly what I needed.”

“I bet it was.” Nadia pauses, then shakes her head like she’s clearly seeing the image. “It’ll get easier and easier. The first time’s always the hardest. Trust me, I know.” She holds up her hand, showing her wedding bands. “And I know that none of this is easy, and it gets messy, but you’re already in all of that, and I think that deep down, both of you have made up your minds anyway.”

Again, my witty friend isn’t there with the quick retort. She chews on it, lost in thought.

Nadia looks at me meaningfully, then at Manhattan beside me. She nods. Go for it. This wasn’t all some elaborate setup, was it? I shake my head at

her. She rolls her eyes and looks frustrated.

Heather's phone breaks the quiet. She checks it and laughs.

"He wants to know if he should wait up."

"That's code," Nadia says. "See, he wants it. You want it." She looks at me. "This guy here wants it. So what are you guys waiting for?"

Manhattan actually looks flustered. She looks at me quickly, then just as quickly, back at Nadia. "No, um. Not with him." She forces something that could be a laugh as she looks at me longer. "As much as I'm sure he'd love that, no."

The frustration that Nadia leveled at me is now aimed at both of us.

"And really, I should be going." Manhattan reaches into her purse to pay.

Nadia stops her. "It's on me. You two have been entertaining enough." She leans in. "And I think..." She searches for my name. "Paul here will be even more entertaining once my shift's off. You up for it, Paul?"

It's as much a challenge to Manhattan as a question to me. I'm disappointed when her lips don't purse and she doesn't go green. I really am just a dumb friend to her.

"I'm always game. Call your redheaded friend and we can make it a party."

Nadia's laugh is loud. "Let's not get ahead of yourself, cowboy."

"I'll leave you two." Manhattan stands, shaking her head. "Have fun, kids. And Paul, we're going to have to hit this rebranding pitch hard tomorrow for Friday's presentation. So prepare yourself for some long days."

"Yes, ma'am."

When she's gone, Nadia leans back on the bar and crosses her arms beneath her breasts. "So I actually know the owner of this place."

“Oh, yeah?”

“Ever fucked in the office of a bar before?”

“Can’t say that I have.”

“Then follow me.”

Celebration

The pitch goes well. Smith & Kingsley put together an amazing presentation of all their market research, along with a revamped logo, brand colors, motto. The Memory Project is the runaway winner, not just based on our social media polling, but in the overwhelming opinion of the board.

The work doesn't end there, though. The Global Philanthropy Conference is in just two weeks. Manhattan has already secured me a speaking spot for a plenary session. I'll be joined by Eleanor and we'll roll out the new brand.

"We did it," Eleanor says at the end of that long day. She's there in person, along with Mason and Heather and a few of the senior staff of what will become The Memory Project. "And it's all thanks to this woman and all the hours she's put into selling it."

She gives Heather a big hug.

"You pulled it off, blondie," Mason says, arms crossed and smile wide. "Looks like I owe you that drink."

"Pretty sure I never took you up on that offer."

He spreads his hands, palms up. "I'll honor it anyway."

Manhattan glances at Eleanor. "You're seeing this, right? Rich, powerful man coming on to me?"

Eleanor giggles. "I'll see it if that's what you really want me to see. Or maybe I didn't see anything." She winks, and Manhattan pretends to be scandalized.

Me? Something slippery turns over in my gut that I do my best to ignore.

“You’re right,” she says, eyeing Mason up and down. “There really is not much to see. I’ll see you later, kiddos. I’ve got plans with my husband.”

I laugh. “Burn, man.” That felt good.

Mason lets it roll off with a shrug, but I see the shadow that passes across his brow—his ego swallowing the insult, but not forgetting it.

“I’ll take that drink for her,” Eleanor says.

“Paul, you in? This rich and powerful man is buying.”

I know that Manhattan, gathering her bags, is listening. The night will probably proceed innocently enough—we’ll drink too much in celebration, then each of us will go our separate ways. Then again, the last time I got together with these two—separately—we ended up having some of the wildest sex of my life. I could see things going that way, too.

It’s not just the sex that tempts me. It’s the competition. I hate the idea of Mason fucking Elie without me being there to show her that I can do it better.

But we’re past those things, right?

“Thanks, but I need to get going, too.”

“You’re also hanging out with Joshua?”

Mason makes the clumsy joke, but it’s Elie who watches me closely. She sees all the calculations I’m doing in my head.

“Yup, Josh and I go way back.”

“Kinky, Heather.”

Manhattan laughs. “Oh, you have no idea. Paul, come on. Let’s go.”

When we're out of there, Heather says, "I'm proud of you."

I shrug. "Why? I really do have plans, and they happen to be a whole lot hotter than Mason Coles." It's a lie.

"Ah. She must be hot, because that's some steep competition."

"Don't tell me you're into that asshole."

"Okay, I won't." She winks, looks at her phone. "My ride's here. Have fun, Paul."

"You too. Nice job in there. See you next week."



The photo comes through around one in the morning, a blurry image bathed in a hue of low-light red. A long couch fills most of the frame, curving along a bank of windows, black with night, and on that couch sit a row of beautiful women wearing very tiny dresses. There are men sprinkled throughout, but mostly I see the women.

In the foreground, two, a blonde and a brunette, flirt—the brunette whispering to the blonde as the blonde rests her hand on her friend's knee. Beside them, a man is sandwiched between two more women as they talk. And all the way in the back, their shapes flat and losing contrast in the low quality of the photo, a couple makes out. He has his shirt off, and his hand is very clearly beneath her dress.

[Elie]: My view, right now.

[Me]: Where are you?

[Elie]: Swingers gathering. Mason has some interesting connections.

Interesting indeed. I feel protective of Elie, like a father to his daughter. I brought her into this world, but she is now fully grown, capable of making her own choices.

And her own mistakes.

[Elie]: Want the address? You can still join us.

I'm more tempted than ever. After all, I'm here alone in my apartment, checking out the DeBauch stars that I've built up over the last few months, re-reading the positive reviews. "Jameson's" rank, however that's determined, is pretty high, and even as I check it out, several messages of interest wait for me.

I should open them. I should see if anyone's free, tonight, right now. It's a Friday night, so not completely out of the question.

[Me]: Don't worry about me. I'm good.

My phone buzzes again and for a second, I feel the tickle of annoyance. She needs to stop.

Then I see it's from Manhattan and my heart sings.

[Manhattan]: That bartender is right. He wants me to try again.

[Me]: ?

[Manhattan]: It's only been two weeks and he's pestering me to get back on DeBauch.

[Me]: We can get Jameson out of retirement.

[Manhattan]: No, I think that's played itself out. This time, it's going to be real.

This is punctuated by the emoji with the wide-eyes, unblinking eyes.

[Me]: Go for it. Only one stopping you is you.

[Manhattan]: Am I the only sane person around here?

[Me]: I'll help you vet these guys.

[Manhattan]: Gee, thanks.

[Me]: That's what besties are for.

[Manhattan]: LOL. You probably don't want to know what I did to my last 'bestie'

[Me]: Sounds like I do.

She doesn't respond, no matter how hard I stare at the black, glossy screen. Eventually, though, another message alert slides over my screen.

[Elie]: Game on.

The accompanying photo is of Elie and Mason walking down a long, door lined corridor. She's still wearing her work dress, but it looks sexier now that she's stripped the jacket off. Had her arms always looked so toned?

[Elie]: We're going to the playroom. I'm supposed to tell you that 'this is what you're missing.' Sorry.

Ron's got her phone. I pour myself a glass of whiskey and sit back. At least this'll be entertaining.

[Me]: No need to apologize. Send me all the pictures you want, but I'm still not joining her.

A minute later, his response comes in.

[Elie]: She says, 'We'll see.'

After that, the photos come in a steady stream.

Elie, still clothed, with her hands bound behind her back. Elie, still bound, on her knees, staring up at Mason as he unbuckles his pants. Elie, still bound, still in the work suit I saw her in earlier, her head cradled in Mason's hands and his cock lodged down her throat.

I'm not into this, don't feel the jealousy I know comes with it, but it's hot watching Elie. Like a porn production I didn't know I am into plucked right out of my mind. I'm hard.

The next thing to come in is a video. Ron has shifted, the angle of the camera taking away my view. It's still powerful in a different way. Straight on, I can see just how Mason holds her head, just how he starts to thrust his hips as she bobs in and out, arms bound and helpless.

The mic picks up Elie's slurpy blow job and her gags as she takes him into her throat. He grabs her, uses her face. He fucks his cockhead in and out of her throat as she lets out a wet cack-cack-cack.

But Mason wants more. He lets her catch her breath, just barely. Says, "You still haven't taken it all. Maybe Heather can do better. Hot blonde like that, I bet she's deep-throated a ton of guys."

Heather. They're talking about Heather? It strikes a chord—in both of us. Mine is jealousy. Elie's is competition, and when she goes back to the blowjob, she does it with determination, squaring her shoulders and taking him back into her mouth. Into her throat. Deeper and deeper. She shifts her angles, a sword swallower swallowing a thick, black sword.

“Fuck yeah, baby. Almost there. Almost... there. Mm!” He holds her in place, suffocating her, grinding his pelvis against her lips and nose. She links her fingers and squeezes, seeking resolve, seeking just a second longer.

When he releases her, she pulls back, gasping, sinking onto her heels.

Mason's cock bounces free. Huge. Arcing upward like a fighter jet's contrail, skyward. He pulls her to her feet, slapping her ass and guiding her in the direction of the bed. She looks over her shoulder slyly, glancing at the camera, reminding me of a dirty Calvin Klein model on a bondage shoot.

The video freezes there right on the sly smile. The pictures continue. Beneath the business suit, Eleanor Heller wears a sinful, black lingerie set—her bra padded, her thong tiny, her nude-colored hose topped in lace and clipped into a black garter belt

She strips out of those slowly, too, baring her full, ripe breasts, her heart-shaped ass, her cleanly shaved pussy. Mason gets naked, too, his dark skin taut over hard muscle. Elie admires him. They kiss. They fall into bed with her on top. She strokes his cock again, her hair falling over her in one photo, brushed back in the next—not just for Mason, but for the camera. She knows how to play to it.

Ron frames the pictures perfectly. He's right there, capturing that moment when she presses his cock against her pussy, riding the hard shaft, making him feel her gloriously smooth cunt.

The images come at me like a stuttering, silent movie—a dance of light and dark. Mason's hands jump along Elie's curves, a violist stroking his instrument. She arches over him as his cock drives into her bare gash. Her nails dig into his pecs as she tosses her hair, lost in her orgasm.

And still, the images come. Mason and Elie are joined by others—the playroom apparently open to all. A woman with short blond hair and a large tattoo of angel wings across her back joins them, kissing Elie as Mason fingers her clit-pierced pussy. A man comes next, heavy set and balding. He forces his cock into Elie’s mouth. She shares it with the tattooed woman.

The photo stream slows down, like a video feed that’s trying to buffer. The bodies shift. Elie winds up on the bottom, Mason behind her, the woman over her in a sixty-nine. I recognize the position from last week, when Mason and I interrupted the girls night out.

Ron gets involved, a photo of Elie sucking his dick as the heavy set man fucks her doggy-style. Then a new woman with bronzed skin and black hair eats Eleanor out as Mason sits on her face and plays with her tits.

I check my other accounts. Check Facebook for messages. Check Manhattan’s chat stream. Check Debauch. Nothing.

I fall asleep. The buzz of the Jameson whiskey and the ebb and flow of the texts is too much for me to overcome. The last image I see is of Elie getting plowed from behind as she shoves two fingers into the other woman’s clean shaven pussy.

In my dreams, the scene is the same, only Elie’s face is buried between Heather’s legs. Mason kneels at Heather’s side as she reaches up to encircle his cock, her wedding ring catching the reddish light. Joshua is off to one side, watching the action.

And it’s me behind the lens, holding the camera. Watching it all.

Just Friends

“You never sent me any guys to vet.”

It’s Monday. We’re drinking coffee together and chit-chatting like the friends we’re both pretending to be. Or maybe it’s just me pretending.

Manhattan squints at me through one eye, the morning sun bleeding between buildings and catching in her golden hair. “You were serious about that?”

“I figure I can give a more honest opinion of a guy than either your husband or Eleanor. I feel like they’ve got ulterior motives.”

“What’s Eleanor’s?”

I shrug. “To corrupt you.”

That draws a sharp laugh from Manhattan. “She has no idea then.”

“Now a good time to ask about what happened between you and your last bestie?”

She gives up trying to shield her eyes from the morning sun and seems to remember that she’s got sunglasses perched on her head. “There’s no good time to talk about her.” She slides them down. “So you fuck that bartender?”

“Nadia? Of course.”

“She was hot.” Said like a guy.

“You ever sleep with an Indian chick?”

Manhattan shakes her head. “Closest I got to that part of the world was this hot Iranian girl in my integrated marketing class. Indian guys, though, for sure.”

She’s so casual about it. Is this how I sound? “You should go back. I’m sure Nadia could help you check that box.”

“I’ll add her to my list. First up, though, is Thomas.” We stop at a crosswalk, where she shows me someone on her phone.

He’s a good looking guy, I have to admit. Probably in his late thirties with a slightly receding hairline that he wears well, he looks like a guy with confidence bred from birth and reinforced in the boardroom as much as the squash court. He’s rugged and handsome and has a great smile. And I hate him instantly.

“Looks like an asshole.”

Manhattan chuckles. “You sure you’re unbiased?” She strokes the screen. “I think he looks a little like my husband.” I remain quiet. Too easy. “He wants to get a drink this Friday.”

“And your husband?”

“All for it, of course. He’s already urging me to go buy a new dress.”

That gets me thinking... “Are you teasing him like you did with Jameson?”

“You mean am I sending him semi-risque photos of me in various states of undress?” She knows it gets to me, but I don’t rise to it. “We’ve exchanged a photo or two, but don’t worry, no shirtless shots of him yet.”

It’s weird, being left out of all of that. I don’t love it, and what the hell, I decide to just say it. “It’s weird being on the outside now.”

She pouts for me, but then softens. “Well actually...” We’ve started picking up on each other’s body language like we’ve been together for years. I

know she's being deliberately casual. Interesting. "So this Friday is just drinks, nothing more. Joshua was going to come and watch, but now he can't make it." She's not exactly stammering, but this is probably as close as she'll ever get. "So you could come along..."

I feel her nervous, hopeful, embarrassed plea, like asking a girl out in high school. I do my best to sound casual right back. "Sure. I owe you one after you did that for me with Andy and Brandi."

"Yes you do." I hear her relief, and let it go.



We hold our final board call the Friday before GPC—the same Friday of my chaperone date with Manhattan. Eleanor presides. Manhattan sits to her left and I to her right, and ten other board members lighting up the conference call screen with a mixture of agitation and boredom. In a year, half of them will be gone, and with them, their money. That'll be a problem for another day.

The only other person physically present is Mason Coles, who I haven't seen since last Friday—since Ron Heller sent me photo after photo of him fucking Elie.

The two look professional now. If there's been a fallout, neither show it. "Thank you all, and I'll see you in Las Vegas."

"You pack your bags yet?" Mason asks.

I busy myself packing up my things while keeping an eye on the two. They're not obvious. She doesn't blush and sigh in his presence. I wonder if she even does that anymore.

"Jealous?" Manhattan whispers.

I shake my head, although I keep looking at them. Elie laughs. Mason smiles. They pause in the lobby.

“She’s free to make her own bad decisions—”

Manhattan looks delighted at this revelation. “You are!” she whisper-shouts.

“I’m not.” I need to shut this down. “Seriously. I just...that guy’s only out for himself.”

She nudges me with an elbow and an insufferable smirk. “You should take a look in the mirror sometime.” I hate how cute she is when she crinkles her nose like that. “Mason’s not that bad. And apparently he’s got a gigantic... personality.”

“Elie tell you that?”

“Whisper, whisper,” Mason says. “Elie tell you what, Mrs. Kingsley-Fletcher?”

Manhattan just stares at him flatly, laughs, and shoulders her bag. “See you later, Paul. And the rest of you at the conference.”

She rides the elevator down with Eleanor, leaving me next to a grinning Mason Coles.

““See you later, Paul?” Please tell me that means what I hope it means.”

“Doesn’t. We’re just friends.”

“The fuck, man?” He shakes his head.

I brush him off. “I have a bad feeling about her husband. Jealous type, and doesn’t handle it well.”

“Meh. You can handle it.” He stabs the elevator button. “And if you can’t, maybe I’ll take my shot.”

I hold up my hands. “Never said you couldn’t.”

“A’ight. I’ll see ya around, man. If you’re free tonight, come on by the Heller’s. You know the way.”

Well, there goes that secret.

“You have fun.”

“Oh, I will.”



This may be the first time in recent memory that I’m actually nervous as I get ready to go to a bar. At home, I shower, fix a light meal, and spend too long picking out what to wear. I go with a pair of tailored jeans and a patterned shirt, rolling up the sleeves and leaving enough buttons undone to show my hard-fought gains.

I know PJs, a restaurant on the bottom floor of the Renaissance with its dark wood and brass fixtures. It fits with what’s going on—rich, old-school polish over seedier, more risqué motives.

Manhattan’s already at the bar when I arrive, and she’s already ordered our signature drinks. I take a moment to check her out before she sees me. Dressed in a tight, black dress, she fits right into this place—classy with the hint at something more. It’s also the first time that I really see her the way Thomas will—the way I normally look at women myself. And Heather Kingsley-Fletcher is absolutely stunning.

The black dress is short enough to show off the length of her shapely legs—encased in dark hose and tucked into tall heels. It’s tight on her, too, emphasizing just how flat her stomach is and how narrow her waist is compared to the flare of her hips and her full tits.

Her hair is loose, curled more than I'm used to so that it falls in rich, honeyed waves around her face and shoulders. She tucks a strand of it behind her ear as she turns, searching the entrance. Searching for me. When she finds me, her face lights up, and I feel a pang of excitement roll through me as I return that smile.

I don't feel this way about other women—weak in the knees and the heart. But I'm here as a friend, her chaperone, I remind myself. By the time I reach her, the cloud is gone and the ground is once more solid beneath my feet.

“Buy you a drink?” she asks.

“I really shouldn't,” I say with a grin. “I'm meeting someone.”

“Pff, forget about her. She's nowhere near as fun as I am.”

I slide into the spot beside her and pick up my drink. I glance into the deep V of her dress, before meeting her eyes. “That's probably true.” I need to drop this impromptu roleplay. “So are you nervous?” I ask.

Manhattan takes a deep breath. “Always.”

“Excited?”

“Shaking with it. This is nuts.”

Her phone buzzes. She checks it and laughs.

“Joshua?”

“He keeps texting like crazy. Wanting updates.”

“Doesn't like not being in control.”

“You can say that again. You should have seen the dress he laid out for me to wear. Probably would have been arrested for soliciting.”

“Sexier than the last one?”

“Hard to believe, isn’t it? We compromised with these heels.”

I glance at her stilettos. Ask, “How do you walk in those?”

“A lot of practice.” She sips her cocktail. When the glass comes away from her lips, she’s got that devious smile on again. “He also picked out...everything else I’m wearing.”

“Go on.”

She shakes her head, ignoring the prompt. She smiles to herself. “Joshua likes dressing me up.”

I study her. “You like it, too.”

She shrugs. “This game has many perks.”

“Well, now that I’m here, you can proceed to hook up with this asshole.”

“No offense, Paul, but as much as I enjoy your company, I’m not crossing that line without my husband here.”

“Poor Thomas.”

“Oh, please. You don’t think he’s expecting sex, do you?” Her smile tells me she knows the answer to her question.

“We always expect sex.”

“Men.” I love the eye roll.

“So if I wasn’t here, and Joshua was, then you’d possibly sleep with this guy.”

“Did I say that?”

“You implied it.”

“I’ve learned that anything’s possible. After all, a couple months ago, I thought you were a UPS driver.”

“You just liked the idea of me in a short sleeved brown shirt.”

She snorts.

“Let me get you another drink,” I offer.

She shakes her head, but I’m already putting the order in. “I owe you one, anyway.”

“You’re just trying to get me in trouble.”

Am I? “Maybe.”

Before the banter can continue, she whispers, “He’s here.”

She’s nervous in a way that I’ve never seen her. She wasn’t like this when we first met, and certainly not in any professional setting. But here, waiting on a man she met on a hookup service, she’s short of breath and growing pale.

“Which guy?” I ask, but I know. He’s about my age, or maybe a few years older. White guy, his hairline is receding, but he sports the look well. It goes with the suit he wears—without a tie—and the confident way he enters the room. He has swagger, and I hate him immediately. “Dark hair? Charcoal gray suit?”

“That’s him.” I feel Manhattan look at me, and turn to meet her eyes. “Approve?”

“You know what I think.”

“That no one’s good enough for me?”

“No one is. But...” I glance at the guy, then back at her. Right now, you’re a friend, I tell myself. I tell Manhattan, “He’s not a bad choice.”

She visibly releases her breath. It's weird, seeing this woman like this. Like she's uncertain of herself.

"Relax," I say. "Have some fun."

I pass her the second cocktail, then lean on the bar and pretend that I don't know her. Just in time, too, because Thomas sees her. The game is on.

"Thomas?"

"I am. And you must be Mandy. Very nice to meet you."

"Mandy." It still makes me smile.

"You beat me here," he says. He's got a voice that's somehow soft yet firm. The kind of voice used to people listening. "And you already have a drink."

"I just ordered it," she lies.

"That's too bad, I would have liked to order you one."

"I'm sure you would, but I can take care of myself." That's more like the Manhattan I know. "What will you have?"

He's taken aback, and I smile into my whiskey. He recovers quickly, though. Glancing at the beers on tap, he says, "I'll take the blonde."

I groan.

"Are you referring to the beer, or me?" Manhattan challenges. "One you can have. The other, you'll need to work a little harder for."

If he says, some things are worth it, I'm going to have to intercede.

"Fair enough. Some things are worth it."

I nearly lose it. Instead, "Um, okay." She waves at the bartender and puts the order in. Our eyes meet briefly. I can tell she's doing everything in her power to not laugh.

I wish we came up with some code for when I should step in. Like, she tugs her ear and I pretend to spill a drink on him or something.

When the golden drink comes, he holds it up. “Well, I’m sorry I didn’t get a chance to buy you your first drink.” Or second. “Thank you for buying mine.”

They tap their glasses together and drink to it.

Manhattan isn’t going to let him off the hook just yet. “So tell me, Thomas, do you really like blonde beers? Or was it all a setup for that line?”

He hesitates, already off-balance. She will eat this man alive. “Actually, they’re one of my favorite beers to brew. Unlike so many American beers that are over-the-top, blondes can be more subtle, yet secretly fun.” He glances from his drink to her, quickly adding, “And I swear to God that wasn’t meant to be a line.”

Manhattan, to my surprise, actually laughs. “Well, I can be secretly fun, too.” He doesn’t bite, knowing the game now. “So you brew your own beers?”

“For the last ten years, yeah. More a hobby than anything else.”

She checks him out. She can be lecherous where he can’t. Such a double standard. “You don’t have a beer bod.”

Thomas rubs the distinct lack of a gut. “All paddle boarding.”

Of course this guy fucking paddle boards.

“Oh, I love paddle boarding,” Manhattan says. It’s a reminder of how little I actually know about this woman. “You go down on the Potomac?”

“When I can, but I actually prefer this quieter spot in Reston, on Lake Anne.”

I pull out my phone, officially bored of their small talk and unofficially doing my best to ignore how interested she seems.

A text from Mason awaits—a text with an attached photo that I should not look at, but can't resist.

[Mason]: Tell me you've got something better going on than this.

He sent it about a half hour ago, a photo from his perspective as he rides Elie from behind. I can't see her face, but I recognize her body, her hair, the blurred background of her sex loft.

[Mason]: This one loves sex, man. There's only one person I can think of that you'd give this body up for, and even then, you're fucking crazy.

"I don't show you any attention for ten minutes and you're already looking at porn?" Manhattan is back, and her suitor is gone. "Is that Eleanor and Mason?!"

I flip the phone down before she can actually read the texts.

"What happened to Mr. Paddleboard Homebrewer? Seemed like you two were hitting it off."

She looks delighted, torn between whether to keep teasing me about the explicit photo or my naked jealousy. "He's checking to see if we can get a table in the restaurant."

"So it's a dinner date. Sounds like progress."

"Joshua approves."

"I'm sure he does."

“You don’t?” She winks. This woman is frustrating, but her playfulness tonight is also infectious. “You’ll stay, right?”

“Of course.” Warmth swirls inside me. I’m a part of this, and for right now, that’s good enough.

“So Mason is really fucking the board prez? What the hell is up with this organization?” Her Manhattan, I notice, is empty.

“You’re going to miss us.”

“Yeah, I probably will... right up until the next big scandal breaks.”

Thomas returns before I can respond to that. He gives me a dirty look, misinterpreting the situation. Putting a hand on her back, he says, “They’re setting a table up now.”

“Great!” Manhattan hops off her stool and smiles at me. “Nice meeting you, James.” She leans into Thomas as his arm glides across the valley of her waist.

The man is so smug, so superior. I almost spoil her moment by doing something dumb and macho. I swallow that urge and nod to her. “Pleasure meeting you, Mandy.”

They settle into a table within sight of the bar, Thomas with his back to me, Manhattan in profile. I watch her sharp features as she chats and laughs and listens, watch her bat her long lashes and toss her lush, golden hair. The ache inside of me is real, the jealousy and envy and angst suddenly there the way the flu comes on. It’s insidious. It permeates. I don’t like it at all, and yet when I watch Mrs. Heather Kingsley-Fletcher tip her head back and laugh as she fingers her delicate, golden necklace, I want her more than ever.

This is how Ron feels. This is what Joshua wants. I finally get it. Sort of. And yet—

[Mason]: This is how I handle a husband.

I nearly fall out of my stool as I process the image that arrives with the text—Eleanor on the bed behind a naked Ronald Heller. Eleanor wearing a strap-on. Eleanor very clearly fucking her husband's ass.

Now I've seen a lot of wild things, but this is new. New and crazy. How the hell am I going to look at Ron Heller now and not think of this image?

[Me]: Wow

[Mason]: This bitch will do anything. Check it.

Another it.

I expect another explicit image and am grateful when it's just a text thread between the two of them.

"I already miss your cock."

"My what?"

"Your big BLACK cock."

"It misses you too, baby. Especially that tight asshole of yours, which felt even tighter as you fucked cucky hubby."

Now there's a raunchy image I'm glad that he didn't send—Elie fucking Ron anally with a strap-on as Mason fucked her the same way.

"I still can't believe I did that."

"What til Vegas, babe. You'll be saying that a whole lot more."

I let it all wash over me. Eleanor's not my problem anymore. As I said, she's free to make her own mistakes.

As I think about it, I glance over at Manhattan, who's engrossed in whatever Thomas is telling her. It twists my gut up in knots. That should have been me. Why wasn't it me?

Just as I think it, she glances my way, her smile climbing a fraction higher as our eyes meet. Like she's reassured that I'm there. Like we're here, in this together. She puts a hand on his arm, says something, and excuses herself.

She passes the bar on the way to the ladies room in the back. She doesn't say anything to me. She doesn't brush a hand along my back or do a thing to acknowledge me. But again, our eyes meet and that smile's there and I feel swept up in her.

She breezes by, flipping her hair. That black dress frames her shoulders, her graceful poise only betrayed by the slight, drunken wobble on her stilettos. She's in her element, just as surely as she is in front of a conference hall dressed in a suit.

A moment later, Thomas follows, even more unsteady on his feet than my friend. He pauses as he passes me and sets a hand on my shoulder.

"She's fucking hot, man," he says, glancing in the direction of the rest rooms.

I don't like the way he says it, like he's added to the end: And she's all mine.

I try to keep it cool. Like Eleanor, Manhattan's a grown woman. "First date?"

"Not exactly a date," he says, not quite slurring, but close enough. "I don't think there's going to be much talking after this."

This guy is completely out of touch. I wonder if I ever get like this, and suddenly feel self-conscious. I grimace. Is this how I behave when I'm out with women I meet on DeBauch? Is this my state-of-mind?

"So it's going well?"

"Yeah, man. I've been here before. She doesn't really need to use the ladies' room for what you're thinking."

This is definitely not a line of thinking I've ever followed. With anyone. "What?"

"You know what this bar is notorious for, right?"

I actually do not, which is surprising to me because I should. It's okay. He going to tell me anyway.

"Bathrooms are private, and the sinks are just the right height..."

I blink at him. "You think she's inviting you—"

"Uh huh." He slaps my back, this time latching on and squeezing in a way that's designed to impose his will. "See ya later, buddy."

With that, he heads towards the bathrooms. I watch him as the hackles on the back of my neck rise. Adrenaline channels into my body, heightening this instinct to protect, to rescue.

I settle my tab with the bartender and retrieve my phone just to get my mind off what could be happening. Like, is that what's going on? Did Heather

invite this man to fuck on the restaurant sink?

I've got a text waiting, but from the wrong M.

[Mason]: So plans changed for Vegas. Remember that dude who wanted me to seduce his wife? Can't do that anymore. Want her?

[Mason]: She's your type. Blonde.

Blonde. I glance again towards the back. They still haven't come back. I drain the last of my drink and stand, rocking my head back. The joints in my neck crack. It's probably fine. This is probably what she wants. But I'm also the chaperone, after all.

Time to get my chaperoning on.

My warm buzz cocoons me. Helps steady nerves that I shouldn't be shaky but are. I wonder what I'll see back there. I wonder what I'll walk in on. What if this is really what she wants? What if, despite what she said earlier, she would cross the line without her husband to watch. What if she would because I'm here.

I don't have time to reflect on that possibility and all that it implies. I round the corner into the hallway at the back of the restaurant and there they are. Manhattan has her back against the wall, with Thomas pressed against her. Pinning her. Boxing her in. He's staring down at her as they talk, close and intimate. Manhattan shakes her head. She's got a hand on Thomas's chest, trying to push him away.

She turns her head as he leans in for a kiss. He catches her jaw instead, kissing her still, whispering something that makes her roll her eyes and shake her head some more. She glances down the hall, for help, for witnesses. She sees me, and a smile forms.

Thomas's other hand runs down her hip, finding the hem of her dress. She clearly says, "No," her arm flexing to try and push him off of her.

I take a step forward, the white knight that I didn't know I have emerging from inside of me. Thomas doesn't get it. He's not going to stop. His hand runs up the back of her thigh, pulling her dress up. I see the top of her stocking, black lace. I see the band of her garter belt.

I enter the hall, all the sounds of the bar muffled, drowned out by the pounding of my blood and the huff of each heavy breath I take.

But Manhattan doesn't need me. She says, "I said, 'No'," one last time. Thomas doesn't stop. So she grabs his groping hand and twists, slipping out around him as he yelps in pain. Her body moves, as fluid as water along rocks, using his momentum against him, cranking his arm behind his back. He crashes into the wall, his face hitting the hard surface with a meaty slap.

Somehow, even in her heels, she manages to sweep his legs out from beneath him without going down herself. He hits the floor. She steps forward and presses the point of her stiletto into his hand. "I don't think it's going to work out between us, Thomas."

I'm frozen there, a few yards from the action. My mouth is open. I'm not the only audience member, either. Someone starts clapping. Another whispers, "Did you see that? She's scary." Another: "I want to fuck her so bad."

I concur. I step forward and she comes to me. She's breathing hard, her chest rising and falling as adrenaline burns behind her eyes. When she collapses into my arms, the femme fatale badass drains away, leaving her shivering and overwhelmed. She feels tiny in my arms.

"Want to get out of here?" I say.

She nods. We leave wordlessly, my arm around her, ignoring the strange looks we get.

Finally

I don't even remember how we got there, but suddenly we're at my condo, a few blocks away, and I'm pouring us each a shot of tequila.

Manhattan is sitting on my couch, still shaking. I hand her the glass.

"To one scary chick," I toast.

She laughs, tips her liquor back and drinks like it's water. I do the same, only start coughing as the alcohol burns. I fall onto the sofa beside her.

"I'm sorry I didn't get there earlier."

She puts a hand on my knee, patting it in a way that starts friendly and ends as something more. Slowly, she looks at me through the curtain of golden curls. "I'm glad you came." There's more, but she bites it back and offers only a weak smile. Her hand doesn't leave my knee.

"I'm glad you asked." Without thought, I reach up and brush her hair away, tuck it over her ear. It falls free again and we laugh. Because it's easier to laugh than to acknowledge how good this feels. How right.

"Heather?"

She smiles, like her name off my lips is music. "Hmm?"

I shouldn't do this. She shouldn't be here. I like this woman. A lot. I like being her friend, and she being my confidante. I like talking to her about my weird life as a bull and about work and her dog and all the things in between. I could lose all of that if I do what I so desperately want to do.

Heather doesn't seem to have those fears. She leans in, tilts her head, and kisses me.

Her lips taste like her cocktail, sharp and strong at first, with hints of something sweeter. Something more sensual. The world moves in that kiss. Time folds in on itself as she leans into me and pushes her tongue into my mouth.

I cling to her, feeling the heat of her body beneath the thin dress, her pulse beating fast and strong. Her lips are warm, her kiss hungry. Our tongues dance with the feverish harmony that seems just one moment away from collapse.

I want more. I want to prolong this as long as possible. Heather does, too, straddling my lap as my hand finds the zipper that runs down the back of her dress.

I pull it. She doesn't stop me. She doesn't pull some martial arts moves on me. She helps me out, pulling the dress up over her head. I get the view of the black lingerie that her husband has picked out for her—stockings, thong, lacy push-up bra, the man has taste.

Thoughts of her husband flash by and are gone at the sight of Heather's barely clothed body. She's as slender as her dress suggested, but not too skinny. Not like so many of the girls I date and fuck. This is a woman before me, a woman who could probably get by on her good genes and healthy eating, but chooses not to be content with just that.

We kiss again as she works the buttons of my shirt. She pulls back, her eyes linger on my pecs, her fingers touching the smooth, hairless muscles. Like what you see? I almost quip. I don't, too afraid to break this spell. Too afraid to lose this moment.

She leans down, kisses one of my nipples. I shudder. Looking up at me through her lashes, she says, "Take me to bed, Paul."

Words I've dreamed about. Words I've longed for. Finally. Finally.

Heather rises off of me, treating me to a tantalizing view of her lingerie and the body it barely conceals.

I stand, and once again she plays her fingers along my chest. In her heels, she's nearly as tall as I am. I tuck my hand behind her neck and kiss her softly. She melts against me, and once again the world spins. I'm dizzy.

Pulling away, she slides her hand into mine. She tugs and I follow, a kite on a line, tethered and floating.

A tattoo sits on her tailbone, her girl spot—a small tiara in black ink, like a princess's—half obscured by her thong. This surprises me. Heather feels my eyes and glances back. She explains before I can comment. “Evidence of those younger, dumber days.”

It's small—small enough to hide beneath a modest bikini. But even still... “I think it's hot.”

“Of course you do,” she laughs as we enter my bedroom.

I pull her against me, kissing her shoulder. Cupping her breasts and squeezing them through the padding of her bra. I whisper against her ear. “Everything about you is hot.”

Our lips find one another, clashing, fueled by all the energy that's been building between us for months. I run a hand down her flat stomach. I can feel her abs tighten where I touch. Down further, I push my fingers into her panties, where things are humid and sticky. She's bare, her pussy smooth and free of even a single whisker. I grunt at the discovery, pushing two fingers into her wet and swelling depths.

She reaches behind her, kneading my cock through my pants, humming when she finds how hard I am.

I push her forward, toward the bed. She turns smoothly, grabbing me by the belt and pulling me with her as we fall back on the mattress. We kiss some more as she works at my trousers, kicking them off with her feet. I'm left in my boxer-briefs, tight and unable to fully contain my erection.

I grasp her thong, thumbs hooked in either side. Our eyes meet. This is happening, but we can still stop it. We can still pull out of this nose dive.

She lifts her butt off the bed, granting me permission. I yank them off, then squirm out of my own underwear. Her fingers close around my cock even before I get my boxers all the way off. She takes a sharp breath. “God, you’re so hard.”

I crawl over her, propping myself up on an arm beside her head. She’s smiling. She kisses my bicep. Pulls my cock close, setting it against her pussy.

Our eyes meet again in that moment, our breathing hard, our heartbeats wild, but peace passing between us in that look.

She hooks her free hand behind my neck, fingers tickling the short hair. She gently pulls me into a kiss, passionate and deep and profound. I press forward with my hips, her pussy encircling and swallowing my cock—my entire being—like it was meant to be. I push all the way to the root, until my balls rest against her toned ass and the smooth skin of my pelvis brushes the smoother skin of her sex.

A moan rips through her, disrupting our soulful kiss. I groan. She rocks her head back, face tight with pleasure. That tender moment passes, and then we’re fucking. Hard. She arches her body, wrapping her long legs around me. I feel the silk of her stockings and the sudden pain of her heels digging into my skin. She rakes her nails along my back, urging me on with her cries.

I fuck her harder, squeezing her ass. She licks the outside of my neck, right along the jugular. Right up to my ear. “Don’t hold back. You won’t break me,” she whispers.

I don’t. Better, she fucks me back. A lot of women I’ve been with over the years—hot women, drop dead gorgeous chicks with model-perfect bodies—will just lay there and take it. They’re into it, they cry and moan and take the fucking, but they’re not active participants. Heather is into it.

She pulls my lips back to hers, forcing me into a kiss that we cannot maintain, but try to anyway. Our hunger cannot be slaked. The boundaries of our desire are yet to be discovered.

I pull out of her, grab her by the hips, and flip her onto her stomach. She almost anticipates what I want—because it's what she wants, too. She lifts her ass to me as I slide into her, grabbing her hips, pulling on the straps of her garter like reins. As if anyone could ever control this woman.

Her ass is even more fantastic from this view, a woman's ass, heart-shaped and full enough to bounce when I fuck her. The perfect ass to—

SLAP!

She moans as my first spank lands, but doesn't protest. So I do it again, leaving a red hand print across her tanned cheek.

SPANK!

“Uh, yeah,” she cries out.

“You've been bad, haven't you?”

“I've been having naughty thoughts about other men.”

SLAP!

“How naughty?” I demand.

She doesn't confess at first, and I wonder how much of this is role play. I grab her ass, running my thumb across her tailbone tattoo before brushing it between her ass cheeks. She squirms as I rub her anus.

“Thinking about strange men fucking you?”

“Yes.”

I press my thumb harder against her asshole, sinking the tip of my thumb into her butt. The friend is gone. The man—the bull—has taken control. I'm

not Paul Sharpe in this moment. I'm the guy who fucked a married woman's ass in front of her husband. I'm the guy who makes playthings of wives for their husbands' pleasure. And the blonde before me is now mine.

"Oh my..." Heather is hysterical. Her brain begins to short circuit. I pull my hand away and grab her hips. Start to slam into her, hard and fast. My abs burn. My arms scream.

"Oh, fuck. Oh fuck ohfuck!" Her cries drive me on. Manhattan's cries. Heather's cries. How many nights have I dreamed of hearing them. How long have I had this fantasy? "Oh, oh!"

She screams, burying her face in the mattress as she comes. Reaching between her thighs, she rubs her clit, driving herself to higher, dizzying heights.

We aren't done. I'm not ready to be done, and neither is Heather. I pull free of her again, and she turns on the bed, hungry for more. She takes me into her mouth, swallowing me halfway to the root in one seamless motion. I groan, staring down at her as she stares back up at me, her blue eyes clear and tantalizing.

I look away, because it suddenly feels wrong to see her this way—see my friend with her lips stretched around my cock and her cheeks caving with each suck. Wrong, but so right.

She's stretched out on the bed, her lean body a work of art. She still wears her bra, her garter belt, her heels. I need to see her nude. I don't want to be denied anymore.

But Heather isn't ready to let my cock go. When I try to pull away, she grabs my ass, holding me in place as she takes me into her throat. Her eyes smile up at me as if to say, Impressed?

I am. Not many can do that. She does it without gagging, without pause. She knows what she's doing. She has experience, lived a wild life before her husband. It's that thought that catches me off guard and shoves me over the edge. My balls tighten and my shaft begins to pulse in her throat.

She's ready for me, swallowing my load without hesitation. She smiles around me, her cheeks high, her eyes like blue crescents fringed in dark lashes. I'm done. She is not. Releasing me, she attacks my balls. I groan, too sensitive. Too much.

I pull her up to me, unclasping her bra so I can sweep down and suck on her tits. Her nipples are hard and dark, small on her full breasts. Sensitive, too, judging from the way she moans, the way she runs her fingers through my hair.

She hasn't taken her right hand off my cock, though, and begins to pump it back to life as I maul her breasts. "You like sucking them?" she gasps. "I like you sucking them, too. Don't be gentle—AH!"

I graze my teeth along the caps, nibbling lightly. She sucks in breath, her hand clenching down on my cock, hard enough that I hiss and shove her back. She laughs, falling onto her back, her tits bouncing.

I'm hard enough to fuck her again. I approach, and she's ready for me, opening her legs wide, tempting me with her bald snatch, framed in her garter belt. I sink back into her, but before I can settle back into a hard, missionary pounding, she shifts us until suddenly I'm on my back and she's riding me.

I reach up, grasp her tits, mashing and squeezing them as she bounces on my cock. Her hair is damp, her body dappled in sweat. She grabs a hand and pulls it to her mouth, sucking on my fingers as we fuck.

Our eyes meet, and it's like she's crawled up inside of me. I don't look away this time. I can't. I'm transfixed by those deep pools of blue and the slick feeling of her pussy along my length. She leans into me, her soft breasts pressing against my chest. Our fingers entwine as she holds my arms above my head, pinning me to the mattress.

We make out through the pants and huffs, our hips slowing, losing ourselves in the sex. Suddenly, things are less frantic. Suddenly, we're making love.

I keep looking at her, our gazes locked. I watch the orgasm build on her face, behind her deep eyes, growing with each roll of her hips. Her brow creases. I feel mine do the same. She bites her lower lip. Her eyelids grow heavy. She's close.

I pull a hand free to grab her ass. To urge her to ride me, to fuck me, to let it all go. She does, but rather than push herself to straddle me, she buries her face in my shoulder. Her tits press into me. Our skin touches as much as possible. We become one as we shudder and rut and gasp.

She squeezes my hand, still above our heads. I squeeze her ass. Things get hazy and weak. The moment builds between my ears, a buzz that grows and grows. She shifts, rising over me. A ghost. A vision. Blond hair dark and damp. Tits bouncing before I can collect them in my hands and knead.

Our eyes meet, one last time. I see her. I want her. I want her more than any other woman before. I gasp. Grab at her hips. She knows it's coming. Doesn't pull out. Doesn't deny me. Her eyes glitter, hungry. She drops a hand to her clit, rubbing herself.

Timing it.

Just.

Right.

"Oh, Heather!" I groan. Push up into her. She bites down harder on her lower lip, her face tightening. Her fingers are a blur as she touches herself, as she tries to match my orgasm with one of her own. I try to hold off. One more second. Two more. Then—

"Ohhh!" Her climax comes like a roar, the true lioness that is this woman. She kicks her head to the side, eyes shut tight. She leans back, bowing away to grasp my ankles as she feels me fill her—the first man besides Joshua to come inside of her in years.

I come so much, so hard, my balls hurt even before it's over. I watch her. Memorize her. Memorialize this moment. I touch her stomach, feeling her

muscles flex and shiver. I touch her pussy, slick and so fucking smooth. She shudders. Grabs my hand.

“Too much,” she sighs, crashing down into my arms. I fold her body into mine, hot and damp and out of breath.

“That was...” But I can’t finish. I have no words.

“Yeah,” Heather agrees.

Retreat

We lay in comfortable silence. I don't want to let her go, but know that eventually I have to. "We should have done this sooner," I say, trying to lighten the mood.

Heather laughs, patting my chest and kissing my neck. "I don't know. I think some things work out just the way they should. I mean, if you'd picked me up at the Marriott the very first time we met, do you really think it would have been this good?"

No. Of course not. It would have been fun, but easily forgotten. So much of what made tonight great is that she's not just another blonde. Not anymore. But I don't tell her that. I'm an asshole who can't resist an opening.

"So you're telling me I'm that good?"

She snorts. "Thank you. I almost forgot who I was with."

She pulls away from me. I feel the loss. Feel my mistake. Still, I don't try to fix it. Damage is done, and having a naked woman who looks as good as this one explore my apartment for the first time is distracting. Her heels are gone, but she's still got her garter belt and stockings on, and they frame her bubble butt that's still a little red from where I spanked her. I just watch.

"I'm going to take a shower. It's in here?" She opens the door to my closet, revealing my suits and shirts, neatly hung and organized by color.

She looks back at me, impressed. I point to the other door in the room.

"Right through there," I say, feeling relaxed, one arm behind my head.

She enters, leaving the door open as she peels off the stockings and turns on the water. I'll join her. The temptation to feel her lips on mine again, to feel her hands run over my back, is just too great. But right now, it feels good just lying there, listening to the hiss of the spray and fantasizing.

This could be my life. Our life. A Friday night of fun, followed by a shower, a cuddle. Falling asleep with Heather tucked under my arm, smelling fruity and clean. We wake in the early morning to make love again before going out to grab brunch in the city. After that, the day is open and unplanned, a clean slate ready for us to write our story—together.

I crawl out of bed and join her.

"Skintimate shaving gel," she says, amused. "This for your lady friends, or for yourself?"

I don't answer. I step into the shower. Soap suds run along her body. Her hair is wet and washed, darker now, slicked back along her head. I press my body to hers and seek out her lips.

She's tall enough to kiss me back with only the slightest raise of her head. Her hand finds my shoulder, caressing it. Her amusement falls away, replaced once again by lust. She'll take my mind off of things. She always does.

"You're hard again?"

"Almost," I say. "Could use some more attention."

"You just want to see me on my knees."

It's Heather who sinks to her knees and wraps her fingers around my shaft. It's Heather who smiles up at me as she opens her mouth and slides her lips across my cockhead. This is the dream made real. This is more than another hotwife wearing another man's ring, looking to get fucked.

With her eyes locked solidly onto mine, she flicks the tip of her tongue across my cockhead, swirling along the crown. She knows exactly what

she's doing, almost anticipating my groans, the way I reach out to touch her. She swallows down on me just before I push forward to make her, slows when I get too close, and quickens her pace even before I know that I'm ready.

Heather is really, really good at giving blowjobs, and I consider myself a pretty experienced judge on the matter. It's not just technique, either. It's her enthusiasm. It's the excitement that plays along her face. Or the way she gasps with delight as she pulls off me to stroke me and rub my cock along her cheek.

"Think he's had enough attention yet?" She encircles my glans with her tongue again. I shudder. "Or think he needs a little..." Kiss. "More..." Slurp. "Encouragement?"

She takes me back into her mouth, swallowing deeper and deeper. I'm back in her throat again, her lips brushed the base of my shaft, her tongue tickling my balls. Only this time, she doesn't pull back to breathe. This time, she keeps my cock in her throat, passing it in short strokes along her esophagus. This time, I hear her chokes, her gags, wet and muffled and raunchy. I see tears collect in her eyes—eyes that want this as much as I want her.

I shudder. Barely manage not to come. Only reason I don't is because of the two previous orgasms, and even then, it's a tentative thing. I push her back. She reads me, reads my body language. Knows what's next as she slides up my body, rubbing my cock between her tits. Her nipples drag along me, hard eraser tips that she pushes against my chest as our lips meet again.

Something moves inside of me at that kiss. It's deep and formless and profound. Like a hazy painting of a couple looking out over rolling hills as a fog creeps in. I feel a whole life together as I hold her, kiss her, feel her respond as I respond to her.

I push her, gently, against the shower wall. She lifts her long legs around my waist, her arms around my neck. I grab her ass, lift her, settle her over my cock. We groan, but we don't break the kiss. Not until we have to. Not until it's impossible to keep it going.

She's taller than Elie. Taller than most women I've been with. She should feel heavier. I should feel the strain of holding her up like this as we make love against the wall. But she doesn't. I barely feel her. My muscles sing, encouraged by her moans and cries. "Oh, Paul... Oh... Paul..."

I feel her hands in my hair, stroking the tapered fuzz at the base of my neck. They slide higher, where my hair is longer, raking through the dark and disheveled mop. I bury my face in her neck, kissing a spot I know works on others. Her fingers tighten in my hair. The spot works on Heather, too.

"Fuck!" She barks the obscenity as her climax begins to overwhelm her. I squeeze her buttocks, bouncing her along my length with longer strokes. I use her weight to drive down onto me, strain my arms to lift her up with equal force.

Now I do feel the burn in my arms. I fight it. Sweat mixes with the hissing assault of the shower behind us. I taste the salt as it glides down my face and along my lips. I taste it on Heather's neck, just below her jaw.

I want this to be our special moment. I want to close my eyes and feel that vague fantasy again, where Heather and I actually do find love and a life and a sensation of completeness.

"Fuck me, Paul. I'm... I'm close. So close."

"What do you want?" I demand.

"You."

Her answer catches me by surprise. For a moment, I hear... I hear an echo of my own desires. For something more. For something deeper.

"I want you, Paul!"

I pin her to the wall and thrust in and out of her on the power of my legs alone. She grabs my head, drags my mouth to hers. We kiss and kiss and I'll never get tired of kissing this woman.

She shoves me away, rocking her head back, eyes closed. I see her climax rise in her throat. I kiss her there, feeling the moans beneath my lips.

Her orgasm passes, and I lower her to the shower floor, my cock sliding free. “You’re pretty strong.”

“You could stand to lose a few.”

She shuts her eyes as she shakes her head. I kiss her eyelids, and when she looks at me again, I sense a confession coming. She’s nervous. Her breath comes quick and shallow. I don’t want to hear it, whatever it is. What I want is to live in this bubble for just a few more minutes.

I step out of the shower and grab a towel, drying off. I can feel her eyes on me as she watches from the warmth of the shower.

She lets go of whatever it was, stepping from the shower and taking an offered towel. “I should get going.”

It hurts to hear, even as inevitable as it is. But I can do this. I can be the bull, the fuck buddy, the friend with benefits. I can. It’s worth it. She’s worth it. Better than whatever weird thing we had.

She draws up close to me, her hair damp, her makeup washed away. She’s even more stunning without. “Thanks for being my chaperone.”

“Sorry your date didn’t work out.”

She touches my face and scrunches her nose. “Oh, I’d say it worked out just fine.”

And then we’re kissing again, touching, tugging at our towels on the way back to the bed. I go down on her, gorging myself on a pussy that I almost let slip away. She tastes divine, and sounds even better as I drive her to another orgasm. She has to push me away with her foot before I stop.

I don’t let her recover. We are on borrowed time, and I don’t intend to waste a second of it. Instead, I crawl along her body, enjoying the smell of my

body wash as I kiss her soft skin. Heather, not one to ever be passive, welcomes me with her caresses.

We move like a pair of experienced dancer partners, anticipating and improvising off one another as our bodies once again unite. She takes my cock in hand as she offers me her neck to kiss. I do, smoothing her drying hair along her forehead.

Our lips brush, but we don't kiss. Not yet. I open my eyes to see her staring back up at me—staring into me. Between us, she squeezes my cock, pulling it to her. Those blue eyes soften as she runs it over her smooth mound and down along her even smoother slit.

I have never in my life felt the urge to tell someone that I loved them. I feel it now, and it's breathtaking and frightening and profound. Like watching my own sunrise.

She pulls me into her, and I go, sinking deep, drowning in the pleasure. At last, our lips close that last fraction of an inch. Our kiss is languid, like we're trying to force ourselves to forget what-comes-next. Like we want to believe that this can last forever.

"Oh, Paul..." She sighs. I lace my fingers with hers. "Ohhh... Paul..."

"Heather," I gasp. Her name—her real name—feels forbidden to say, yet good. Like sharing a secret. Like confession. "You feel so good, Heather."

She brushes her heel along the back of my thigh, shifting her body ever so slightly left. It changes my angle into her and we both groan.

Her voice is husky as she asks, "Feel even better?"

I run a hand up her side, tracing each individual rib before palming her breast and thumbing her hard nipple. "Even better."

She actually blushes as I stare down at her, turning away as pink invades those high cheekbones. Again, I feel the urge to say something sugary and sentimental.

Instead, I drive into her harder, giving her the hard fucking that is my role. Planting my hands on either side of her body, I rise up onto a plank as I fuck her. Heather reaches up, touching my face as she undulates beneath me, opening her thighs and welcoming my driving hips.

I lean down and kiss her, but it's too hard to maintain, so we just hold each other like that, faces inches apart, sharing the same heated breath.

“Come, Paul. I... I want to feel your come.”

“Are you close?” Talking is hard, my words laden beneath the weight of this moment.

Heather nods, quickly, tightly, like she's holding everything at bay. “Come, Paul. I need to... I need to feel it—”

I obey. I want to obey. I'm there with her, one last downward thrust and I'm there. My balls ache. My cock throbs and pulses and explodes deep inside of her.

We feel it as one. It's dizzying. It's expansive. I rest my head on hers, shuddering as she shudders with me.

I fold into her, unable to hold myself up, but unwilling to part. When I slip free of her, we both groan at the loss. She rolls into me, cuddling close as I pull a blanket around her. This is the end. This is the moment when she gets up and leaves, going home to her husband, to her life, to reality.

I stroke her hair, silky and bright and fine. I kiss her forehead, and before either of us realize it, we're asleep.

Heather

I wake with a feeling of warmth and belonging. I wake up... complete. I wake smiling. It's the remnants of a dream, and as its hazy edges lose their definition, the panic sets in.

I'm in an unfamiliar bed. A man who is not my husband sleeps at my side, on his back, his chiseled upper body rising and falling in slow and peaceful breaths. I never imagined seeing Paul Sharpe like this—unburdened by the weight of his machismo. Asleep, he doesn't have to be that man. I caught a glimpse of that man last night, when he held me and looked into my eyes and—

No. Can't go there. My own weight returns. I want to cry when it does, but I don't. I will not. I am not that woman, and I will face this head on.

Paul stirs as I crawl out of bed. He half opens his eyes and smiles when he sees me. His voice is thick with sleep. "You're awake."

I want to reach out and touch his smooth face. I want to kiss him again. I want to return to his arms and my dreams and forget the rest of everything. But I cannot. "Go back to sleep," I whisper.

His own dream slips away. He understands what's happening. This is the end. Or maybe it's the beginning? I don't know if that's hope or fear or what. I don't linger.

"Stay," he says, but I know it's just a gesture.

I glance at the clock. It's 3:04. The panic in me rises. I wasn't planning on spending the night. I wasn't planning on doing anything, for that matter.

"I can't," I tell Paul. "I need to go."

And yet I want to stay. I want to return to this man's arms and weather whatever came next with him. I search for my clothes, and remember how tiny the dress is, how shameful it feels to put it all back on in front of another man.

"You going to be okay?" Paul asks.

"Yeah." I tug my black dress on over my head. "It's fine." I wince at how callous that sounds, but this needs to be casual. It can't be more than that. It just can't. "I'm sorry, I just didn't mean to fall asleep."

Paul nods. He gets it. "We had a lot to drink there."

I scoop up my lingerie—the stockings, the garter belt, the thong and bra. All the evidence of a woman I once was and thought to leave in my past forever.

"I'll see you in Las Vegas, Paul."

"Yeah. See you then, Manhattan."

His name for me. It was playful and silly before. It sounds cold and distant now. Which is good. It's fine. It's where the two of us need to be.

"Bye, Jameson."



In the cab heading home, I feel the shame I felt in my early twenties—the less glamorous aspects of a party-first lifestyle. In those early-morning

sober moments, I would look at my reflection in the window of my taxi and curse the woman I saw. You're better than this, I would tell myself. For years since, I thought that I was.

"You stupid girl," I say to myself, anger once again flaring. The cab driver looks back at me. He sees a crazy chick in the back seat. No idle chit chat from this one. I flash him a smile that doesn't help his perception of me.

I stare out the window. It's begun to rain, beads streaking down the windows. Reminds me of the shower. Of water rushing across Paul's shoulders, his back, as he holds me up and fucks me.

I check my phone, re-read the text I sent when I got into this cab.

[Me]: I hope you really wanted this, because I did it.

He still hasn't responded, so I sink back into the seat and think it through. I resisted this for so long—years of knowing Joshua had this fantasy. He gets so jealous. I've seen what happens when he's left out. Just two weeks ago, he walked out on me when he thought I'd crossed the line.

Panic wells up, stifling and hot in this cab. I could lie. I could tell him that nothing happened. Just have to make it a few more weeks, until after GPC. My contract with the Dawning Foundation—now the Memory Project—will end. Just a few more weeks and we can bury this in the past, too.

And yet it didn't need to be this way. If I could have held out just a little longer... if I could have waited until Joshua was there to watch, we could have done this together. As crazy as Eleanor and Ron have it, as much as I don't understand it, I know why it works. They're in it together.

"But you couldn't wait," I mutter. I don't even bother looking at the cab driver. I'm beyond that, deep in my own self-loathing. I chuckle.

I arrive home. My empty home. No warmth. No light. No Joshua waiting for me, waiting to welcome me back into his arms. I don't expect him. He's down in Richmond for the night. Won't be back until the morning.

I could have stayed with Paul longer. We could have woken together, made love in the blossoming dawn light. I could have had a few more hours...

I let myself dwell on those adulterous thoughts for just a minute, for just the amount of time that it takes to step out of the taxi and walk up to my front door. I let them go. I have to. There is no place in my life for that fantasy now.

It's four in the morning, I slept with a man, and my husband hasn't returned a single text. If only he didn't have to be away. If only he had come along to meet Thomas, rather than Paul. If, if, if...

The front lights click on, motion detection. I unlock the front door and take off my heels. Switch on the foyer light.

The shame and guilt and stupidity seem to amplify in the shadows around me, in the photos of me and my husband that sit along the table of our entry hallway. We picked that table out together. We filled this home with furniture. Together. What I've just done—and how I still glow from it—is such a betrayal, fantasy or not.

I hang my coat up in the hall closet. Set my purse beside those family photos. A couple steps toward the stairs, I hear Joshua clear his throat.

"Jesus," I gasp, clutching my chest. My heels clatter to the floor. Joshua is sitting in the living room. In the dark. And he looks...upset. Guilt clutches at my gut. My face flares bright red. "What are you doing home?"

Joshua rises, a shadow. Moonlight glints off the silver in his hair. He holds a glass of liquor at his side, and as he approaches, I can smell it. I resist the urge to step back. He is my husband, after all. He's never laid a finger on me in aggression—unless it's welcomed aggression.

Like Paul. Like how he spanked me. How he took me and rode me and drove a thumb into my ass—

Joshua holds up his other hand, clutching his phone. “Is this true?”

I want to lie. The temptation is real. I could pretend it’s just another game, another test. But no. I can’t. I won’t. Honesty. Communication. We’re in this together, wherever it takes us.

“Yes.”

I see the fury in his face. The pain. The anger. The jealousy. I start to fumble to say more, to apologize or beg for forgiveness. Joshua stops me, reaching out and pulling me into a hard, possessive kiss.

We’ve been here before. The last two times I’ve been out, this is where it led. This time, I need it more than ever. I need to be reminded that I still have Joshua. That I am still his.

He lifts me onto the foyer credenza without breaking the kiss. A picture frame clatters to the floor. Glass shatters. We hardly notice.

I fumble with his pants. He’s so hard, so turned on despite what I’ve done. “I knew you’d do it,” he hisses as I free his cock. “I fucking knew it.”

“Joshua...” I need to tell him everything. I need to confess, and it scares the hell out of me. “Joshua, it was Paul. I... I fucked Paul.”

He opens my legs, exposing me. I’m wearing nothing beneath, and his breath catches me at the discovery. He must smell Paul on me—the smell of another man, the smell of sex, the smell of come. I regret not showering again.

“Was he as good as you were hoping?” Joshua asks. He runs his fingers across my pussy, rubbing my clit as he steps closer. “Was it all that you ever dreamed?”

I gasp as he enters me, as hard as a column of granite. I look up at him. A vein bulges on his forehead, and he’s breathing hard enough to make me

worry. Only it's not worry I feel. It's harsher than that. It's anger.

"You knew."

Even in the haze of the sex, I connect the dots. He never went out of town. He must have been reading my texts—wouldn't be the first time. And if he was, he knew that Jameson was really Paul, and that I'd ask Paul to come along if Joshua couldn't.

Worse, he knew what Paul and I have and that if he just pushed us a little more, in the right circumstance, we'd do what we did.

"That you'd spread your legs wide for Jameson?" He says the words like a slur. He presses on my knee, opening me up. His cock swells at the confrontation. Pressing his face close, he practically snarls. "I had a hunch."

I turn my head away. "Of course you did. Always scheming. Always manipulating."

"You give me too much credit." He's so smug. "I didn't make you get into bed with him tonight. That was all you."

He spits the accusation back at me with a cruelty I've always known he's had, but tried to ignore. It riles me. "Don't forget about the shower. We spent some quality time there, too."

He draws a breath in through his nose, his eyes lighting up. Feeling him surge inside of me, I dig my heel into his back.

"I blew him in the shower, and then he fucked me right up against the wall." I lean in, close enough to kiss. "He's so strong."

"You slut."

"Mmm, I was a slut for him tonight, honey. I don't know how many times he made me come. I'd forgotten how good it feels to blow a new guy. To learn what makes him tick. To feel him swell inside my mouth."

He moves to kiss me, but I deny him, turning away. He grabs my face, turns me to him so he can stare into me with that crazed expression. His normally neatly combed hair is wild, silver and dark strands all over the place. He wants more. He wants more verbal lashes.

“My favorite was the last time, after the shower. He was on top, pounding me with his big, hard cock.”

Joshua’s close. I feel his orgasm coiling tighter and tighter.

“It hit me in all the right spots, baby.”

“Uh, Heather...”

“Want to know where he came?”

His jaw tightens as he realizes where.

“Want to know why I feel so wet?”

“Oh, fuck, Heather—”

“That’s right, Joshua. He came inside me. Bare back. No protection.” I kiss him softly on the lips—feel all that tension inside him. “Just like you’re about to do.”

He rams home, hammering the credenza against the wall and rattling our pictures. He clutches his head against my body as I feel the second man of the night fill me with his hot come. It doesn’t feel like a reclamation. This isn’t a reunion. I do not feel redeemed or welcomed back in the end. Did I ever?

Joshua leans against me, breathing hard enough that I should worry about him. I don’t. If anything, I want to get away. I feel trapped, smothered—beneath him, in our marriage, in my life? I don’t know.

“You actually did it.” It’s almost like he’s talking to himself. “You actually fucking did it.”

This is the turn. It always comes. Now that he's satiated himself and the lust has burned off, this is where he lashes out and runs away. Not this time.

I slide out from under him and tug at the short hem of my dress. I can feel him dripping down my thigh. I feel cheap, and I don't know who to blame—Joshua, Paul, myself? All three of us.

I cross to the room and grab a raincoat from the closet.

"Was Paul in on your scheme?"

A hand on the sweat coated console table, Joshua laughs, cruel and haughty. "And why does that matter? You and I both know he only ever saw you as a stacked blonde."

The comment stings as much as a slap. It hurts because deep down, I worry that he's right. "You're an asshole."

"And you are a cheating whore."

"I thought you wanted this!" I scream.

He lowers his brow. He does that when he thinks he's being cool. "Never said I didn't want a cheating whore. Haven't you been listening? Did I stutter?"

"You know what, Joshua? You're right." I give him a second's worth of satisfaction before continuing. Blood thunders like a revving engine in my ears. "I haven't been listening. Now I am. And you know what I hear? I hear a man desperate to keep control of the situation, no matter the cost. A friend once told me that guys never do the right thing when they face temptation and think they can get away with it, but I never thought that applied to my own husband."

"Heather—"

"You manipulated me. You've been manipulating me. We should have done this together. That's what marriage is all about." I pull the raincoat on and scoop up my heels. He finally sees what I'm doing. That I'm leaving.

“Where do you think you’re going?”

“None of your fucking business.”

I don’t want to cry in front of him. I don’t want to show weakness, but the tears come before I can make it to the door. Incredibly, it’s only now does my husband realize that he’s pushed things too far.

“Heather, wait.”

“You wanted to know if tonight, being with Paul, was everything I ever dreamed?” I pause at the open door. Outside, I can hear the rain. “That’s what gets you off, right? You wanted to transform me into some cock-hungry slut? Well, mission accomplished. It was amazing. Beyond amazing. Tonight gave me a glimpse of what my life could be without you.” I force a cruel smile through my tears. “So thank you for that, Joshua.”

“Heather—”

“No more, Joshua. No. more.”

I slam the door on my way out. I don’t know if I’m talking about tonight, or about these games, or about our marriage. All I know is that I can’t stay here. And that something needs to change.

Acknowledgments

This one's been in the works for so long, there's no way I can thank all the people that I need to thank, so let me hit the highlights.

First, thanks to Kirsten McCurran, who first came up with the title, "Bull's Eye," and then so graciously allowed me to use it for this series.

Thanks to Ben Boswell and Max Sebastian, as always, for reading older drafts and helping me shape the pacing and narrative of not just the series. Thanks for KT Morrison, who inspired the structure of this series (and is just inspirational in general!). Thanks to Arnica Butler, another amazing author, for making up the fake social networking/dating app "DeBauch", which is featured prominently in this series.

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Thanks to my wife, not only for giving me the space to write and publish these books, but also for taking me to romantic comedies at a young and impressionable age, which indirectly inspired so much of this series.

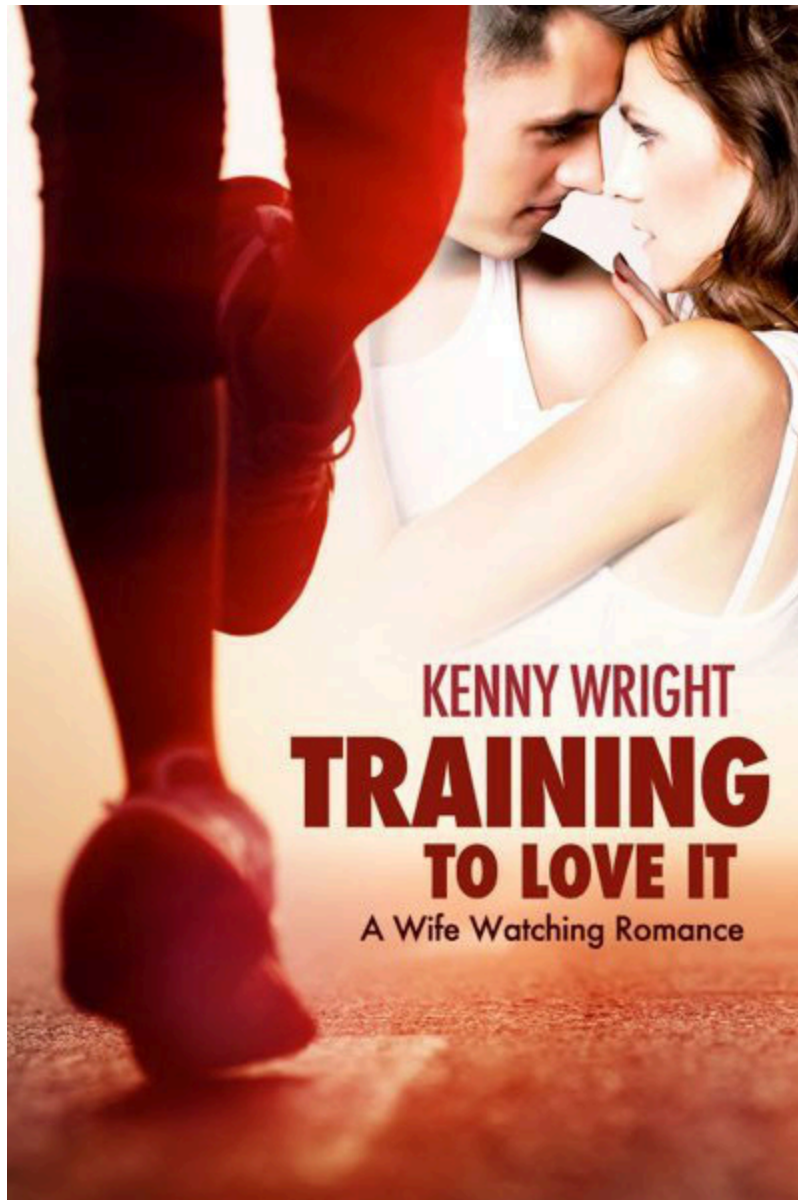
And thanks to you, reader, for not only paid to read, but took the time to read, and if there's one thing I've learned over the years, time can be a much scarcer resource than money.

Cheers!

Also by Kenny Wright

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Training to Love It Series (3 books)



Can a wife-watching fantasy be trained?

When Erin comes home from the gym and lets slip that her new personal trainer is a man, Tom doesn't know how to react. When he overhears Erin admitting that she's attracted to AJ, her trainer, he becomes even more confused. He wants to be supportive, but he feels jealous. He wants to be understanding, but he doesn't even understand his own feelings. Every time

he thinks of Erin with AJ, his heart begins to race. Every time she says his name, his breath catches in his chest.

AJ ends up pushing more than just his wife's physical limits. As Tom watches this newer, stronger, more assertive woman emerge with each training session, he realizes that this other man is pushing the limits of their marriage and their happy life. How far would they go for a fantasy? And whose fantasy is it? And what happens when things go too far?

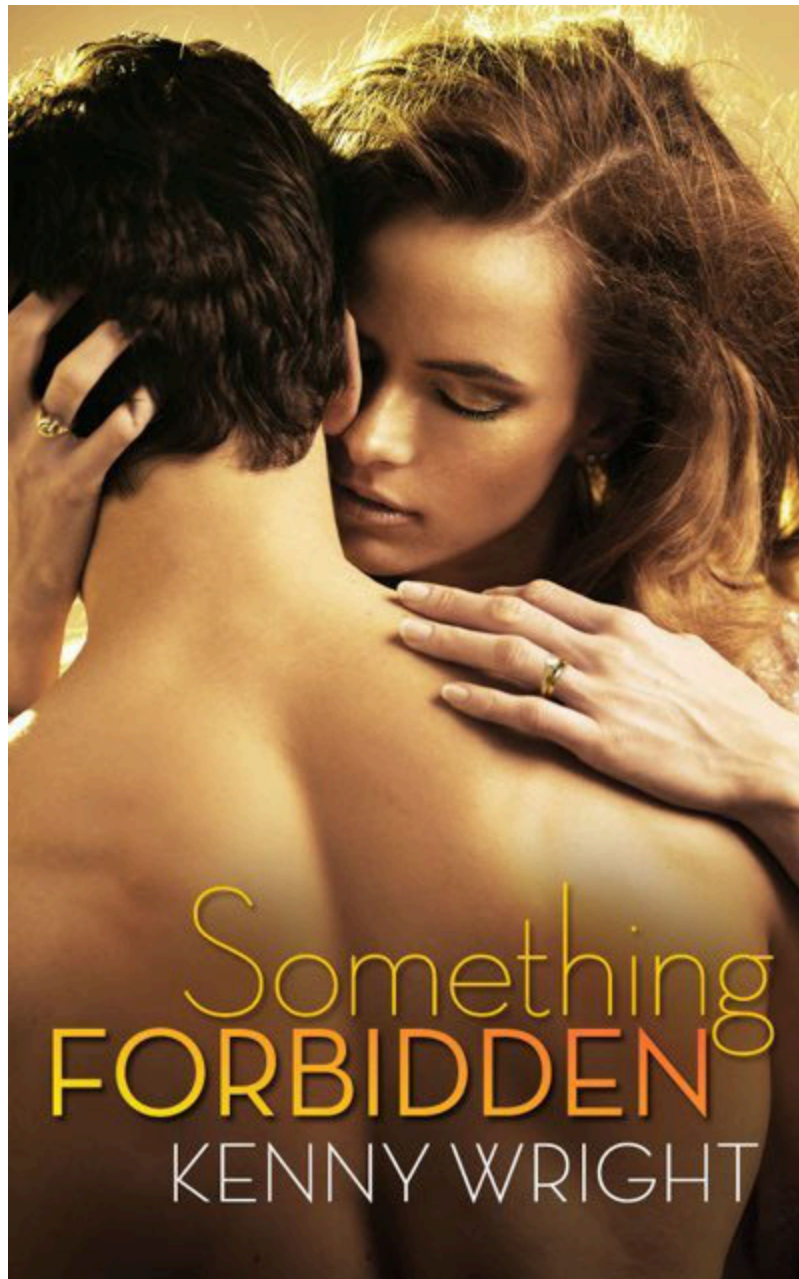
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Training to Love It 3



Forbidden Series (2 books)



Wife-watching. Swinging. Consensual infidelity. These are not concepts that Maxwell Callahan understands, let alone fantasizes about. Max has a great life: husband, father, successful bar owner. He has no plans to shake it up.

And then he witnesses a couple play a dangerous game of pick-up in his bar: the wife gets picked up, the husband watches. A seed takes root and starts to grow. What would it be like to watch his beautiful wife, Katie, in the same situation?

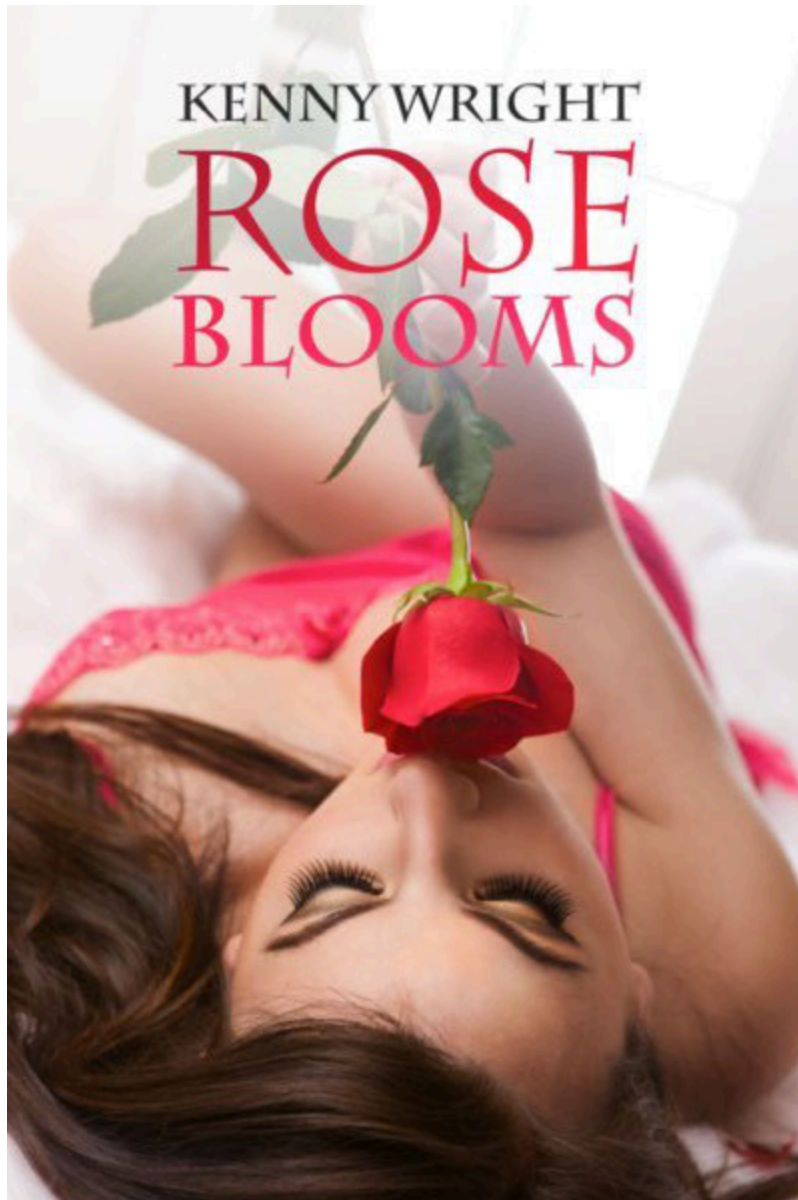
Smart, successful, yet a little conservative, he never thought Katie would entertain such an idea...until she does. This suburban couple is about to take a wild ride as they turn fantasy into reality. Don't miss this marital adventure as Katie and Max try something forbidden.

Something Forbidden

Nothing Forbidden



Rose Blooms



When Rose and Andy Shaw learn that their neighbors have separated, they are shocked. Jordan and Louis always seemed so...normal. Like them. Only their neighbors weren't normal. Louis has a dark fantasy, one that eventually pushes his marriage to the brink. He wants to share his wife, Jordan, beautiful and blonde, with other men.

Andy and Rose are reminded of a time early in their relationship, when their sex life was riskier and things were more exciting. When a new man

enters their lives and starts to push Rose's buttons, they wonder if they are more similar to their neighbors than they want to believe.

Find out what happens when Louis's fantasy rubs off on Andy and Rose discovers that Jordan has secrets of her own. Discover how vibrant this rose blooms.

[Find Rose Blooms online](#)



Annie's Affair



She cheated, and it turned him on.

Travis never thought his wife would cheat on him. Never considered it once in nineteen long years of marriage...until Rick entered their lives.

Travis never thought an affair would turn him on...until he found Annie's diary and started reading about his wife's attraction to her new, younger editor. Confident and attractive, Rick made his intentions clear. He wanted Annie, and she responded. She was tempted. She was attracted. She was conflicted.

Suddenly, Travis is able to see Annie the way Rick does—the way he used to before his perception was dulled by the long years of marriage. Annie is an attractive, smart, fun woman, with an adventurous side ready to be unleashed.

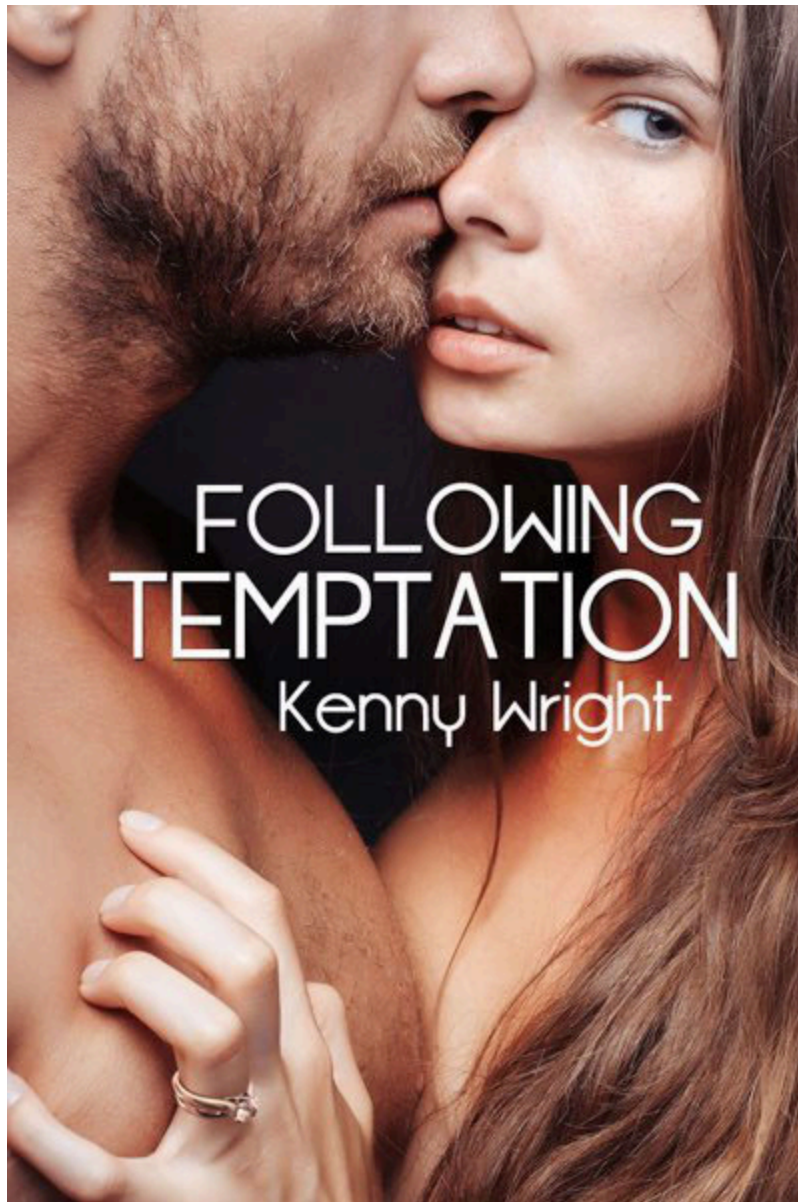
Travis never thought he'd want to watch his wife sleep with another man... until he did. And then it became his obsession.

Annie's Affair follows Travis as he witnesses his wife fall into the arms of another man, and becomes just as complicit in the betrayal as his wife.

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Following Temptation



Temptation waits just around the corner. Follow and see where it leads.

Life is good for Michael and Laura Richards, if a little stale. That is, until Michael follows his neighbor, Dane, to the house of the married Jessica, and watches Dane take full advantage of the voluptuous brunette. Michael shouldn't watch, but he can't stop himself, and the veneer of his sleepy suburb peels away to reveal its naughtiness.

Michael confesses the adventure to his wife, Laura, and the couple embarks on a journey of sexual awakening, following Dane and Jessica into a world that is as uncomfortable as it is irresistible. But there are layers within layers, and when Laura befriends Jessica and learns that not everything is as straightforward as it seems, just how far is she willing to follow her neighbor? Prepare yourself for a tale of voyeurism, naughty neighbors, sexy wives, and illicit temptation.

[Find Following Temptation online](#)

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About the Author

I'm just a guy who writes what I like to read: steamy, explicit erotica that's just crazy enough to be true. I write romantic erotica. I write about characters that I like, and endings that feel natural. I write stories where husbands watch their wives get naughty. I write about MILFs and erotic games and loss of innocence. I believe in a world where men read and appreciate erotica, and hope to contribute to it word by word.

Find me online at www.kennywriter.com, or follow me on Twitter at [@kennywriter](https://twitter.com/kennywriter). I also operate eroticaformen.com, which may or may not look like crap right now.



